

NOT A POTATO

THE BELLY HILL



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Chapter 1 — The World's First Temple, Solved

Naila counted the cones first. There were forty-one orange cones laid in a line along the cordon, and the line wanted to be straight and wasn't, and that was the first wrong thing.

She let it sit. A cordon line bending six degrees off true was nobody's crime. But the line was supposed to read as *control* — the whole production read as control — and the people who'd laid it had no idea it announced the opposite to anyone who counted. The cones were too far apart at the western end, where the camera wouldn't go, and clustered tight at the eastern end, where it would. Forty-one cones. A budget for forty. Someone had grabbed one extra from the van and not bothered to even it out.

"You're doing the cones," Mara said beside her. Not a question. Mara had her camera down at her hip, not up, and she was watching Naila watch.

"They didn't have enough to do it properly," Naila said. "So they did it where it films."

"That's the whole company in one sentence." Mara lifted the camera, then didn't. Lowered it. Let it hang.

They stood at the edge of the world's first temple, which is to say they stood on a low ridge of pale, baked, broken ground above Şanlıurfa, with the dust coming up gold in the slant light and the diesel smell of three generators laid under everything, and below them a man in a linen jacket the colour of clean sand was being filmed telling the truth in a way designed to make a lie.

His name was Anton Reyes. The banner behind him said ANATOLIA HERITAGE TRUST in a serif so restrained it cost money. He had a lavalier mic and a way of pausing before the important words that meant he'd done this a hundred times and the pauses tested clean.

"Eleven and a half thousand years," Reyes was saying, to the lens, to the future, to whoever the Trust's video would land in front of. "Six thousand years before Stonehenge. Built — and I want to be careful here, because this is the part people get wrong — built by *hunter-gatherers*. People with no farming. No pottery. No wheel. No writing." He let that breathe. "And they raised stone pillars five and a half metres tall and carved them with foxes and vultures and *lions*. Before the plough. Before the village."

It was all true. That was the thing Naila kept having to hold. Every fact out of the man's mouth was a real fact, and the radiocarbon under it was good, and the wonder he was rationing out in those tested pauses was an actual wonder she felt in her own sternum even now, with the generators going and the cones lying crooked. Klaus Schmidt had dug here from 1995, German Archaeological Institute, and what he'd pulled out of this hill had bent the spine of the whole story — monuments first, then the village, possibly the monuments *making* the village. She'd read the papers. She'd read the papers twice.

Reyes turned, lovely, toward the enclosures behind him — the famous oval rings, the T-pillars standing in them grey and patient under their shelter roof.

"And the Trust is proud," he said, "to have helped bring this site to the world. Catalogued. Mapped. Secured." The pause. "Solved. The mystery of Göbekli Tepe — answered. A gathering place. A meeting ground. The first place our ancestors came together." Pause. "And safe. In careful hands."

"Liar," Frik said.

He said it quietly, into his own collar, the way he said most of them lately, head ducked, jaw working before and after the word like it was a stone he'd had to spit. He'd been good for almost a minute. Naila had been half-counting that too without meaning to.

"Sorry," he added. "Sorry. Solved. *Solved*." The echo came off him three times, softer each time, his hand pressing flat against his own

thigh. “Not my — that one’s mine but it’s also just *true*, hey.”

“It’s true,” Naila agreed.

“He didn’t lie once and the whole thing’s a lie. How does he *do* that.” Friik blinked hard, twice, a tic riding through, and breathed out long through his nose. “Sorry.”

“Stop saying sorry,” Mara said, easy, not looking at him, eyes on Reyes. “You’re allowed to hate him out loud. We all are, we’re just being quiet about it like cowards.”

Jakobus stood a little apart from the three of them, further along the ridge, where the cordon line bent. He had his shades on against the gold light and a flat cap and the worn tan jacket, and he was not looking at Reyes at all. He was looking at the pillars. He had been looking at the pillars since they’d arrived, in the particular still way he had, the way that made the production assistants who passed him glance twice and then decide he was hired and then decide he wasn’t and then decide not to ask. He’d brought them here. He’d flown them across the world and shipped the Beast across a sea and stood them on this ridge, and now he stood at the edge of it the way he stood at the edge of everything, and let them be the ones looking at the thing.

“He keeps saying *our*,” Naila said.

“Mm?”

“*Our* ancestors. *Helped bring this site to the world. Our hands.*” She watched the man’s clean jacket. “He’s from a private antiquities concern. The dig is a Turkish state project — Taş Tepeler, the whole regional programme, Şanlıurfa museum, the ministry. He keeps standing where the dig is so the *our* lands on the dig. But the sentences are about the Trust.”

Mara made a low sound. “That’s the steal.”

“That’s the steal,” Naila said.

She knew the shape of it because she’d seen the shape of it in the paperwork before they’d seen the man. Jakobus had a way of getting paperwork. The Anatolia Heritage Trust was buying things — access, geophysics data, the *rights to publish* on enclosures that hadn’t been opened yet. And the argument that let them buy it, the argument under the linen jacket, was the word *solved*. If it’s solved, there’s

nothing left to protect. If it's a gathering place, just a meeting ground, mystery answered, then the ninety percent of this hill still under the dirt is a parking lot. You don't fight for a parking lot. You sell the parking lot to the careful hands.

Two hundred pillars, at Göbekli alone. Around twenty enclosures. About one in ten dug. The rest still down there in the dark, holding whatever they held.

"Where's the local," Frik said. "The one Jakobus said. The — Eylül."

Naila scanned. There was a cluster of project people in dust-coloured field clothes standing well back from the Trust's setup, arms folded, not part of it, watching it happen to their site with the specific patience of people who have watched a great many things happen to their site. One of them, a woman maybe a decade older than Naila, dark hair under a faded cap, was not folding her arms. She had a clipboard against her hip and she wasn't watching Reyes. She was watching the *other* thing — the thing the Trust had set up forty metres downslope, inside the eastern cluster of cones, where the camera could swing to it on a track.

"There," Naila said.

The other thing was the reason they'd come.

The Trust had built a set. A flat pad of compacted earth, raked. A length of timber track, two parallel beams. A block of stone the size of a small car — pale limestone, freshly cut, a rough rectangle that wanted, you could see it wanted, to become a T. Around it, eight people in matching grey coveralls with ANATOLIA HERITAGE TRUST stitched on the back, hard hats, gloves, water bottles in a neat row. A drone hovering. A second camera on a tripod. A man with a tablet who was clearly the experimental-archaeology consultant, hired in, hard hat too new.

"They're going to do the easy version," Frik said. "On film. To show it's easy."

"Yes," Naila said.

"Oh, *no*," Frik said, with real feeling, and grinned for the first time all morning. "Oh, this is going to be *kak*."

Naila looked at her watch. It was 9:14.

She started counting.

The consultant — his name carried up the slope as *Devrim*, and he had the harried look of a man who'd told someone the timeline was wrong and been overruled — got his eight people on the ropes by 9:22. That was eight minutes to organise eight people. Naila noted it. The plan, as far as she could read it from above, was sound on paper: drag the block along the lubricated timber track to the upright position, lever it into a prepared socket, raise it with ropes and an A-frame, then carve the relief while it stood. One day. Daylight, modern crew, modern kit, a plan. The Trust's whole pitch.

It was a good plan. That was what nobody filming it understood. E. B. Banning had run the arithmetic for real, in a real journal — seven to fourteen people could move a pillar this size with ropes and a greased track. Not hundreds. Not thousands. Not, Naila thought, with the particular cold pleasure of killing a bad number, an *impossible workforce*. The over-reach people loved — *it would take ten thousand slaves, it's impossible, therefore* — that over-reach was just wrong, and you could feel how wrong it was by watching eight people in coveralls actually try.

Because the plan was sound and they still couldn't do it.

The block came off its blocks and onto the track at 9:31 and immediately did the first thing the plan hadn't accounted for: it twisted. Not much. A few degrees. But a few degrees of an eight-tonne block put the whole load onto one beam, and the beam complained, a long woody groan that carried up the ridge over the generators, and four of the eight let go to grab it, which put the rest of the load onto two people who very sensibly also let go.

"Eight minutes to load," Naila said. "Off the track in under thirty seconds."

"They're laughing," Mara said. She had the camera up now, low, careful, framing not the people but the *block* — the patient stupid weight of the thing. "Down there. They think it's funny."

"It is funny," Frik said. "It's funny until you've got to do it twenty-six more times for a whole enclosure and then a roof and then come back

in spring and do another one.” His hand was tapping his thigh, four-beat, steady, a metronome Naila had come to read as *Frik thinking*, not *Frik struggling*. “Hey. They’ve got the block wrong way up.”

Naila looked. He was right. The grain of the limestone — she squinted — the bedding planes ran the wrong way for the shape they wanted. To carve a T-pillar you wanted the flat broad faces to take the relief, and the way they’d quarried this block, the strongest plane to spall along was exactly where the head of the T had to cantilever out. The first hard knock at the neck of the T and it would shear.

“They don’t know that yet,” she said.

“They’ll know it at lunch,” Frik said, happily.

It took them until 10:40 to get the block to the foot of the socket. An hour and nine minutes, four people, then six, then all eight, then a break, then a different rope configuration that the consultant clearly hadn’t wanted and the director clearly had, because the director wanted the *raising* on camera before the light went flat. The drone kept dropping in close for the hero shot and the rotor wash kept lifting fine pale dust off the raked pad into everyone’s eyes, and at one point a woman in coveralls waved it off with both arms and the drone retreated and you could read, even from the ridge, the small mutiny in her shoulders.

Down among the project people, the woman with the clipboard — Eylül — had drifted closer to the set, and she was watching the block with an expression Naila wanted to photograph and couldn’t, because it wasn’t an expression you could photograph. It wasn’t contempt. The Trust people would have read contempt and felt better. It was closer to the look you’d give a stranger handling your grandmother’s hands roughly while explaining your grandmother to you.

“She knows something we don’t,” Naila said.

“She knows everything we don’t,” Mara said. “We’re the tourists, Nai.”

The raise started at 11:50. The A-frame went up, the ropes went taut, the eight became eleven — they’d pulled in three of the camera grips, which Naila also noted, *eleven now, not eight, the number keeps climbing* — and the block came off the ground at one end, beautifully, a metre, a metre and a half, the crowd of production people making

the involuntary *ooh* a crowd makes, and the drone diving, and Reyes himself drifting down from his banner to be filmed near the triumph.

At a metre and a half the block found out about its own centre of mass.

It didn't fall. Naila wanted to be fair about that, later, when she wrote it up — it didn't crash, nobody was hurt, it was never *dangerous*, exactly, because they had modern rope and modern sense. What it did was worse, for them. It *settled*. It found the place it wanted to be, which was not the place the plan wanted it, and it leaned into the ropes with the whole patient argument of eight tonnes, and the eleven people leaning back against it discovered they were not raising it anymore. They were *holding* it. And you can raise a thing in bursts, with your whole body, in glory. You cannot hold a thing. Holding is just losing slowly with your feet planted.

You could see the exact second they understood. It moved through the eleven of them like a temperature change.

"There it is," Frik said, very softly, and there was no cruelty in it at all now. He'd stopped grinning. "Ag, man. *There it is.*"

Naila had stopped counting the people. She was counting something else now, and her chest had gone quiet and clean the way it did when the numbers lined up, that good cold quiet that other people didn't seem to have a word for and called *cold* when they noticed it on her face.

Because here was the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was the whole thing.

Eleven people. Modern rope. A steel A-frame. A greased timber track they hadn't had to fell, shape, and haul themselves. A pre-dug socket they hadn't had to cut into bedrock with stone tools. Tea and water bottles and a van and lunch coming. Daylight. A plan, on a tablet, written by a consultant with a degree. Every advantage. And they were standing in the dust holding a block they could not finish, and the block had not even been *carved* yet — no fox, no vulture, no arms bending at the elbow, no fingered hands meeting over a belt, none of the part that made it a *person* instead of a stone.

And the people who'd actually done this, who'd done it for real, eleven and a half thousand years ago, had done it without the rope and with-

out the steel and without the metal to cut the stone with and without the village to feed the crew and without — this was the part that went all the way down — *without anyone before them having done it*. No precedent. No tablet. Nobody to copy. They'd done it the way you do a thing the first time anything has ever been done.

It was not impossible. That was what she'd write. She wanted to be exact, because the over-reachers got everything by being inexact, and the surest way to lose an argument to the woo was to overstate it and get caught. Seven to fourteen people. Ropes. A track. It was *possible*. Banning was right and the man on the documentary about the alien stonemasons was wrong, and she would prove that cold, on paper, with her own hands, because that was the work.

It was possible. It just wasn't *easy*. And the Trust had bet the whole site on *easy*.

"Cut it," someone called down on the set. The director. Sharp. "Cut. Cut, cut, *kapatın şunu* — kill the cameras, kill the drone."

The drone hung a second too long.

"Kill it."

The drone retreated. The tripod camera swung away, deliberately, toward the enclosures, toward the safe finished famous standing pillars, so that whatever the edit was it would not have this in it. And the block stayed up there at its tired angle in the white noon, held by eleven people who could not put it down and could not raise it, with Anton Reyes standing in his clean linen at the edge of the raked pad with his hand half-lifted toward a triumph that wasn't going to arrive, and the awful thing, the thing Naila found she couldn't look away from, was that his face wasn't a villain's face. It was the face of a man watching his good intentions fail in front of the people he'd promised. He believed it. That was the part nobody warned you about. He genuinely thought the careful hands were his.

Up on the ridge nobody said anything for a moment.

Then Frik laughed — one short bark, surprised out of him, more than half horror in it. "They just showed everybody," he said. "On film. They set up a camera to prove it's solved and they just — they showed *everybody* it isn't."

“They cut the camera,” Mara said.

“They cut *that* camera,” Naila said.

Because there were other cameras. There were the project people’s phones, half of them up. There was Mara, who had not been told to cut anything and who had, Naila saw, taken exactly one frame the whole morning — not of the failure, not of the eleven sweating people, not the cheap shot — but of the *block itself*, off the ground at its tired angle, alone, the patient impossible-not-impossible weight of it filling the frame with the cordon’s crooked cone-line just visible behind, and nothing in it that would shame a single person who’d pulled on those ropes.

“Ask first,” Mara said, to herself, the way she did, and lowered the camera. “Going to ask her if I can use even that.”

Down the slope, Eylül Demir turned away from the set. She’d seen enough. She walked back up toward the project cluster, and her path took her along the bent part of the cordon, near where Jakobus stood, and Naila watched the two of them pass within a few feet of each other without speaking — the woman with the clipboard and the still man in the shades — and watched Eylül glance at him once, the way everyone glanced at him once, and then keep walking, because she had a hill to protect and he was just another stranger on it, for now.

Jakobus took off his shades. He looked up the slope at the three of them, and he tipped his head a few degrees toward the standing block — the failed, held, un-carved block — and then toward the finished pillars in their shelter, the real ones, the ones with the arms bending at the elbow and the fingered hands and the fox cradled at the belt.

“What’s it *for*,” he said. Not loud. He didn’t repeat it. He put the shades back on and went back to watching the hill, and left the question lying there on the ridge for them to pick up or not.

Naila looked at her watch. 12:03.

She had the start time. She had the load-out, the twist, the wrong-grain block, the climbing headcount, the held angle. She had a notebook full of a thing the Trust would spend real money pretending hadn’t happened. She had Banning’s number, seven to fourteen, the number that killed the *impossible*, the number that was on her side.

And underneath it, where the clean cold quiet usually closed over and let her rest, something would not close.

It wasn't the weight. The weight she could do. The weight was *possible* and she would prove it.

It was the order of it. Foragers. Before the pots. Before the seed went in the ground.

She'd carry that down the hill, and it would keep her up that night in the room in Urfa with the call to prayer coming over the rooftops, and in the morning she'd open the file and start with the part she could win — the workforce, the ropes, the lubricated track — and find, the way you find a stone you can't lift in a field you thought you'd cleared, that the part she could win wasn't the part that mattered.

Chapter 2 — Seven to Fourteen

The room in Urfa had a desk that wobbled on one short leg, and Naila had spent four minutes of the previous night working out that a folded coaster of cardboard from the kettle tray brought it level, and now it did not wobble, and she did not have to think about it again. That was the rule. You solved a thing once, correctly, and then it stayed solved and got out of the way so the real thing could come forward.

The desk had stayed solved.

The hill had not.

She opened the file at 6:40 in the grey before the muezzin, before the bazaar two streets down began its diesel-and-shutter clatter of waking, and she started where you always start, which is with the part you can win.

The part she could win was the weight.

She wrote the number at the top of a clean page, in pencil, because pencil was reversible and pen was a claim.

8-10 t.

Eight to ten tonnes. Pillar 18, the central one in Enclosure D, the one with the arms. The relief arms bending at the elbow, the long fingers reaching across the belly to meet over the belt, the fox-pelt loincloth, the small fox cradled at the hip. Five and a half metres of limestone standing up out of the bedrock floor. Carved soft — limestone *was* soft, that was a fact people forgot when they wanted it to be a miracle — but five and a half metres of it, free-standing, balanced on a socket

cut into living rock, and the twin of it two metres away, and not one of them fallen in eleven and a half thousand years, which meant whoever set them knew exactly what they were doing with a footing.

She drew the pillar in profile. She was not a good draughtsman and the drawing was bad, a thick T, and she put the number beside it and began to take the impossible apart.

There was a man called E. B. Banning. He was real, he had a real argument, and the argument was this: you do not need a lost civilisation to stand a stone up. You need rope, a track, lubricant, and people. Banning had run the figures on what it actually took, and the number that came out the bottom — the number Naila had carried down the hill yesterday like a warm stone in a pocket — was *seven to fourteen*.

Seven to fourteen people.

She wrote it. **7-14.**

Then she did what she did, which was to refuse to let a number be a slogan. She made it earn its place.

Coefficient of friction for stone dragged across stone, dry: roughly point-six. Murder. Nobody drags ten tonnes across dry stone; your seven-to-fourteen die of it. So you don't drag dry. You lay a track — timber sleepers, the Neolithic had timber, they had the whole oak-and-pistachio woodland of the plain before they ate it back — and you wet it, or you grease it with animal fat, of which a community that hunted aurochs and gazelle by the hundred had a frankly stupid surplus. Wet timber on timber, you're down near point-two. Fat, lower. Now the ten tonnes that needed an army needs a load you can write down: the pull is the weight times the coefficient, so two tonnes of pull, give or take, spread across a rope long enough to put fourteen pairs of hands on.

Fourteen people pulling against two tonnes of resistance. A hundred and forty-odd kilos each. That was a hard morning. That was not a mystery. That was *farm work*, or it would have been, except there was no farm yet, and she was not going to think about that part, not yet, that was the other page.

She built the rest of it the same way. The lever to break the pillar off the bedrock floor of the quarry — there was a quarry, you could walk to it, there was an unfinished pillar still lying in it, cracked, abandoned,

a forty-five-tonne monster they'd started and never freed, which told you they pushed their luck and sometimes their luck said no, which is exactly what people do and exactly what gods don't. The cradle of timber to carry it on its back. The earthen ramp to bring the butt-end to the socket. The shear-legs, or the simple gin, to walk the top up off the ground while the base bit into the cut — there were a dozen ways and the Neolithic could have known any of them, and you only needed *one* to work *once*.

She killed it. She killed *impossible* dead, cold, on the page, in pencil, before the call to prayer.

The first thread of it came over the rooftops then — one minaret, then a second answering it a beat behind, the two of them out of phase, and she sat with the pencil down and let it move through the room and not catch on her, because sound that arrived on a schedule was a thing she could hold; it was sound with no warning that took the floor out. The unmeasured city was the problem. The bazaar was the problem. The call to prayer was on a clock. She breathed on its clock and it passed.

When it was gone she picked the pencil back up and she had, on the page, a complete and honest answer to the question the Trust was paying a man named Devrim to ask wrong on camera.

Could a small band of foragers raise these stones with no machines?

Yes. Astonishingly, gruellingly, cleverly — yes. Seven to fourteen. Write it on the wall of the visitor centre. It is not a miracle. It is people, being people, very very good at being people.

She underlined **7-14** twice and felt the clean cold quiet begin to close over the way it was supposed to, the way it had closed over a thousand claims in fifteen years of work, the Bosnian pyramids and the Yonaguni monument and the man in Ohio with the magnet and the conviction — the quiet of a thing flattened, made level, a desk with a coaster under its short leg, solved and out of the way.

And it would not close.

She sat very still and located the snag, because a snag you could not name was the worst kind and a snag you could name was just a problem.

She had answered *can it be done*.

She had not touched *when*.

She turned the page.

Mara found her there at half-seven, because Mara woke at dawn the way the formerly-shelled wake at dawn — not rested, just *present*, eyes open before the body agreed to it. She'd heard the prayer too, from the next room, lying on top of the made bed in yesterday's clothes because some nights the act of getting under a blanket in a strange room was more vulnerability than she had to spend.

She came in with two glasses of tea from the urn in the lobby, the small tulip glasses, amber and too hot to hold so you held them by the rim, and she set one by Naila's bad drawing without being asked and without saying *here* and without making it a thing, which was its own small discipline.

"You've been up," Mara said.

"The desk doesn't wobble anymore." Naila didn't look up. "There was a short leg."

"Course there was." Mara pulled the other chair around and sat. She did not lift the camera that was on its strap across her body even now, even here, even with one friend in a hotel room — she had it, she always had it, but she had learned in the last year to notice the want before she obeyed it. The light coming through the thin curtain was doing something to the side of Naila's face, the focus on it, the absolute address of her whole attention to a piece of paper, and a year ago Mara would have had the frame before she'd decided to. *Pattern-reader at dawn*. It would have been a good photograph. It would have been a photograph *of* her, a thing taken, and Naila hadn't said she could.

She drank her tea instead.

"It's astonishing without being impossible," Naila said, to the page. "The weight. The workforce. I can prove it. I did prove it. Seven to fourteen." She tapped the number. "Devrim is going to stand on that hill with eight men and a hydraulic something and say see *how easy*, and he'll be wrong about the easy and right about the possible, and

the Trust will use the *possible* to say *solved*, and use the *solved* to say *nothing left to protect*. That's the move. That's the whole move."

"And you can stop it."

"No." Naila finally looked up, and her face did a thing Mara had learned to read as distress, which was that it went *more* still, not less. "That's what I can't make people understand. Proving the weight is *their* argument. If I prove it's possible, I'm helping them. The weight was never the mystery." She put her finger on the second page, the page she'd turned to, where she'd written one word and nothing else.

The word was **ORDER**.

She tried to explain it to Frik over breakfast, in the courtyard, under the grapevine that was bare this time of year, with the proprietor's grandfather watching them from a plastic chair with the frank curiosity of a man who has watched everything and is not going to stop now.

She tried to explain it because Frik listened the way nobody else did — not patiently, he had no patience, his foot was going under the table in a fast even rhythm and his head pulled left twice while she talked, hard, a snap, and then settled — but *completely*, no part of him pretending to a politeness he didn't feel, which meant when he heard you he'd *heard* you, all the way down.

"It's the order," she said. "The sequence. Everyone fixes on the weight because the weight is something you can feel in your body. Ten tonnes. You can imagine your back under it. So that's where the wonder goes." She laid bread on the table, a flat round, and tore it. "Watch. This is the order we were taught. This is the staircase of us." She put the first piece down. "You settle. You stop walking around. You plant seeds because you've noticed they grow." Second piece, beside it. "You get a surplus, because farming gives you more than you eat that day." Third. "Surplus means some people don't have to find food, so they can do other things — they can be priests, soldiers, kings." Fourth. "*Then* — only then, at the top, when you've got a town and a granary and a boss — *then* you can build something big, because now you've got the spare hands and the spare grain to feed them while they build."

She had four pieces of bread in a line.

“Religion at the top of the stairs,” she said. “Monuments at the very top. The reward you earn for becoming complicated. That’s the order. That’s what every textbook I read at sixteen said. You farm, you settle, you get rich, you get organised, and *at the end of all that* you get a temple.”

Frik had gone still in the way that meant he was about to say a true thing and couldn’t stop it, his jaw working, and Naila waited for it because his true things were useful.

“It’s upside down,” he said. The words came out a little too loud and a little too fast and the grandfather in the plastic chair glanced over, mild. Frik’s hand jerked. “Sorry. *Sorry*. — It’s upside down. You’ve got the temple at the top and the place is the *temple* at the *bottom*.”

“Yes,” Naila said. She picked up the *fourth* piece of bread — the monument, the top of the stairs — and she put it down at the *front*. Before the first piece. Before the settling. Before the seed.

“That’s Göbekli Tepe,” she said. “That’s the radiocarbon. Not a guess. Charcoal in the fill, run in a lab, run again, by people whose whole careers would be made by finding it *wrong* and who found it right. The enclosures go down to about nine and a half thousand years before the common era. Eleven and a half thousand years ago. And the people who carved Pillar 18 — the arms, the fingers, the fox — were *foragers*.” She tapped the staircase, the empty top three stairs. “No farming. No pots — *pre-pottery* is in the name of the whole period, that’s how sure we are, there isn’t a potsherd because there wasn’t a pot. No wheel. No metal. No writing. No town. No king. None of the things the staircase says you need *first*.”

She left the front piece of bread sitting out there, alone, in front of all the others.

“They built the cathedral,” she said quietly, “before they invented the village.”

Frik looked at the bread. His foot had stopped.

“*Six thousand years*,” he said.

“What?”

“Before Stonehenge.” His head pulled. “You’re going to make me say it. — Six thousand years before Stonehenge. Before the pyramids. The pyramids are closer to *us* than they are to *this*.” The last word came out cracked and his hand went flat on the table as if to hold it down, and the grandfather in the chair laughed — not at him, with the appreciation of a man hearing something land — and said something in Kurdish that none of them caught, and went back to his cigarette.

“Right,” said Naila. “And I can’t flatten it. I’ve tried. I sat with it till the prayer this morning and I cannot find the over-reach, because there isn’t one. It’s not a fringe claim. It’s not aliens, it’s not a lost super-race, it’s not Atlantis. The opposite. The most boring, careful, peer-reviewed mainstream archaeologists in the world dug it up and dated it and looked at the date and went *oh no*. Because it means the staircase is wrong. It means the temple didn’t come *after* we got civilised.” She put one finger on the front piece of bread. “It means maybe the temple is *why* we got civilised. Maybe the gathering came first, and the gathering needed feeding, and feeding the gathering is the thing that made us plant the seed.”

She said it flat, the way she said everything, no rise at the end, and then she ruined it, because she was honest to the bone and the fire-wall in her own head wouldn’t let a good sentence stand uncoded:

“That’s a *maybe*. I want to be clear that’s a maybe. Nobody’s proven the gathering drove the farming. It’s a live argument. There’s people who think the water management came first, there’s people who found house-floors and grinding stones, so the old line that *nobody lived there, it was just a temple* is dead too — they lived there, they processed cereal there, it’s messier than Schmidt’s pretty story.” She breathed. “The weird thing isn’t a thing I’m allowed to round up. The weird thing is *already true at the boring size*. The monuments came before the farms. That’s it. That survives every flattening I own.”

Frik was quiet for a while, which for Frik was a kind of weather, the tics still coming but small, idling.

“That’s why he kept saying it,” he said finally. “Jakobus. On the ridge. *What’s it for*.” His chin jerked. “He wasn’t asking how. You answered how. Seven to fourteen, ropes, fat on the track, done. He doesn’t care how. He’s looking at the arms and the fingers and the wee fox and he’s asking *what’s it for* like it’s a *who*.”

“They’re people,” Naila said. “The pillars. That’s not woo either, that’s just looking. The arms bend at the elbow. The hands have separate fingers. They’re wearing belts. One’s wearing a fox like a pelt. They’re not abstract. They’re not decoration. They’re standing figures, three storeys of them, in a ring, facing in.” She’d had this in her notes and hadn’t known where to put it. “Whoever they are, the living came and stood among them. In the dark, probably. By firelight. That’s the part I can’t do anything with. The weight I can do. The date I can do. But why thirty-foot stone people standing in a circle was worth *that* — worth the broken pillar in the quarry, worth the dead backs, worth doing it *first*, before bread—”

“That’s hers,” Frik said.

Naila stopped.

“The local lassie. Eylül.” He got the name almost right and his foot started again. “That’s not in your file, Nails. The *what’s it for*. That’s not a number. That’s whose ground it is.” He looked at the bread, the four torn pieces and the lonely fifth out in front. “You can prove they could lift it. You cannae tell her what her great-times-five-hundred granda was standing in the circle *for*. That’s the one you don’t get to win.”

The grandfather said something else and pointed at the bread and then at his own mouth, and Naila understood, after a second, that he was telling them not to play with food, and she gathered the staircase back into a pile and ate the front piece, the monument, the one that came first, and it was just bread.

She went back up that afternoon, on her own, while Mara stayed in the town and worked the consent she was working — finding the imam, finding Cemal who ran the tea-awning, asking the slow patient question of *may I*, learning the answer might be *no* and learning to let it be *no* — and while Frik stayed because the hill in the open with the Trust’s crew on it was a lot of unmeasured space for a body that drew eyes.

She went up because of the second page. The page after **ORDER**. The page she hadn’t shown anyone, because she didn’t trust it yet, and a thing she didn’t trust she kept off her mouth.

It was the measure.

She had stood, the day before, between the two central pillars of Enclosure D, and her hands had done the thing they did, the involuntary survey, and she'd clocked the span — pillar to pillar, the gap the living stood in. Then on the path out she'd passed the site board, the one with the surveys of the other Tas Tepeler on it, the whole family of hills, Karahan Tepe an hour east, the twenty-odd enclosures, the two hundred pillars, the ninety percent of it still under the ground waiting. And the board had a plan of Karahan's central setting on it, scaled, with a bar.

And the span had been the same.

Not *similar*. The same, inside the error she could read off a printed bar at arm's length, which was not nothing, which she would not pretend was proof — but the same.

That was the snag under the snag. Sites that had no business sharing a template. No writing to carry a plan between them. No road in the sense she meant a road. Foragers, who were not supposed to think in standard units, who were not supposed to have a *unit*, building rings an hour's walk apart to what looked, from a printed board, like one measure.

She stood between the two great limestone people now in the long gold afternoon light, in the shelter that kept the rain off eleven and a half thousand years of survival, and she paced the span again with her own feet to be sure her hands hadn't lied, and they hadn't.

She did not let herself say what it could mean, because what it could mean had no bottom and she was a woman who lived by bottoms, by floors, by levelled desks. It was probably convergence. It was probably the human body, the reach of an arm, the easiest ring to lay out with a rope and a peg. There were a dozen boring answers and any one of them would do and she *wanted* one of them to do.

But she stood with the pillar people, in the place where the living had come to stand with the raised stone dead, and she felt the floor not be there.

She'd spent fifteen years proving things weren't mysteries. She was good at it. She'd flattened this whole site flat — the weight, the work-force, the ropes, the track, the date, the *impossible*, all of it down to

the ground where it belonged.

All of it but the one thing. The order, and under the order, the measure. The same span, in two places that shouldn't share one.

Somewhere down the ridge a man she could only ever see from the outside took off his sunglasses to look at the pillars properly, and put them back on, and said nothing, and watched the hill.

Naila looked at her watch.

It told her the time. It did not tell her the year. Eleven and a half thousand years ago, in this exact gap of air, someone had stood where she stood, and looked up at the same arms, and the same fingers, and the same small fox cradled at the same belt — and had, presumably, known what it was for.

She got out the second page, and under the measure, she wrote a single question, the only one she had no method for, and left it lying there for someone whose ground it was to answer.

Who taught both hills the same length?

Chapter 3 — The Man Who Reads the Made Thing

The Beast had crossed two seas to be here and it had not enjoyed the trip.

Frik stood in the hotel's back lot at six in the morning watching Jakobus open the bonnet of the thing the way a man opens a letter he's been dreading, and the dawn light came in flat off the plain and turned all the dust gold, which was a lie the dust told every morning, because by ten it would just be dust again, in your teeth, up your nose, ground into the creases of your hands like you'd been handling old money. The Land Cruiser had come overland from the port at Mersin on a flatbed, and it had arrived with a film over everything, a salt-and-grease film off the Mediterranean crossing, and Jakobus was wiping it from the air intake with the hanky.

The hanky. *Eish*, the hanky.

It was always clean. That was the thing about it Frik couldn't get past, had been unable to get past since the first week. The man drove a truck the colour of a riverbed through countries that produced dust as their primary national export and the hanky was always, impossibly, white. He never seemed to wash it where anyone could see. It just was. Folded into a square. Came out. Did a job. Went back. Frik's left shoulder jumped — a hard hitch up toward his ear, twice, the morning tic, the one that liked the cold — and he let it, because there was nobody here to manage it for, just the truck and the man and the gold lie of the light.

"It ran rough on the test," Jakobus said. Not to Frik especially. To the engine, maybe. "Bad fuel somewhere. Cape diesel and this diesel,

different animal.”

“Different animal,” Frik said. He hadn’t meant to. The words came back out of him the way they did, repeated, polished, handed back. Echolalia, the doctors called it, when they were being kind, and the other thing when they weren’t. He’d long ago stopped flinching at himself for it. Mostly. “Sorry. Carry on.”

Jakobus didn’t look up. “Nothing to be sorry for.”

That was the whole strange country of the crew, right there, in three words said to a carburettor. *Nothing to be sorry for*. Frik had been thrown out of more rooms than he could count — out of a chemistry exam, out of a funeral, once out of a cinema by a man who genuinely believed Frik was barking the words *back* at the screen on purpose, as a comment, as criticism — and here was this enormous quiet South African with the sun-creased eyes who had said, in the first hour they met, that Frik’s mouth was the most honest instrument he’d ever found, and that he intended to point it at some lies, and would that be all right.

It had been all right.

It was the most all right thing that had ever happened to Frik Basson, and he didn’t have a single tic for that, no word at all, which was its own kind of telling.

This was the part Frik kept, the way other people kept photographs: how they’d come to be standing on the wrong continent.

It had started with chalk. A school’s worth of chalk, a year and a country ago, on a board Edie Vane had filled and filled and not been able to stop filling — holes in the ground, all over the map, holes that weren’t supposed to know about each other. Frik hadn’t understood most of it. He understood that Jakobus had stood very still in front of that board for a long time and then taken off his sunglasses, which was the man’s entire vocabulary for *this matters*, and had said: it’s not one. It’s a pattern. And you don’t get a pattern from accident.

And then he’d gone and found them. One at a time. The way you’d build a tool when the tool you needed didn’t exist yet.

Naila, who read the system underneath the thing — who could look

at a too-clean number and feel it the way you feel a step that isn't there in the dark. Mara, who read the lens, who'd put a camera down at a war and walked away from the only thing she was famous for. And him. Frik, who read the lie — not cleverly, not by deduction, God knew, but with his actual body, which had the appalling and lifelong habit of saying the true thing out loud at the worst possible second, in the worst possible room, where it couldn't be unsaid.

The anti-paintover, Jakobus had called him once, and Frik had had to look it up. A paintover was when you painted over the crack instead of fixing the wall. Frik was what happened when the wall couldn't keep a secret.

He thought about that a lot, here, in a place that was — by every account — built on a very large and very old and very *polite* version of painting over the crack.

They drove out to the hill before the heat, the four of them, on Eylül's say-so and under the project's grace, which was a thing made of permit numbers and a stamped letter in the glovebox and Eylül's name spoken to a guard at a gate, and not at all of money, because the money in this story was the wrong money and belonged to the wrong people.

The site sat under a great pale tensile roof now, a modern shelter spread over the enclosures like a held breath, and the walkways kept you off the stones, up above them, looking down, which was correct and which Frik hated, a little, the way you hate being told not to touch the dog. From the walkway Enclosure D opened below them, the great oval of it, the wall of smaller pillars ringing it, and in the centre the two big ones.

The two big ones.

Frik's first time, two days ago, his mouth had gone off like a fire alarm. He'd stood on the walkway and his throat had done the thing it did when something was *too much*, when the dial went past where the body could hold it quiet — a rising series, *hah, hah, HAH* — and then a word, loud, into the German tourists' reverent hush, a word that was just the truth coming up sideways out of him before he could swallow it: "*People.*"

Heads had turned. Mara had stepped half in front of him, casual, blocking sightlines without making a show of it, the way she always did, a body between him and the staring, and Naila had kept looking at the pillars as if nothing had happened because to Naila nothing had, and Eylül — Eylül had turned and looked at him with an expression he was still chewing on, two days later. Not annoyance. Not pity. Something closer to: yes, *and*?

Because of course they were people. Anyone could see it. Klaus Schmidt had seen it in the nineteen-nineties when he started digging, the German archaeologist, Deutsches Archäologisches Institut, the man who'd given his whole life to this hill and then died of it more or less, of a heart attack, in 2014, and Frik thought of him often, the way you think of someone who built the house you're sleeping in. Schmidt had looked at these T-shaped megaliths — and they were *megaliths*, that was the right and unhysterical word, eleven and a half thousand years old, made by people who had no pottery, no metal, no wheel, no writing, no farms — and he had seen that the T wasn't a T. It was a body seen flat. The crossbar at the top was a head turned to face you. And on the great central pair, carved in low relief down the long shaft of each, were arms.

Arms that bent at the elbow. Arms that came round to the front. And at the belt, where the belt was carved — actual fingers. Individual fingers, the two hands almost meeting over the buckle, the way a man stands when he's at ease and somebody's about to take his portrait.

Pillar 18 wore a belt. Pillar 18 wore, carved across the front of him, a fox-pelt loincloth, and cradled against the side of him, in low relief, a fox.

They were people. Schmidt knew. The fish knew. *Frik's body had known so hard it shouted.* And the only question worth a damn — the question Jakobus had been turning over since the chalkboard, the question that wasn't *who* and wasn't *is it real* and wasn't, God help us, *was it aliens* — was the one nobody could carbon-date.

What is it for.

"Banning says seven," Naila said.

She was on the walkway rail, both hands flat on it, rocking very slightly,

heel to toe, which Frik had learned not to read as nervous because it wasn't, it was thinking, it was her metronome the way Jakobus had his. She'd been at the labour arithmetic for two days now and she'd taken it apart like a watch.

"Seven what," Mara said. She had the camera up — the small one, the one she used for *looking* rather than *taking* — and she was sighting on the far pillars, not pressing anything, just framing, the way she warmed up.

"To move one. Seven to fourteen people. E. B. Banning ran it — ropes, a lubricated track, the weight's eight to ten tonnes, you don't need a magic army, you need a dozen people who aren't idiots and a wet log." Naila's heel came down hard, once. "Everyone wants it to be impossible. It isn't impossible. That's the *boring* part and the boring part is *true* and people hate that, they'd rather have a miracle than a wet log." She turned her head, not quite to Frik, eyes on his collar-bone the way she aimed. "It being possible is the whole problem."

"Because they'll say so," Frik said. His shoulder hitched. "The Trust."

"Because they'll say so." She put a little weight on it, glad to be understood. "It's solved, it's just a workforce, hunter-gatherers got together for a barn-raising, nothing left here to protect, sign the access agreement, let the nice foundation take the unexcavated ninety per cent off your hands for safekeeping." She said *safekeeping* like it had a hook in it. "I proved the easy version is feasible and I handed them the knife."

"You didn't hand them anything," Mara said, low, still framing. "You did the maths. The maths is just true."

"That's what a knife is."

Down on the walkway behind them, near the far end where it bent toward the slope, Jakobus had stopped.

Frik watched him do it. That was Frik's specialty when it came to Jakobus — watching, because watching was all anybody got. The man could not be had any closer than the outside. Mara had said it best, weeks ago, half a bottle in: she'd tried to photograph him for a year and never got him clean. He came out blurred, or turned, or eaten by glare, or just somehow *not in the frame he should have been in*, and she'd stopped calling it bad luck. Even the Trust's little drone

the other day, the one that had hummed over the dig fence like a fat metal bee and that Eylül had glared at until it left — even that had a hard drive somewhere full of everyone but him.

So Frik watched him from the outside, which was the only telescope there was.

Jakobus had stopped at the rail. He took off the sunglasses. He did it slowly, hooking one arm, folding them, and the bare eyes went down into the enclosure and stayed there a long time on the two central pillars, on the arms, the fingers, the fox, and his face did the nothing it did, the great patient nothing of a man reading a made thing for its purpose, and then he put the glasses back on, which was him filing it, and he said, to the air, in his way, not loud:

“Sawubona.”

I see you. The Zulu greeting. The one he carried from home and aimed, sometimes, at things that weren’t people, except these were, that was the whole point, these were people, eleven thousand years dead and standing up straight in the ground, and the big man had just said good morning to them.

Frik’s throat moved. He let the word come because it was true and there was nobody here it would cost. “*Sawubona*,” he said back, to the pillars, and it didn’t feel like echolalia. It felt like answering.

Eylül arrived at the slope-edge in a field shirt the colour of the dust with a clipboard under her arm, and the gate-talk and the permit-number weight came off the day the second she was on the ground, because this was her ground and you could feel the air change.

“You’re up early,” she said, to all of them, and to Naila in particular, because she’d clocked which one was the engine. “Cemal sent tea. My uncle. It’s in the truck and it’s better than the hotel’s, so don’t insult me by saying no.”

“We won’t say no,” Mara said.

“Good. The Trust’s people were here yesterday.” Eylül said it lightly and it wasn’t light at all. “Reyes. Mr. Anton Reyes, of the Anatolia Heritage Trust. Lovely man. Genuinely, that’s the trouble, he’s a lovely man. He brought a slideshow.” She made the word *slideshow* sound

like a soft and terrible weapon, which Frik supposed it was. “It had drone footage and a sad piano and a sentence about *neglect*. The provincial budget is real, you understand. The roof you’re standing under has a maintenance cost. He stands in the gap between the money we don’t have and the heritage somebody has to save, and he stands there with very clean hands and he is not lying, that’s the genius of it, he believes he’s the hero, and the official story —” she gestured down at the enclosure, at the whole solved, dated, radiocarbon-secure, beautifully-explained wonder of it — “the official story is his best slide. *It’s a gathering place. We know what it is. There’s nothing left to find. Let the grown-ups take care of it.*”

Naila had gone very still on the rail. “It’s not solved,” she said.

“I know,” said Eylül.

“No, but it’s *not*. People think it’s solved because the headline got solved. Schmidt cracked the headline — monuments before farming, the order’s inverted, you didn’t need a town to build a temple, you maybe needed a temple to build a town, *that’s* secure, that’s the part that’s actually true and actually huge.” She was rocking again, hard, the maths coming up through her. “But that’s the famous part. The famous part being solved makes everyone stop looking, and under the famous part —”

“Under the famous part,” Eylül said, and she was smiling now, the first real one, because here was an outsider who’d found the trapdoor under the floor, “there’s the part nobody put on a slide.”

The tea came out of Cemal’s flask, and it was better, and they drank it on the walkway with the heat starting to lean in, and that was when Naila laid the two pages on the rail, weighted with a stone, and Frik leaned in to read over her shoulder because his eye liked her handwriting, which was small and even and ran perfectly level without a line.

The first page was the labour arithmetic, the wet-log math, the dozen-not-a-miracle, all of it, ruled and totalled and *killed*, the over-reach lying dead on the page where she’d shot it.

The second page had two numbers on it and, under them, one line of words.

The numbers were spans. A measure. The same measure, she'd written, twice — once for here, once, in a smaller hand, for *Karahan*.

Karahan Tepe. The other hill. One of the Taş Tepeler, the Stone Hills, the whole spread of them across this plain, twenty enclosures maybe, two hundred pillars at Göbekli alone and only a tenth of it dug, ninety per cent of it still down there in the dark under the dirt, asleep. A whole *tradition*. Not one weird hill. A region of them, talking to each other across ground a person would walk for two days.

And the span was the same.

"It's probably nothing," Naila said, before anyone could speak, fast, the way she headed off a thing she didn't trust herself near. "It's probably convergence. The arm. The reach of an arm makes a natural unit, you lay out a circle with a rope and a peg, you get human-scale numbers everywhere, of course you do, it's the most boring explanation and the boring explanation is *usually* the —" She stopped. Her heel came down. "I keep wanting it to be the boring one."

"Why," said Mara, gently.

"Because the boring one doesn't keep me up."

Frik's body moved before his mind caught it. The hitch, the throat, the rising *hah, hah*, and then — out, before he could hold it, dropped into the middle of the quiet like a coin into a well — the true thing, the thing nobody at the rail had said out loud yet, the thing under the thing:

"Somebody *taught* them."

Silence.

His face went hot. He waited for the room to do what rooms did. To go careful. To go *managed*.

It didn't.

Eylül looked at him for a long second with that *yes, and?* face, the one from two days ago, and then she said, slowly, like she was being fair to a possibility she didn't owe anything: "That's the question the maths puts on the table, and I'll tell you honestly, I don't know the answer, and I'll tell you something else." She tapped the second page, the measure. "Don't fall in love with it. That's how the woo gets you.

You see one shared number and next thing you've got a lost super-race and a master plan and little grey men with a tape measure, and you've made the whole thing *smaller*, not bigger, you've taken the actual miracle — that ordinary people, hunters, with stone tools and rope and their own backs, *invented all of this from nothing* — and you've handed it to imaginary strangers because you couldn't bear that human beings did it." Her voice had heat in it now, the protective heat of someone whose ancestors were on the wrong end of *humans-couldn't-have*. "They could bear it. They *did* it. The same measure might be a teacher walking between two hills. Or it might be a man's arm and a piece of rope. I'm not going to pretend I know which, and you" — she looked at Frik, dead level, full dignity, the first person in his whole life to do it about a tic — "your mouth's right that it's a real question. It's just not a solved one. Hold it open."

"Hold it open," Frik said. And then, because it was true, and because there was nobody here it would cost: "Thank you."

The handoff came without anyone calling it that.

It came in the angle of things. Naila's pages stayed on the rail, weighted with the stone, but she didn't pick them back up, and when Mara raised the camera at last — toward the enclosure, toward the two great pillar-people with their bent arms and their patient fingers and the small fox at the belt — she didn't press the shutter. She lowered it again. She turned to Eylül.

"Can I," she said. "The pillars I'll shoot — they're under a public roof, they're on every postcard in town, that's nobody's secret. But the *meaning*. The thing it is to *you*. I'm not putting that in a frame and selling it." She said it plainly, no performance in it. "So I'm asking. What do you want seen, and what do you want left alone."

Eylül looked at her the way you look at someone who's just declined the thing everyone else takes.

And Jakobus, at the far end of the walkway, with his back half to them and his sunglasses on and the desert behind him that wasn't his desert, the wrong continent under his boots, the Beast washed of two seas of salt down in the lot, the cayenne tin somewhere in his pack against a snakebite that the snakes here didn't deliver the

same way — Jakobus did the thing he did, the only thing, the thing he'd built this whole crew to be able to do without him.

He stepped back. He let the rail be theirs. He turned his face to the plain and the buried ninety per cent of it and he stood guard over a question that wasn't his to answer, in a place that wasn't his to own, and he said nothing at all, which was him handing it across.

Naila looked at her two pages on the rail. The dead arithmetic. The open question.

Who taught both hills the same length.

And the woman whose ground it was set down her uncle's flask, and looked at the three of them, the system-reader and the lens-reader and the man whose body could not lie, and she said:

"You want to know what it's for."

It wasn't a question.

"Then come down off the walkway," said Eylül Demir. "And I'll tell you what my grandmother told me. But not up here. Not over the heads of the dead."

Chapter 4 — The One Who Owns the Ground

The steps down off the walkway were modern. Galvanised mesh, anti-slip tread, a handrail somebody in a provincial budget office had signed off on. Mara photographed none of it. She was watching her own feet and the dust they kicked, because the dust was older than the steps and would outlast them, and because she had just told a woman she would not steal her face, and she was now in the slightly weightless aftermath of having meant it.

Eylül went first. Then Naila, with her two pages folded once and held against her sternum like a hymn book. Then Frik, who hummed the descent — not a tune, a metronome, four notes climbing and one falling, the same five he'd run all morning, the thing his throat did to spend the charge before it spent itself in words. Then Mara. Then, last and a long way back, Jakobus, who did not come down at all. He set his shoulders against the rail at the top and turned his sunglasses to the plain, and that was that. The man had a gift for subtraction. He removed himself from a frame so cleanly you forgot he'd been the one to assemble it.

At the bottom there was a path, then off the path a track that wasn't a track, just the worn ghost of one through the scrub, and at the end of it a man under an awning made of two olive poles and a sun-bleached tarp the colour of weak tea. A folding table. A gas ring. A long-handled pot. The man was sixty-something and built like a fence post that had held a gate forty years, and when he saw Eylül his whole face did something Mara's hands ached to catch and her training would not let her.

“Cemal,” Eylül said, and then a run of Kurdish, and the old man laughed and waved a hand at the table as if they’d kept him waiting.

“My uncle,” she said, to the rest of them. “He’s farmed this since before Schmidt. Before any of us. The Germans used to buy his tea by the litre.”

“Schmidt.” Frik said it like he was tasting it. Then, lower, to himself, the involuntary footnote: “*Klaus*.”

“Klaus, ja.” Eylül’s mouth tilted. “You know the name.”

“Everybody who comes here knows the name,” Frik said, which was the true thing and also, today, a kindness, because the old man had heard it and nodded at the ground like a man hearing an old friend mentioned.

The tea came in tulip glasses on a tin tray that had been red once. Cemal poured it from a height, the dark stream and the lighter water meeting in the glass, and he handed the first one to Naila because Naila was standing nearest and looking at the legs of the folding table.

“Four,” she said. “The table has four legs and three of them are level. He’s shimmed the fourth with a flake of limestone.” She wasn’t being odd. She was being accurate, and she took the glass with both hands and said *teşekkür ederim* in the careful, learned way of someone who’d practised it in a hotel room, and Cemal beamed at her like she’d recited poetry.

Mara sat where she was put, on an upturned crate, and did not lift the camera. The camera was on its strap against her chest and it weighed what it always weighed, which today was more than the body and the lens and the card, because she had told the woman she would ask first and now the asking was a live wire between them and she could feel it.

She’d built a life on not asking. That was the ugly part she’d stopped hiding from herself somewhere over the Mediterranean. The frames that made her name — the boy at the checkpoint, the woman at the morgue door, the whole bound career of horror she’d carried out of three wars on a memory card — she had asked nobody. You didn’t ask. Asking broke the frame. The frame was sacred and the people in it were not, and she’d believed that the way you believe a thing

that pays you, which is to say completely and without examining it, right up until the morning she'd lifted the camera at a fourth war and her hands had simply refused, the way a horse refuses a jump, and no amount of professionalism in her shoulders could make the body do the theft again.

So now she asked. And it was excruciating. And she sat on the crate and drank the old man's tea and let the perfect photograph happen all around her without her in it.

Because it *was* perfect. That was the cruelty of it. Eylül had her back half to the hill, and behind her the slope rose to the enclosures, and the light at this hour came in low and gold off the scrub and caught the side of her face and the loose dark hair and the absolute unselfconscious authority of a woman on her own ground, and behind that the pillars — the great grey teeth of them up the slope, the central two in Enclosure D that you could just see the heads of from down here. A woman. The dead. Eleven and a half thousand years between them and not a finger's width of distance in the frame. It would run a full page. It would run a cover. It would be the photograph that said *Göbekli Tepe* to people who would never read a word of the caption, and it was sitting there in front of Mara, composed, lit, gift-wrapped, and all she had to do was lift the thing on her chest.

"You're not shooting," Eylül said. She'd caught it. Of course she'd caught it; reading what a person did with their hands was half her trade too.

"No," Mara said.

"You want to."

"Like a thirst," Mara said, because there was no point lying to her, and a small honest thing was the only currency she had down here. "You against the hill. The light's doing the work for me. I could make my year off it and yours too." She turned the glass in her hands. "Which is exactly why I'm asking. You said come down and you'd tell us. You didn't say bring the camera into it."

Cemal said something. Eylül answered, three words, and the old man looked at Mara and then up at the hill and then back at Mara, and he made a flat pushing gesture with his weathered hand — *down, leave it down* — that needed no translation, and then he softened it with a

smile and refilled her glass she hadn't finished.

"He says," Eylül translated, "the Germans took ten thousand photographs of the stones and not one of his father, who showed them where to dig."

The wire between them stopped being a wire and became a thing Mara could stand on.

"There it is," she said. "That's the rule. Tell me the rule."

Eylül sat. She drew one knee up and wrapped her hands around her glass and looked not at Mara but up the slope, and when she spoke it had the cadence of something said many times and meant every time.

"The stones, you can photograph. The stones belong to everyone now, that's the bargain we made when it became a —" she flicked her fingers at an invisible plaque " — *World Heritage Site*. Photograph the stones until your card is full. But the people of these villages have been the backdrop of other people's pictures for thirty years. The expert flown in. The documentary host. The foundation man in his clean shirt standing where my uncle's grandfather pastured goats, telling a camera that nobody lived here." Her jaw set on that one. "So. The rule. You do not put one of us in front of the stones to make the stones look more *ancient*. You do not use my face to sell the hill. If you want me, you ask me, *Eylül*, not *the local woman*, not *the Kurdish archaeologist*, and you tell me where it runs and you let me see it before it does. And if I say no —" she shrugged, light, final " — then you put it down. Like you're doing."

"Like I'm doing," Mara said.

"Why are you doing it?" Not a challenge. A genuine question, and a sharp one. "You came here to get pictures. It's your job. Why is your camera on your chest instead of your eye?"

And this was the thing Mara had not said out loud to anyone, not to Jakobus who had found her in a Tbilisi hotel bar not lifting a camera and offered her a job that was mostly *not* lifting it, not to Naila, not to her own self most days.

"Because I spent fifteen years taking pictures of people on the worst day of their lives," she said, "and I never once asked them. And the

pictures were good. That's the part nobody tells you. They were very, very good, and they did some good, and they also ate something out of the people in them that I gave back to nobody, and ate something out of me, and one day I went to lift it at a checkpoint and my arms wouldn't." She set her glass down on the shimmed table, careful of the wobble. "I don't know how to witness a thing without consuming it. I'm trying to learn. You're my teacher today, whether you want the job or not."

Eylül looked at her for a long moment. Up the slope a tour group's voices floated down, thinned by distance to birdsong. Naila had drifted to the edge of the awning's shade and was looking at the joint where the tarp met the pole, at the lashing, the over-under of the cord, and Frik had folded down cross-legged in the dust beside Cemal and was being shown — without a word of shared language between them — how the old man read the sky for the afternoon wind, the two of them pointing at clouds and grunting agreement, and it was, Mara thought, the most relaxed she'd seen Frik since the airport. Nobody here wanted him to be still. The old man didn't even seem to notice the tics, or noticed and filed them under *the way this young man is*, the same drawer he kept the wind in.

"All right," Eylül said. "Then here's your first lesson, photographer." And she stopped looking at Mara and started looking at the hill, and her voice changed register, dropped the wariness, picked up something older. "You know what they always get wrong about this place. All of them. The hosts, the foundation, the man who'll come and offer to *protect* it. They say it like it's a fact you swallow once and you're done. *The temple before the farm*. They say it to sound clever and they don't let it land."

"Let it land," Mara said. "I want it to land. Half of why we're here is I don't think any of us have let it land."

So Eylül let it land. And Mara, who would not lift the camera, did the other thing she knew how to do, which was hold still and see.

"Eleven and a half thousand years," Eylül said. "Write the number down, Naila, you like the numbers."

"I have the number," Naila said from the tarp. "Nine thousand five

hundred BCE for the oldest secure dates. The charcoal in the fill. The radiocarbon's not in dispute. It's clean." She said *clean* the way other people said *beautiful*. "Six thousand years before they cut the first stone at Stonehenge. Seven before the pyramids. It's the oldest monumental architecture on Earth that we've found and dated."

"Clean," Eylül agreed. "Klaus Schmidt dug here from 1995. German Archaeological Institute. He found the first pillar with his own two hands after a survey team forty years before him saw broken limestone on the surface and wrote *medieval cemetery* and went home." A small dry laugh. "Forty years it sat under the wrong word. *Medieval*. The oldest temple on Earth, mislabelled and ignored, because the people who looked first couldn't imagine the answer was older than their imagination. Remember that, when the foundation tells you what's down there isn't worth saving."

"What's the temple, though," Mara said. "Tell me what I'm looking at. I've read the panel. I want it from you."

"Enclosures. Round, oval. Dug into the slope. Built and used and refilled and built again over centuries." Eylül lifted her glass toward the hill. "Stone rings, with the great T-pillars standing in them like a circle of —" she searched for it "— like a meeting. And in the centre of the oldest, the biggest, two pillars facing each other. Five and a half metres. Eight, ten tonnes. The weight of a loaded truck, standing on end, balanced, eleven thousand years before anyone had a truck or a wheel or a written word or a pot to boil water in."

"Eight to ten tonnes," Mara said, and looked at Naila. "And you worked out you could move that with — what was it. Seven people."

"Seven to fourteen," Naila said, and there was an edge in her voice Mara had learned to hear. The edge meant a thing that had cost her. "Banning's arithmetic. Ropes, a lubricated track, levers. Seven to fourteen people and a season and you can move a pillar. I checked his working twice. He's right. You don't need a lost civilisation. You don't need giants. You don't need —" a flat hard stop "— anything that isn't a determined group of ordinary humans who decided it mattered enough."

"That's a strange thing to sound sad about," Eylül said, gently.

"It's not sad," Naila said. "It's worse than that. It's easy. The lift is

easy. Fourteen people, off you go.” She came out of the tarp’s shade and into the low gold light and her pages were in her hand again. “What’s not easy is the part nobody can solve with rope. Who fed the fourteen people. For the season they’re hauling stone instead of hunting, who hunts for them. Who organised it. Who decided which pillar went where, in what *order* — because you can’t put the centre stones up after the ring, the geometry won’t let you, and you can’t put the ring up first either, you’d box yourself out of the centre. There’s a sequence. A correct sequence. Somebody held the whole sequence in their head before a single stone moved.” She looked up the hill at the two heads just visible. “Somebody planned it. Hunter-gatherers. Before farms. Before the granary, before the surplus, before everything we were taught comes first and makes the rest possible. They had the plan before they had the bread.”

And there it was. Mara felt it go through the little group under the awning like cold water, the actual size of it, the thing the panel said in two flat sentences and Eylül had made them sit down in the dust to feel.

“Say it the simple way,” Eylül said. “The way that makes people stop walking.”

“The monument came first,” Naila said. “We always told the story the other way round. First you farm. Farming gives you surplus, surplus gives you towns, towns give you priests and kings and leisure, and *then*, fat and settled, you build the temple. That’s the order in every textbook. Plant, then pray.” She tapped the page. “Here it’s backwards. Here they built the temple while they were still chasing gazelle. And the live question — the real one, the one that’s actually open — is whether it was the *building* that did it. Whether gathering hundreds of people in one place to haul ten-tonne stones, year after year, is the thing that *forced* them to figure out how to feed a crowd that wasn’t moving. Whether we didn’t settle down and then build a temple. Whether we built a temple and *had* to settle down to keep building it.”

Frik, from the dust, eyes on the clouds, said it before he could stop it, which was the only way he ever said anything that mattered:

“The church built the town.”

Nobody laughed. Cemal, who hadn’t followed the English, looked at

the young man's face and at the hill and something passed over him too, the recognition that crosses any language, and he said one quiet word in Kurdish and Eylül translated it without being asked.

"He says: yes."

A long silence then, the comfortable kind, four foreigners and a Kurdish archaeologist and an old farmer sitting in the long gold light with the oldest building on Earth above them and tea going cold in their hands.

Mara could feel the photograph still sitting there. Eylül, the hill, the light. It hadn't gone anywhere. If anything it had gotten better; the woman's face had opened, the wariness gone, there was a thing in it now you could have built a magazine around. *This is the face of the people who own the ground.* Her thumb knew exactly where the power switch was. The body remembered the whole choreography, the half-step left for the light, the breath held, the squeeze.

She kept her hands in her lap.

"You could take it now," Eylül said, watching her again. Almost amused. "I wouldn't even see you do it. I'm not looking."

"I'd see me do it," Mara said.

Eylül nodded slowly, and that — Mara understood, sitting on the crate with her career going cold beside the tea — that was the actual lesson, the one under the lesson. Not *don't take the picture*. You could take the picture; some pictures wanted taking. The lesson was that the rule lived in *her*, now, not in Eylül's permission, that she'd carry the held breath and the lowered hands out of this awning and into every place after it. That she'd become someone who *saw* she was about to consume a thing, in the half-second before, when there was still time to choose. It would cost her photographs. It had already cost her the cover. She found, drinking the cold tea, that she did not want it back.

"All right," Eylül said, and she stood, and brushed the dust off, and looked at the three of them — the one who read the system, the one who read the lens, the one whose body could not hold a lie — with the steady appraising warmth of a woman deciding to give a gift she

didn't have to give.

"You came up the walkway looking for *how*," she said. "How they cut it, how they raised it, how seven people move ten tonnes. The foundation will come looking for the same thing, and they'll find the *how*, and they'll write it on a glossy panel and say *solved, nothing left here, sign the access papers*. You hear me? The *how* is the trap. The *how* is what they use to tell you the wonder's all spent." She looked up at the two grey heads on the slope, the central pillars of Enclosure D, the ones carved as people, with arms that bent at the elbow and hands that came together over a stone belt and individual fingers, the fox-pelt loincloth on the one, the small carved fox cradled against its side, eleven and a half thousand years standing in a ring facing each other in the dark under the dirt until 1995.

"My grandmother never read a panel in her life," Eylül said. "She walked past this hill every day of it. And she told me what it was for. Not how. *For*."

She crouched and gathered the empty glasses onto Cemal's red tin tray, the most ordinary motion in the world, and over the small ring of them, the system-reader and the lens-reader and the truth-teller, with her uncle nodding beside her at a sky only he could read, she said the first thing that none of them, after, could un-hear.

"They're not pillars," said Eylül Demir. "We knew that before the Germans. Every child here knows it. They have arms. They have hands. They're standing up.

"They're *people*."

Chapter 5 — The Anatolia Heritage Trust

The brochure was on glossy stock, the kind that wants to be held.

Naila held it because Eylül had put it in her hands at the awning that morning and said *tell me what you see*, and because paper that good has a tell. The grain on the cover was a drone shot of Enclosure D at golden hour, the two central pillars throwing long shadows that did not exist at that latitude on the date the photo claimed in its caption corner. Somebody had composited the shadows. Somebody had wanted them longer.

She did not say that yet. She turned the page.

THE ANATOLIA HERITAGE TRUST. *Stewardship for what cannot speak for itself*. Beneath it, a man's photograph — open collar, no tie, the deliberate informality of money that has stopped needing to prove it has money. Anton Reyes, Director of Acquisitions and Conservation. Behind him, soft-focus, a conservation lab, a row of fragments laid on grey foam in numbered trays. The trays were the thing. Naila counted them without deciding to. Eleven. The eleventh was empty.

"He's coming up at noon," Eylül said. She was sitting on the upturned crate she always sat on, peeling the foil off a fresh brick of tea for Cemal, who was asleep in the shade with his cap over his eyes. "The provincial office set it. A *courtesy meeting*. The Trust is a registered partner on three sites in the Tas Tepeler. They have a research-access application sitting in Ankara with the museum's name on the cover sheet, which is how they'd like it to look. The museum doesn't love it. The museum can't stop it either."

“Why noon,” Frik said. He was crouched on his heels at the awning’s edge, watching a line of ants carry a dead beetle uphill, and his head jerked twice to the left, the small clean tic he carried like a comma. “Hot at noon. Bad light. Why would the camera guy pick the worst light.”

Mara, who had not lifted her camera since the sun cleared the ridge, looked up from where she sat with the lens cap on in her lap. “Because he’s not the camera guy. He brings the camera guy.”

“Two of them,” Naila said. She had reached the back page. Partners and Patrons, set in a typeface that cost more than the tea brick. She read the names down the column and stopped on one near the bottom and read it again, and the small machine behind her sternum that never quite switched off went *click*. “Mara. The drone shot on the cover. The shadows are wrong for the date. Somebody added them in post.”

“Shows you what they want it to feel like,” Mara said. “Older. Lonelier. Empty.”

“Empty,” Naila said, “is the whole document.”

She laid the brochure flat on the table and the table rocked, because the table always rocked, and she had stopped trying to fix it on day one and started using it as a metronome. She put her finger on a line of body copy halfway down a page that was otherwise photographs of light through dust.

Following decades of distinguished excavation, the central enclosures of Göbekli Tepe are among the most thoroughly understood monuments of the ancient world. The story is, in essence, told. The Trust’s mission is to secure what remains — the unexcavated periphery — against the twin threats of neglect and unregulated tourism, and to ensure that the chapter, now substantially closed, is preserved for all humankind.

“Read it out,” Eylül said quietly. “The middle bit.”

Naila read it out. The story is, in essence, told. The chapter, now substantially closed.

For a moment the only sound was the ants, and a generator coughing two terraces down, and the wind doing the thing the wind did here,

coming off the plain in a long even press with no edge to it, the kind of wind that had been blowing across this exact ground for eleven and a half thousand years and would not be hurried by anyone's noon meeting.

"They've solved it," Mara said.

"They've *closed* it," Eylül said. "Different word." She set the tea brick down. "If it's solved, there's nothing left to find. If there's nothing left to find, there's nothing left to protect. If there's nothing left to protect —" She looked uphill, past the two of them, toward the long modern roof that sheltered the excavated enclosures, and past that to the bare brown swell of the rest of the hill, the ninety percent of it that no spade had ever touched. "— then who's going to make a fuss when somebody quietly buys the right to dig the rest of it on a *conservation permit* and ship whatever comes up to a lab in a country with friendlier export law. Nobody. Because the story's *told*. You can't loot a place that's already empty."

Naila looked at the eleven trays again. The empty eleventh.

"Ten percent," she said. "That's what's been dug. Schmidt's enclosures, the central ones, the famous ones. A through F, more or less. Ninety percent of this hill is still in the ground. And that's just this hill. There are —" she did the count she'd been doing for two days, the count that wouldn't leave her alone "— what, twenty enclosures here. Two hundred pillars, give or take, when you add the ones still buried. And it's not one hill. Karahan Tepe, Sayburç, the others. The whole — what did your survey call it."

"Tas Tepeler," Eylül said. "Stone Hills. A region. A *tradition*. Not a site."

"Right." Naila pressed her finger on the brochure where it said *the chapter, now substantially closed*. "You can't close a chapter when you've read one paragraph of one page of one book in a library nobody's catalogued. The arithmetic doesn't let you. It's not an opinion. It's not even close." She looked up. "Somebody who knows numbers wrote this. They wrote it *because* they know the numbers. You don't say *substantially closed* by accident over ninety percent. You say it on purpose, to a reader who won't check."

Frik's head jerked. "Lie," he said. Not loud. Just out, the way it came

out of him, ahead of the part of him that decided things. “It’s a lie.” And then, quieter, almost to the ants: “Sorry. It’s a lie though.”

“You don’t have to be sorry for being right,” Eylül said, without looking round, and Frik’s shoulders came down a centimetre, and Naila watched that happen and said nothing about it because saying something about it would have ruined it.

Reyes came up the walkway at ten to twelve, ahead of his noon, which Naila noted, because people who control rooms arrive early to own them before anyone else does.

He was not what the brochure photo had been. The photo had been informal-money. The man was tired-money — a good linen shirt gone soft with travel, a watch you’d miss if you weren’t her, dust on his good shoes that he had decided not to mind. He came up the long boardwalk with one hand trailing the rail and he stopped, twice, the way people stopped who actually felt the place, and on the second stop he stood for a long moment looking at the central pillars in their roofed enclosure with his head tilted back, and his face when he didn’t think he was being filmed was not a salesman’s face. It was the face of a man looking at something he loved.

That was the part Naila hadn’t expected and didn’t like, because it didn’t fit the arithmetic. The arithmetic said *liar*. The face said *believer*. Both could be true. Both being true was worse.

Behind him came the camera guy, exactly as Mara had said, a young man with a gimbal rig and a cargo vest, and behind *him* a drone in a padded case, and Mara’s whole body changed when she saw the drone case — a stillness Naila recognised because she had her own version of it, the body bracing before the mind had named the thing. Mara set her own camera, capped, deliberately on the table. Made it a stone among stones. Took her hands off it.

“You must be the team,” Reyes said, and his voice was warm and his English was the frictionless English of a man who had four languages and used the one in front of him. He looked at Eylül first, which surprised Naila a second time. “Doctor Demir. They told me in Ankara you were the one who actually knows this ground. I’m grateful you’d see me.” He put out his hand and Eylül took it, once, and let go.

“You said courtesy meeting,” Eylül said.

“It is. I genuinely mean it as one.” He looked at the awning, at Cemal stirring under his cap, at the tea things. “May I?”

“Sit,” Eylül said. It was not warm. It was correct. There is a difference and everyone at the table could hear it.

He sat. The cameraman hung back at the rail, and the gimbal swung, and Frik said, “He’s filming the table,” flat, and the cameraman, who clearly had not been told this team had a man who said the true thing out loud before anyone could pretend it wasn’t happening, lowered the rig half a foot and looked at Reyes.

“Sani,” Reyes said, without turning. “Not the people. The stones are public. The people aren’t ours to take.” He said it like a thing he believed, and the cameraman lowered the rig the rest of the way, and Mara looked at Reyes then, hard, the first full look she’d given him, because he had just said her own rule back to the air with no idea it was her rule, and Naila watched the cost of that move across Mara’s face — the small disorientation of hearing your principle in the mouth of the person you’d come ready to fight.

Eylül poured him tea. The hospitality was the territory. He understood that; he wrapped his fingers round the little glass and did not gulp it, which was the right thing to do, and Naila hated, in a quiet bookkeeping way, how many right things he kept doing.

“I’ll be plain,” Reyes said. “Because you’ve read our materials and you’ve decided what you think of us, and you’re probably most of the way right.” He turned the glass a quarter-turn on the table, a small grounding gesture, and Naila clocked it as the same kind of thing she did with the rocking table. “I run a foundation that buys access. I won’t pretty it up. We pay provincial governments, we pay landowners, we pay for geophysics surveys that the state can’t fund and the universities can’t afford to run at scale, and in exchange we get rights — to data, to selected excavation, to a portion of what comes up. People hear *private antiquities concern* and they picture a man in a back room with a stolen frieze. I understand the picture. I’d like to be measured against the actual alternative.”

“Which is,” Eylül said.

“Which is this.” He gestured, gently, at the bare ninety percent of

the hill above them, browned and patient in the noon glare. “Nothing happening. For years. Underfunded, understaffed, the most important archaeological site on Earth and there’s a hosepipe leak in the conservation shelter that’s been on the work order since spring. You know this better than I do. The site gets ten million dollars of attention and a hundred thousand dollars of actual money, and meanwhile the periphery sits there unmapped, unprotected, and every farmer’s plough and every flash flood and every freelance metal-detector man with a Bulgarian buyer takes a little more before anyone with a permit ever sees it.” He set the glass down. “I don’t take it from the ground. I get to it first. I document it. I conserve it. And yes — I keep some. I keep enough to fund getting to the next thing first. That’s the engine. I won’t insult you by hiding the engine.”

It was a good speech. Naila knew it was a good speech because parts of it were true, and the true parts were carrying the false part the way good cargo hides bad. She set the brochure down on the table between them, face up, the cover with the wrong shadows, and she put her finger on the line.

“The chapter, now substantially closed,” she read.

Reyes looked at it. Looked at her. There was a flicker, brief, of a man recalculating which kind of opponent he had.

“Marketing,” he said. “Honestly. The donor deck writes itself in a register that —”

“Ninety percent,” Naila said. “You’ve dug ten. You’ve read the introduction and you wrote *the story is, in essence, told* on the cover of a fundraising document. You know it’s not. The number’s in your own survey appendix. Page forty. You commissioned the geophysics that proves there are at least nine more enclosures under that slope you just gestured at, and then you printed *substantially closed* on the front.” She wasn’t angry. Anger blurred the count. She was just laying it out, the way you lay out the figures and let the gap speak. “You didn’t write that for the museum. The museum can read page forty. You wrote it for the people who decide whether there’s anything left worth protecting. You wrote *empty* on the door so nobody asks what’s behind it.”

The wind pressed. Cemal had stopped pretending to sleep; his cap was tipped back and he was watching Reyes with the flat ancient

patience of a man whose family had farmed this exact plain since before the word foundation meant a charity.

Reyes did not bluster. That was the third thing Naila hadn't expected. He sat with it. He looked, for a second, genuinely caught, and then — worse — genuinely sad.

"You think I don't love this," he said. "You think because I have an engine I don't —" He stopped. He looked up at the hill. "I started in a museum basement in a country that lost half its heritage to a war I was too young to vote against. We catalogued what we could. We watched the rest go out the back of trucks while men in suits debated jurisdiction. I decided I'd rather be the truck than the debate." He turned the glass again. "If I'm in the ground first, with a camera and a conservator and a numbered tray, then whatever I keep, at least its *provenance* survives. At least we know where it stood and what it stood next to. The man with the Bulgarian buyer doesn't write that down. I do. That's not nothing. In this business that's nearly everything."

"Provenance," Eylül said.

"Provenance," Reyes agreed. "The story of where a thing comes from. Lose it and the object's still beautiful. But it's mute. It can't testify anymore." He almost smiled. "You and I want the same thing, Doctor Demir. I'm just willing to pay for it."

And there it was, Naila thought, the cleanest version of the trap, said by a man who half-believed it: *we want the same thing*. It was nearly true. That was its whole power. He wanted the provenance preserved. He just wanted to *own* it. He'd save the story of where everything stood, and then the story would be his to license, his to lend, his to lock in a friendly-jurisdiction lab and release in the shape that funded the next acquisition. The wonder, catalogued and shelved and *substantially closed*.

Frik, who had been very still, whose head had not jerked in a full minute, which was its own kind of warning, said suddenly, with no run-up, in a voice that came up out of him like water finding a crack: "He believes it. He's lying and he believes it."

Reyes turned to him. Not offended. Curious.

"That's a hell of a trick," Reyes said, gently. "Both at once."

“Ja,” Frik said, and his shoulder hitched, and he looked away. “I know.”

After, when Reyes had gone back down the walkway with his cameraman and his caged drone, Naila stayed at the rocking table and turned the brochure over and over until the gloss came off warm on her thumbs.

“He’s better than I wanted him to be,” she said.

“He’s worse,” Eylül said. She was clearing the glasses again, the ordinary motion. “The cartoon villain you can fight in front of the museum board. *Look, he wants to loot it.* This one shows up with a conservator and a numbered tray and a sad story about a war, and the board thinks, well, at least someone’s *doing* something, the state isn’t, the university isn’t, and the next thing you know there’s a partnership agreement and a portion clause and a man with a key to the ninety percent.” She stacked the last glass. “He’ll get the geophysics first. He probably already has it — he commissioned half of it. He’ll know what’s down there before we do. And the law lets him, because the law was written before there was a thing like this site to protect, and the people who’d rewrite the law have been told the chapter’s closed.”

Mara had picked her camera back up. She hadn’t shot anything. She turned it in her hands, looking at the dark uphill swell where nine more enclosures slept under the dirt, and Naila watched her not lift it to her eye.

“There’s a frame,” Mara said slowly. “Reyes, the empty trays, the drone in the cage, the wrong shadows on the cover. I could make that the most-shared archaeology photo of the year. *The man who’s closing Göbekli Tepe.* It’d run everywhere.” She set the camera down again. “And it’d make him the story. It’d make the *fight* the story. And the second this is a story about a fight, it stops being a story about the hill, and then somebody asks *well what’s even down there, is it worth fighting over*, and the only answer anyone in the room has is —” she nodded at the brochure — *the chapter’s substantially closed.* His sentence wins. Even when I’m using it to attack him, his sentence wins.”

Naila looked at her. This was the thing about Mara that the war had

given her and taken from her in the same motion: she could see the frame, and she could see what the frame would *cost*, and the cost lived in her hands now where the shot used to.

“So we don’t make it about him,” Eylül said. She straightened up with the tray. “We make it about what’s *down there*. We make the ninety percent so loud, so specific, so undeniably *not* closed, that nobody with a vote can pretend it’s empty. We don’t fight the man. We fill the room he wants empty.”

“With what,” Frik said.

Eylül looked at all of them, the system-reader and the truth-teller and the lens-reader, and up the slope, briefly, past the roofed enclosures to the top of the walkway where a man in dark shades stood apart from everything, separate as he’d been all morning, not in the meeting, not in any frame, a shape the cameraman’s gimbal had swung right past as if there were nothing there to catch — and then she looked back at her own people.

“With the truth,” she said. “Which has the advantage of being real. He’s selling *solved*. We have the one thing solved can’t survive. We have the hole.” She set the tray down for the last time and the table didn’t rock, because at some point in the last hour Naila had reached down without noticing and folded the brochure into a wedge and shimmed the leg. “Tomorrow you stop reading the brochure,” Eylül said, “and you come down into the dig. The real one. Mud, diesel, the broken hosepipe, the local crew, my uncle’s tea. And I show you what *substantially closed* actually looks like under a trowel. Then we find out how loud the hole can get.”

She picked up the wedge of brochure to throw it, and stopped, and looked at it — the wrong shadows, the eleven trays, the empty eleventh — and put it in her pocket instead.

“Provenance,” she said, to no one, the way you repeat a word you intend to take back from someone. “He thinks it’s his to keep.”

She went up the slope. The race was on, and it was the quiet kind, the deniable kind, no shots, no shouting, two parties walking toward the same buried ground from opposite directions — and the prize was not gold and not glory but the story of where everything stood, and who got to tell it, and whether it stayed a question worth asking

at all.

Naila put her thumb back on the shimmed leg. Steady now. She left it there a moment, just to feel the thing hold.

Chapter 6 — Mud on the Boots

The brochure had used the word *sîte* like a word for a finished thing. A monument with a gift shop. A place you went to and then had been to.

The real one smelled of diesel.

Naila stood at the lip of the dig at six-forty in the morning and let the smell tell her what the paper had not. Diesel and dust and the green vegetal stink of a hose that had burst somewhere and was watering a patch of nothing into mud. A generator chugged through a hole in its own muffler. Somewhere below the modern shelter roof — a sweep of white tension-fabric the Trust's brochure had photographed at golden hour to look like the wing of an angel and which, up close, was patched with grey tape and sagged in one corner like a tent after rain — a man was shouting in Kurdish at another man about a wheelbarrow.

She counted the wheelbarrows. There were three. Two worked.

"You're counting," Eylül said, beside her, not a question. She had a travel mug of tea in one hand and a clipboard under her arm with a permit clamped to it, the corner of the permit furred soft from being handled, and she was wearing the same boots she'd had on at the awning except now they were the right kind of dirty.

"Two working wheelbarrows," Naila said. "The brochure showed eleven people in clean shirts standing around a pillar. There are nineteen people here and four of them have shovels and the rest are doing paperwork or hose."

“Welcome to substantially closed,” Eylül said, and drank her tea.

The Sanliurfa museum had swallowed them first, the day before — a great cool modern box on the edge of the city where the air conditioning ran like a held breath and the original central pillars of Enclosure D had been reconstructed under proper light, full scale, two stone giants standing in a room built to their height, and Naila had stood in front of them and gone very still and very quiet for eleven minutes, which Mara had measured on her phone and not photographed, because she had asked, and Naila had said *not now*, and Mara had put the phone away without a flicker, which was a thing about Mara that Naila had stopped having to brace for.

Now they were on the hill itself. The reconstructions in the museum had been the clean version, the lit version, the *been to* version.

This was the *is* version.

Eylül took them down a graded path the Trust had laid in pale gravel — *for the visitors who will come*, she said, in a voice with the gravel in it — and the path ended where the gravel ran out and the ground became real, and the real ground was a stepped excavation of packed limestone dust the colour of old bone, terraced in squares, each square a different depth, strung over with white grid-line and labelled with little metal tags, and down in the deepest square the tops of stones stood up out of the earth like the shoulders of people buried to the neck.

Frik made a sound. Not a word. A short hard intake, a tic, his head jerking once toward the stones and then away, and then the word came out of him sideways, the way they did, arriving before he had decided to say anything: “*standing*.”

“Yes,” Eylül said. “Good. Hold that.”

She did that. Naila had clocked it at the awning and clocked it again now — Eylül caught Frik’s blurts and *kept* them, the way you’d catch a coin somebody dropped and hand it back instead of pretending it hadn’t fallen. *Hold that*. As if the thing his body said before his mind caught up was worth keeping. It mostly was. That was the thing nobody who’d thrown him out of rooms his whole life had bothered to find out.

They came down into Enclosure D the way you'd come into a room where someone was sleeping.

It was the oldest. The largest. Eylül said the numbers the way Naila said numbers — flat, exact, no awe layered on because the numbers carried their own. “Radiocarbon puts the oldest construction here around nine thousand five hundred BCE. Eleven and a half thousand years. Six thousand years before Stonehenge. Seven before the pyramids.” She let that sit on the dust for a second. “Built by people who had no pottery, no metal, no wheel, no writing, and no farming. Hunter-gatherers. They built *this* before they grew a single field of wheat. That is not the wild part.”

“That’s not the wild part,” Frik repeated, hungry for the wild part.

“The wild part is what it does to the order.” Eylül crouched by the central pair, the two great pillars Naila had stood under in the museum yesterday, except these were the originals, in the ground, in their place, and they were not the same and Naila felt the not-sameness like a temperature change. “The story we tell ourselves is: first you settle down, then you farm, then you have surplus, then you have time, *then* you build temples and cities and culture. Bread first. Cathedrals later.” She put her hand flat on the dust beside the nearer pillar without touching the stone. “Here it’s backwards. They built the monuments first. The monuments might be *why* they settled down at all. We may have it upside down, the whole arc of how we became us.” She looked up at them. “And it’s not a theory somebody’s selling. It’s the dating. The bread came after.”

Mara had her camera up — she’d asked at the top of the path, and Eylül had said *the stones, yes, not the crew’s faces without I ask them*, and Mara had nodded like that was a clause she’d already written into herself. She was shooting the central pillars now, low, the way you’d shoot a person. Naila watched the way the lens loved them and didn’t trust the love. Mara didn’t either; Naila could tell by how she kept lowering the camera between frames and just *looking*, checking the frame against the thing.

“They’re people,” Mara said, quietly, from behind the camera. Not a question.

“They’re people,” Eylül said. And then she taught them the part the brochure had cropped out.

She walked Naila around to the broad face of the eastern central pillar and there it was, what the museum light had shown clean and the morning sun showed *carved* — the relief, low and deliberate, two arms coming down the sides of the great stone T, bending at the elbow, the forearms turning in across the front, and at the front, meeting over a belt, two hands. Fingers. Individual fingers, splayed and distinct, the way a child draws a hand, except eleven and a half thousand years before children drew anything anyone kept.

“There’s the belt,” Eylül said. “There’s the loincloth — fox pelt, on this one, you can see the brush of the tail. And here.” Her finger hovered, not touching, over a shape low on the shaft. “He’s carrying a fox. Cradling it. In the crook of the arm.”

Frik made the intake sound again and this time the word was “*holding*,” and Eylül said “yes,” and Naila looked at the fox in the stone arms and felt the geometry of it arrive in her like a second sentence laid over Eylül’s.

Because she’d been reading the wrong thing. She’d been reading the pillar as a *shape* — a tall T, a known proportion, a unit. The arms turned it into a body and she hadn’t *felt* the body until the hands. The hands changed the arithmetic. A T-shape was a column. A T-shape with hands meeting over a belt was a *front*. It had a front and therefore a back and therefore it was *facing* something.

“It’s facing inward,” she said.

Eylül turned. The clipboard came down off her hip. “Say that again.”

“The two central ones face each other,” Naila said, because that part was obvious, that was in the museum, that was in the brochure even. “But the others. The ring of pillars around the wall. They’re not random and they’re not all facing the centre either.” She walked it — fast, too fast, the way her feet did when her head had already gone ahead — three steps to the nearest wall-pillar, eyes on the set of its shaft, the slight rotation of its broad face. “This one’s turned. Maybe eight degrees off the radius. And that one —” she pointed across — “the same way, same hand. They’re not facing the centre. They’re facing

slightly *past* it. Like a room full of people all turned a little toward the same —” She stopped. The word wanted to be *door* and there was no door. “Toward the same thing that isn’t there.”

“That’s the geometry,” Eylül said. Carefully. “Tell me the geometry and I’ll tell you the meaning, and we’ll see if they’re the same animal.”

It was an invitation and it was also a fence. Naila understood the fence. *You read the system. I read what it’s for.* She liked the fence. Fences were a kind of clarity.

“The geometry,” she said. “Give me a minute.”

She took the minute on the dirt with the back of an envelope, because Eylül had handed her an actual envelope and a carpenter’s pencil from the clipboard clip, and Naila knelt in the bone-coloured dust with the generator coughing and the burst hose hissing somewhere and the sun coming over the shelter’s torn corner, and she did arithmetic.

Not magic. She wanted to be clear with herself about that, because there was always a temperature in the way people watched her work, a hope that the answer would come down like weather, and it never did. It came down like *sums*. She paced the chord between two wall-pillars and counted her own stride, which she knew to the centimetre because she’d measured it years ago and remeasured it twice. She read the angles off the broad faces by eye and corrected the eye against the grid-string, which the dig crew had laid true to the metre, bless them, true tape and true pegs, a thing the Trust’s brochure had not photographed because clean string is not golden-hour. She did proportions. She held the ring’s diameter in her head and the pillar height beside it and turned them against each other.

What fell out was a measure.

A unit. A length that the spacing of the wall-pillars kept returning to, and the height of the central pair kept returning to, and the offset of the rotated faces kept returning to — not perfectly, nothing in real stone was perfect, but inside the slop you’d expect from hand-tools and eleven and a half thousand years of settling earth. A made measure. Somebody’s cubit. Somebody’s forearm, used as a stick, over and over, until the ring agreed with itself.

“There’s a unit,” she said. “They had a measure. They paced it or stuck it but they *had* one, it’s all over the spacing.” She sat back on her heels. “Which means there was a plan. Before the first stone went vertical, somebody knew the whole shape.”

“Of course there was a plan,” said a voice that was not Eylül’s, and Naila looked up.

Reyes was at the top of the gravel.

He didn’t come down. That was a thing about him she logged and didn’t like the logging of, because it was the kind of thing that made him hard to hate cleanly. He stayed at the gravel’s edge, hands in the pockets of a jacket that cost money and didn’t announce it, the Trust’s cameraman — Sani — a few paces behind him with the camera *down*, pointed at the dirt, obeying. No drone in the sky this morning. Naila had checked. She always checked for the drone now, the small mosquito drag of it at the edge of hearing, and there was none.

“Good morning,” Reyes said, to all of them, to none of them. To Eylül last and longest. “I won’t intrude. I came to see the shelter repaired — the corner. It’s been like that for two seasons. The Heritage Trust will have it fixed this week.” He said it without weight, the way you’d mention picking up milk. “Forgive me. I overheard. A unit of measure.” He looked at Naila with a real attention that she did not enjoy. “You found it fast.”

“It’s not hidden,” she said.

“No,” he agreed. “It’s the kind of thing that’s been hiding in plain sight for thirty years because nobody thought to bring a —” he chose the word, and she heard him choosing it, heard him reject *savant* and reject *expert* — “a fresh set of eyes.” He smiled. Not a salesman’s smile. A tired one. “It’s astonishing, isn’t it. The plan. The competence. People we’ve told ourselves were *primitive* — laying out a structure to a tolerance, to a unit, with a *design*. This is exactly what the Trust exists to protect from being lost.” He nodded once, like a man closing a folder. “I’ll leave you to it. Eylül — the shelter, this week. My word on it.”

He went. Sani went after him, camera down the whole way, and at the very top of the gravel Sani paused and looked back down into

the enclosure — not at the people, at the *stones*, at the central pair standing in their square of morning — and something crossed his face that was not the Trust's, and then he turned and followed his employer up the hill.

Frik said, to the air, in the flat involuntary blurt: "*he wants it.*"

Nobody laughed. Eylül said, "Hold that too."

"He's not lying," Naila said, when the gravel was empty. It bothered her to say it. "About the measure. About the competence. The astonishment's real. That's why it works. He's selling the *true* thing — they were brilliant, they planned, look how brilliant — because if you agree they were brilliant and the brilliance is *finished*, understood, accounted for, then there's nothing left to dig. He's not painting over the truth. He's framing it." She looked at the rotated pillars. "Solved. Catalogued. *Been to.*"

"That's the trick," Eylül said. "You don't have to lie about a hole. You just have to convince everyone it's full."

So Naila pushed at the measure. Because the way you tested whether a hole was full was you put your arm in it.

"The Tas Tepeler," she said. "The Stone Hills. There are other sites. Karahan Tepe. The whole region — what, twenty enclosures here, two hundred pillars, and you've dug —"

"Ten percent," Eylül said. "Of this hill. Less, across the region."

"Then I want to know if the measure travels."

It came out before she'd weighed it. She heard Eylül go still beside her, heard the clipboard not move, and she knew she'd stepped over a line she couldn't see the colour of, because this was Eylül's ground and Eylül's data and Eylül's people's dead, and a stranger had just said *I want* in the middle of it.

"It might," Eylül said, after a beat, evenly. "There are pillar spacings published from Karahan that aren't far off ours. People have noticed. Nobody's proven a shared standard. It's the kind of thing —" and here she did the thing she'd done at the awning, she handed it back

without softening it — “that an outsider with a clean eye might see and an outsider with a clean eye might also see because they *want* to see a pattern. You understand. The plain is full of people who came here and found exactly the connected, designed, single-author secret they brought with them in their luggage.” She let that land. “I’m not saying you’re one of them. I’m saying the measure travelling is the most seductive sentence anybody’s said on this hill, and the moment you fall in love with it you stop checking it.”

Naila felt the rebuke and felt, under it, the respect, because Eylül had said it *to her face* as a colleague and not around her as a problem, and those were different countries and she’d lived in both.

“Then I check it,” Naila said. “I don’t fall in love with it. I check it.”

“That,” Eylül said, “is the only sentence I trust on this hill.”

It hung between them, the maybe, the same forearm laid down across sites that shouldn’t have shared a builder, eleven and a half thousand years gone. Naila did not pick it up. She set it on the dust where Eylül had set the brochure-wedge, a thing to come back to, a thing that might be nothing.

Then Eylül did the part Naila hadn’t earned and was given anyway. She crouched again by the eastern central pillar, by the fox-pelt belt and the cradled fox and the splayed stone fingers, and she said, low, in the voice she used for her own:

“You ask *what is it for*. All of you ask it, your whole —” she gestured up the hill, vaguely, at the absent shape of the man who’d shipped the Beast and stood apart, the one who’d asked it first. “He asks it. I’ll tell you what my uncle says, sitting under his awning, when the tourists are gone. He says: it’s where you stand with them. The dead. The ones who watched you. You came in from the hunt and the cold and the dying and you came *here* and you stood in a ring of your great stone people, your ancestors made tall, fingers and belt and fox, and you weren’t alone in the dark anymore. The animals carved on them — the lions, the vultures, the scorpions, the snakes — those are the dangers. They’re on the dead because the dead came through the dangers and *they’re still standing*. You stood with them. That’s the function.” She looked up. “Not a temple. Not a calendar. Not an

observatory, not aliens, not a power plant. A place the living came to stand with the watching dead and not be alone. And maybe —” and here her voice did not rise, it *steadied*, which was worse, which was bigger — “maybe the standing-together is the thing that made us stay. You don’t go back to the wandering when you’ve built your dead a house. You stay near them. You stay, and you stay, and the wheat that’s growing wild around the place you can’t leave starts looking like a thing you might keep. The cathedral first. The bread because of the cathedral.”

Nobody said anything. The hose hissed. Frik’s hand jumped once and was still and he didn’t blurt, which Naila understood, by now, to be its own kind of held breath in him.

“That’s not proven,” Eylül said, and stood, and brushed the dust off her knees, and was the archaeologist again. “Don’t quote me proving it. It’s where the evidence is *pointing* and the gathering-to-build driving the farming is a live, serious question with real people fighting about it in real journals. The astonishment’s allowed. The certainty isn’t.”

“The astonishment’s allowed,” Frik said, getting it, banking it.

Naila stayed crouched a moment longer after the others moved off toward Cemal’s awning and the tea, where the old man would be awake now and the second tray would be true to the first and the world would be ordinary for an hour.

She looked at the measure on the back of her envelope. She looked at the rotated faces of the wall-pillars, all turned eight-or-so degrees, all looking slightly past the centre at the thing that wasn’t there. She thought about a ring of people built to a single forearm, and she thought — carefully, checking herself, not falling in love with it — about the spacings published from a hill an hour east that weren’t far off these.

She’d come here thinking the geometry would close the place. A measure would mean a plan would mean an answer would mean *been to*. That was Reyes’s arithmetic and she’d nearly done it for him.

But the measure didn’t close anything. The measure said *somebody decided*. And a decision, eleven and a half thousand years old, made by people the brochure had called primitive, to lay out the dead to

a standard and turn them all to face the same absent point — that wasn't a full hole.

That was a door she'd just measured the frame of.

She stood, and folded the envelope, and put it in the pocket where the unit now lived, and went up the slope toward the tea, the diesel at her back, the standing people behind her in the dust still facing the thing that wasn't there — and tomorrow, she thought, the city. The bazaar. Eylül said there were tools in the Urfa market a man named Cemal's brother kept, the old carving stuff, and they'd go in among the stalls and the crowds and the no-exits-anywhere, and she'd hold the unit in her head where it was quiet, and walk in.

Chapter 7 — The Bazaar

Naila had a plan for the bazaar and the plan was numbers.

She built it in the car on the way in, while Eylül drove and Cemal's nephew rode shotgun naming streets, while Frik in the back seat did the thing he did with the seatbelt clip — *click, hold, click* — and Mara watched the city assemble itself out of the dust the way Mara watched everything, like the world had to earn the lens.

The plan was: the unit. The forearm. Fifty-two centimetres, give or take the give-or-take of a thing measured off eleven-and-a-half-thousand-year-old stone with a builder's tape and an envelope. She would carry the unit in her head where it was quiet and she would lay it down on the city like a grid. A stall was so many units wide. An aisle was so many units across. The distance from where she stood to the nearest place a body could get out — *that* was the number that mattered, and she would keep it, and as long as she could keep it the rest could roar.

That was the plan.

The bazaar did not care about her plan.

Sanliurfa's covered market is older than most countries and it does not run on metres. It runs on the logic of a place that grew the way frost grows on a window, branch from branch, no architect, fifteen-some hans and bedestens grown together over five hundred years into one breathing organism of vault and shade and noise. The *çarşı*. Coppersmiths in one artery, hammers going in eight-four time against the brass, *bang-bang-bang*, a sound with a floor under it. Then the spice han, and the air going thick and red, cumin and dried mint and the bright orange of isot pepper in barrels. Then

cloth. Then a tea-house with old men and dominoes and a television. Then — without a seam, without a door, without a single place the eye could rest on an edge — more.

Naila got eleven steps in and lost the unit.

It didn't fall. It dissolved. One second she had the number, the clean fifty-two, the grid laying itself down obedient over the stone floor, and then a man went past her with a hand-truck stacked six high with copper trays and the trays sang against each other, a long bright skidding chord, and a boy on the other side shouted a price, and the price collided in the air with the call to prayer starting up somewhere outside and arriving here filtered through three hundred metres of vaulted stone so it came from no direction, came from the ceiling, came from the floor —

and the grid was gone, and she was standing in the middle of an aisle with no number for the exit and no exit she could see and forty bodies moving in four directions and not one straight line anywhere to hang onto.

Her hand found the seam of her own trousers. Pressed. The seam was a straight line. She kept the seam.

Count the colours. That was a different plan, a backup, older, from before the crew, from years of doing this alone in worse places than this. Count something. Take the roar and give it edges by counting. Red. The isot in the barrels, red. The cloth, red. A boy's football shirt, red. The dried peppers strung overhead like — no. Don't make pictures. Pictures use too much. Just the count. Red, that's four. Five. The roar pressed in on the count and the count thinned out like paper getting wet and she knew, with the cold flat knowing she had about this, that the count was going to fail too, in about thirty seconds, and then there would be the part she did not narrate to anyone, the part where the volume of the world exceeded the size of her, and her body would start doing what it did, and she would be — in a market, in a country, in front of the people whose good opinion she had decided without telling anyone she wanted —

a problem to manage.

She got ready to be a problem to manage. She'd had the practice.

A hand came down on her shoulder. Not a grab. A weight. Set there,

deliberate, the way you set a stone down — and it stayed, and it was warm through her shirt, and a voice that had been in the car all morning said, behind her, low, not into the noise but into the small dead space the hand made between them:

“Tergan.” Eylül. “Look at my collar.”

Naila looked at Eylül’s collar. It was a denim collar, work-faded, with a thread coming loose at the point of it, one single thread, hanging maybe two centimetres, straight down.

A straight line.

“There’s a tea-house thirty steps back the way we came,” Eylül said, conversational, like she was discussing tools, like nothing was happening, because to anyone watching nothing was. “Cemal’s brother is two doors past it. There’s a chair against the back wall, the wall’s stone, it’s cool, it’s been there four hundred years and it is not going anywhere. You don’t have to go in among the stalls. You sit at the back wall. I’ll bring the tools out to you. Frik wants to look at saws and I’d genuinely rather he didn’t do it alone.”

Thirty steps. A number. Eylül had given her a number.

“Thirty,” Naila said. Her own voice came out level and she was distantly amazed by it.

“Give or take,” Eylül said. “I’m not great with my unit either.”

And that — the dry little joke, *unit*, handed back to her like a coin, the geometry of yesterday turned into a thing two people now shared — that did something the count never could. Naila got one full breath in under the roar.

Then Frik was there. Frik had come back through the crowd against the grain of it, shoulders going, head ducking on the tic, and he didn’t ask what was wrong and he didn’t soften his face the way strangers softened their faces, the look she hated worst of all, the *oh you poor* look. He just arrived, and his hand went up and tapped the air twice by his own temple — *click, click*, the seatbelt gesture, except now it wasn’t the seatbelt, now it was a thing he was offering her — and he said, fast, blurted, the words coming out the side of the tic:

“Too loud. *Too loud*. It’s too loud, it’s not you, it’s just *loud*.”

It was the truest thing anyone had said to her in years.

It's not you. It's just loud.

Naila's whole body, which had been getting ready to fail, paused. Hung. Reconsidered. Because Frik did not say comforting things. Frik's particular wiring would not *let* him say a comforting thing if it wasn't true — that was the cost he paid and the gift it left, his body coughed up the real thing whether he wanted it to or not — and so when Frik said *it's not you, it's just loud*, it was not comfort. It was a finding. It was data. A man whose nervous system could not lie had just measured the situation and reported the result, and the result was: the fault is in the building, not in you.

She believed him because he couldn't have been being kind.

"Thirty steps," Eylül said again, and turned, and Naila followed the loose thread on her collar — kept her eyes on that one straight hanging line and nothing else — back the way they'd come, against a current of bodies that parted because Eylül walked like she owned the floor and on her own ground she did. The roar did not stop. But it stopped being *hers*. It went back to being the building's. Thirty steps later there was a chair against four hundred years of stone and the stone was cool and Naila put her back against it and the wall did not move, would not move, had outlasted six empires and was not going to flinch now, and she pressed her shoulder blades into eleven thousand years of human persistence and breathed.

Mara had hung back at the mouth of the aisle.

She'd seen the whole thing — the dissolve, the hand on the shoulder, the loose thread, Frik coming back through the grain — and her own hands had gone, by themselves, without permission, to the camera at her hip. Twenty years of reflex. The frame was *right there*. Naila against the ancient wall, lit from one high window in the vault, the dust hanging gold in the light-shaft, a woman holding herself together with her back to four hundred years of stone. It would have been a hell of a photograph. It would have been the kind of photograph that made her name once, the kind that won the prizes and ran full-bleed and got described in the citation as *unflinching*.

She took her hand off the camera.

Not this one. This one was not hers to take. Naila's worst thirty sec-

onds was not Mara's to keep and crop and put in a book. There was a version of Mara, a younger version, who'd have shot it and called it honesty, and she'd have been lying — that frame wasn't witness, that frame was theft dressed as compassion, and Mara knew the difference now in her body, the way you know a coming migraine, a particular wrongness in the hands. She let the wrongness pass. She did not lift the camera. She turned around and faced the market instead, to give Naila the privacy of an unwatched recovery, and that — looking away from the picture, putting her back to the best shot in the room — was a thing she'd had to learn the hard way and was still learning.

So she was facing the wrong way, the away-from-Naila way, the working-against-her-own-instinct way, when she saw the other thing.

It was nothing. That was how the real ones always came — as nothing.

Across the wide hub where four arteries of the market met, in the angled shade by a kuyumcu's gold-shop window, two men were not buying anything. Mara's whole career had been built on the trained noticing of people who were not doing what everyone around them was doing. In a market, everyone is selling or buying or moving through. These two were doing none of it. They stood in the dead corner the foot-traffic flowed around, the way water flows around a stone, and one of them was Turkish, suited too well for here, soft hands, a man who'd come from somewhere with air-conditioning; and the other was local, a fixer's face, the face of a man who knew which doors opened, and between them, low, at waist height, in the shade, there was a transaction.

Not money on a counter. Money in an envelope — thick, a brick of it, banded — going from the soft-handed man's jacket to a leather satchel the local held open, and the local's eyes never stopped moving while it happened, checking the angles, checking who saw, and his eyes slid over Mara and registered: tourist, camera, harmless, looking the wrong way.

Mara's hands were already up. Twenty years. The camera was at her eye before her conscience caught it, and her conscience — the new conscience, the consent one, the one she'd been building plank by plank since the day she couldn't lift the camera at the war — her conscience said: *you don't have permission, you don't know what*

this is, put it down.

And the old one, the one that had made her name, said: *that is a brick of cash changing hands in shadow and your gut has never once been wrong about a brick of cash changing hands in shadow.*

She compromised the way she'd learned to. She did not frame the men. She did not steal their faces for a story she didn't have. She lifted the camera as if she were a tourist photographing the *architecture* — the magnificent stone vault above the hub, the light-shaft, the four-hundred-year-old fan of the ceiling, a frame any visitor would take — and she let the transaction sit small and incidental in the bottom corner of it, the way it sat small and incidental in the real life of the market, present but not the subject, and she pressed the shutter twice, on the *ceiling*, and lowered the camera, and turned away.

She told herself it was the ceiling.

She nearly believed it.

Naila got the unit back in about ten minutes.

It came back the way it always came back, not all at once but in working order — the wall behind her holding still long enough for the world to stop being a flood and start being a sequence again, one thing and then the next thing, edges returning to the objects. She found she could count the dominoes clicking in the tea-house two doors down. Six players. Three games. Sixty tiles. The number behaved.

Eylül came out of the tool-shop carrying a flat wooden tray and set it on the low table by the back-wall chair without ceremony, without checking Naila's face, which was the kindest thing she could have done — treating her as recovered the instant she sat down, not a patient, a colleague who'd stepped out for air.

"Cemal's brother," Eylül said, jerking her head at the shop. "Bekir. He keeps the old carving stuff because nobody buys it but he can't bring himself to stop stocking it. Look at this."

On the tray were stone tools. Not antiques — replicas, working ones, the kind the experimental-archaeology people commissioned when they tried, every few years, to answer the question that had been

needling at Naila since the slope. Flint blades hafted into wood. A heavy fist-sized hammerstone, a river cobble, dense, dark. A long thin punch of harder stone.

"They tried it," Eylül said, watching her see it. "The replica. The carving. Bekir's nephew did a forearm on a limestone block with tools like these for a German film crew. The relief arm. The fingers."

"How long," Naila said. The number was the question. The number was always the question.

"For one arm? The bend of the elbow and the hand with the five fingers, on soft local limestone, a man who knew what he was doing?" Eylül lifted the hammerstone, turned it. "Weeks. And that's one arm on a block lying flat on a table at chest height in a workshop with coffee. Now stand the block up. Make it five and a half metres. Eight tonnes. Make it forty kilometres from the limestone bed it came out of. Make it before the wheel, before metal, before a single domesticated grain of wheat exists anywhere on earth to feed the man swinging the stone. And then make twenty of these. In a ring. To a standard."

The arithmetic ran in Naila clean and cold and did the thing it did, which was not make the place smaller but make it *enormous*. She picked up the hammerstone. It was heavier than it looked. She set the flint blade against the wooden tray-edge and drew it, once, and it bit — barely, a pale scratch — and she thought about a man drawing that line ten thousand times to bend one stone elbow, and the wonder went up through her like cold water.

"People say impossible," she said.

"People say impossible," Eylül agreed, "and then the people who actually do the work say —"

"— seven to fourteen." Banning's number. The labour figure she'd carried in since before the dig, the corrective she kept like a tool of her own, because the *impossible* was a lie that helped Reyes and the *easy* was a lie that helped him more. "Seven to fourteen people, ropes, a greased track. You don't need a lost super-race to move the pillar. The moving's hard but it's *human* hard. It's the *deciding* that's —" She stopped. The deciding was the door she'd measured the frame of yesterday and she wasn't going to walk through it in a

tea-house with the unit still wet.

“That,” Eylül said, “is the right place to stop.” And there it was again, the boundary, gentle and absolute: *you do the deciding-is-hard, the deciding itself is mine*. Naila found she didn’t mind the wall. She’d spent a life being handed places where her reading wasn’t wanted at all. A wall that said *this far, your part, then mine* was the most respect she’d been shown in months.

Frik came out of the shop holding a stone punch and not buying it, turning it over, and his tic took him — head, shoulder — and then the blurt came, aimed at nobody, aimed at the tray:

“They didn’t *have* to. *Didn’t have to.*” The shoulder again. “Nobody made them. Nobody — there’s no king, there’s no — *didn’t have to* and they *did.*”

Which was the whole thing. Which was the thing Naila had been circling and Frik’s wiring had just coughed up whole and unguarded, the way it coughed up the true thing it couldn’t help: no boss, no pharaoh, no surplus, no granary, no compulsion anyone has ever found — a thousand people, the labour says, gathering on a hill to raise the dead in stone for no reason a power-structure can explain, and from that gathering, maybe, *us*. Frik said *didn’t have to* and the hill got bigger again.

Eylül looked at Frik for a second with something close to respect. “No,” she said. “They didn’t have to.” And she left it there, and didn’t add the rest, the rest being hers.

They drove back as the light went long.

Naila sat in the front, the tray of stone tools wrapped in cloth across her knees — Bekir had pressed the hammerstone on her, refused money, *take it, you’ll carve nothing with it, keep it*, a thing she had not known how to receive and Eylül had received for her. The unit was back, solid, fifty-two centimetres laying itself quiet over the road. The market was behind her. It had not made her a problem to manage. That was the thing she turned over and could not stop turning: it had been bad, it had been the bad thing, and it had not, this time, cost her the room.

It was Mara who broke it, from the back.

“I need to show you something.” Her voice had a wrongness in it Naila knew from her own body, the wrongness of a thing done that maybe shouldn’t have been. “I took a photo I didn’t mean to take.”

She’d been going through the cards on the laptop, the way she always did, the ritual checking, *did I steal anything I shouldn’t have today* — and she’d come to the two ceiling frames, the architecture frames, the ones she’d told herself were architecture, and she’d zoomed, by habit, into the bottom corner. The small incidental thing. The transaction.

She turned the laptop around so they could see it in the failing light, the vault, the gold dust, the two men in the dead corner with the brick of cash between them — and she’d zoomed past the money now, past the satchel, up to the soft-handed man’s face, the one who’d come from somewhere with air-conditioning, caught three-quarter and sharp in the shaft of window-light, a face that meant nothing to Mara, a face she’d photographed by accident while pretending to shoot a ceiling.

“I don’t know who he is,” Mara said. “But I know that’s a lot of money, and I know it changed hands in the dark, and I —”

From the back seat, Frik went still. Then his shoulder pulled, and his head ducked, and his body did its involuntary work, looking at the face on the screen, and what it coughed up — flat, fast, certain, the truth arriving sideways through the tic before anyone could stop it or take it back — was a name.

Chapter 8 — Vultures

The name hung in the truck for a second longer than a name should, the way a thing does when nobody knows yet whether it's a key or a grenade, and then Eylül said, quietly, "Tomorrow. We go up tomorrow. Not tonight," and started the engine, and the plain swallowed the rest of it into dust and headlights and the long flat dark of the drive back.

So Mara did not sleep, and in the morning she went up the hill with the laptop closed in her bag like a held breath and the cameras around her neck like the tools they were supposed to be.

—

You came up to Göbekli Tepe and the first thing the place did was refuse to be impressive. That was the part nobody put in the foundation's promo film, with its drone sweeps and its swelling strings and the slow gold light it must have cost somebody a permit and three good mornings to steal. The real thing was a low rise on a treeless plateau, the colour of a biscuit, with a tensioned-fabric roof slung over it on steel legs to keep the rain off the stones, and the roof made the whole site look like a regional airport that had given up. You climbed the boardwalk. You smelled hot dust and diesel from the generator and the specific sun-baked plastic of the canopy. You heard the wind and a Turkish radio somewhere down by the visitor centre playing something with too much synth in it.

And then you looked down into the enclosure, and the place stopped pretending.

Mara had stood at the edge of a lot of holes in the world. She knew the difference between a thing that performed depth and a thing that had it. This one had it. Two pillars stood in the centre of the great

oval ring, taller than three men, the colour of old bone, and even from up on the walkway, even before Eylül said a single word, you could see they were not pillars. The crossbar at the top sat like a head turned away. The shaft was a body. Down the long front of one of them ran an arm in low relief, bent at the elbow exactly where an elbow bends, the forearm coming round the side, and a hand at the end of it with fingers — five of them, carved separate, the way a child draws a hand and the way a hand actually is — spread across the stone belt at the waist as if the figure were resting its palm there, the way you'd rest your hand on your own belt, the way a man stands when he is waiting and easy and very old.

"Pillar 31," Eylül said. She'd come up beside Mara without sound. "And the other is 18. The two in the middle of every enclosure, the big pair, they face the same way. East. They are the ones the whole ring is built to attend. Around the inside wall there are more, smaller, standing in toward them. Like —" She stopped, and chose. "Like a gathering, turned to face the two who matter."

"They're people," Mara said.

"They are people," Eylül said. "Schmidt saw it early. The arms, the hands, the belt. Eighteen wears a fox-pelt at the loincloth, carved, and it cradles a fox here, in the crook of the arm. Not a god with a name we can recover. Not a king. But — people. Big ones. The dead, maybe. The ancestors. We don't agree on which. We agree that they are *somebody*."

Frik had come to the rail on Mara's other side and was holding it, and his head ducked once, and he said, low, not to anyone, "Hello." Then again, softer, an echo of his own word, "hello, hello," the tic running the greeting out like a stone skipping, and nobody turned to look at him, and Mara understood that this was correct, that you greeted them, that the body that couldn't lie had simply said the only true thing there was to say to two carved humans eleven thousand five hundred years dead, which was hello.

—

Naila had not spoken. She stood a little apart with her hands loose and her eyes moving along the ring of stones the way Mara's eyes moved along a contact sheet, fast, then stopping, then going back. After a while she said, to the air, "The spacing isn't random."

“No,” Eylül said.

“The two centre pillars, the gap between them, that distance repeats. The smaller pillars on the wall, they’re set off that same measure. And —” Naila tilted her head, and her hands came up and made a small shape, a width, the unit she carried in her body the way some people carry a tune. “It’s the same proportion they used at Karahan Tepe. I read the survey on the flight. Different hill. Different enclosure. Same belt. Same elbow. Same gap. People who never met, who were born and died centuries apart, on hills you can’t see one from the other, used the *same ruler*.”

Eylül looked at her for a moment, and Mara saw the look, because reading looks was the job — it was the look of an expert hearing an outsider get something genuinely right and deciding, in real time, how much to give back. “The Taş Tepeler,” Eylül said. “The Stone Hills. There are maybe twenty enclosures here at Göbekli alone. Two hundred pillars. And we have excavated —” she held up a hand and pinched a sliver of air “— that much. Ten percent. The rest is under the ground we’re standing on. And there are more hills. Karahan. Sayburç. A dozen we’ve only walked over with instruments. A whole — country of this. We’ve barely knocked.”

“And they share a measure,” Naila said.

“Some of them seem to. Yes.”

“Across sites that shouldn’t share one.”

“Naila,” Eylül said, gently, and it was a full sentence, that *Naila*. It meant: I see the door you are opening, and it is a real door, and I am not going to let you walk through it into the place where outsiders go when a thing is too big, the place with the spaceships in it. “We don’t know how the measure travelled. People walked. People remembered. People taught. That is already strange enough to keep me up at night. Leave it strange. Don’t make it into magic.”

Naila’s jaw worked. Then she nodded, once, the nod she gave when an argument had actually landed and not just bounced off her. “It’s strange enough,” she agreed, and let it go, and Mara watched her let it go and thought it cost her something, the letting-go, and thought it was the bravest small thing she’d see all day, and was wrong about that, but only just.

—

They went down into the enclosure proper, on the inner walkway, close enough now to see the carving on the stone, and this was where the place reached up and took you by the throat.

Because the pillars were not bare. The big quiet humans wore animals. And not the animals you'd put on a thing if you wanted it loved — no lambs, no does, nothing soft. Boars with their tusks out and their hackles up. A lion coming down a shaft head-first, claws spread. Snakes, dozens of them, poured down the stone in waves. A scorpion, tail cocked. An aurochs, that vanished wild ox, twice the bull we have now, head lowered to charge. The whole bestiary of everything on that plain that could open you up and kill you.

And the birds.

"Vultures," Eylül said.

There were two on the one she pointed to, big-winged, the unmistakable bald-headed hunch of them, and on a famous slab Mara had seen in books and which they did not let you near now, there was a vulture with one wing held out flat, and balanced on that outstretched wing, a small ball. A circle. And beneath the bird, a human figure with no head.

"That panel's not in this enclosure," Eylül said, watching Mara's face find it in memory. "But you know it. Everyone knows it. The vulture, the wing, the round thing — a head? A sun? — and the man without one. And people look at that and they want it to *say something*. They want a sentence."

"Excarnation," Naila said.

"That's the careful word for the idea, yes." Eylül crouched at the rail so she was level with the carved boar, and the four of them came down with her, instinctively, the way you lower your voice in a particular kind of building. "Sky burial. In a lot of places, across a lot of human history, you don't bury your dead in the ground straight away. You put them out. On a platform, a high place. And the birds come. The vultures take the flesh, and what they leave is clean, and the bone is what you keep, and bury, and carry, and stand before. And vultures —" she looked up at the carved bird, the patient terrible bald head of it — "a vulture isn't a horror, if that's your world. A vulture is the

one who carries the dead up. Who turns the body back into sky. The ferryman.”

Frik’s shoulder pulled. “Carries them up,” he said, flat, the echo. Then, lower, the involuntary engine of him finding the true thing under the sentence and saying it before he could stop it: “*we eat the dead too.*” His face did the thing it did after, the small private bracing for the room to turn on him. Nobody turned. Mara watched Eylül take the blurted truth in and use it, the way the good ones did.

“That’s exactly the thought the carving won’t let you off the hook of,” Eylül said to him, evenly, as if he’d said it in a seminar and meant to. “Yes. The birds eat the dead. And these people carved the birds, big, in the most important room they ever made, and stood their giant ancestors in the middle of it. So whatever death was to them, it wasn’t a thing to hide. It was the centre.”

She stood. She put her hand on the rail, near the carved boar, not touching the stone — you never touched the stone — and she said the thing Mara would carry down off the hill and into the rest of her life.

“We don’t know,” Eylül said. “We don’t get the sentence. The man with no head — is it a real practice they did here? A myth they told? A particular dead person, somebody they all knew, the founder, the killed one? Is the round thing on the wing his soul going up, or is it just how you carve a man losing his head, or is it the sun? I have read forty papers that each pick one and build a castle on it. I’ll read forty more. The honest answer is the one nobody publishes loudly, because it doesn’t fund a dig.” She looked at the headless figure across the enclosure, in the bright dust, under the airport roof. “We know they put the birds at the centre. We know the centre is people. We know they did it before farming, before pots, before the wheel, before writing, before any of the things we tell our children you need before you can build something this size. The rest is theirs. They took it with them.”

—

This was the part the foundation’s film would have ruined, and Mara knew it, because the film would have put a voice over it saying *but what if*, and a graphic of a star-map, and a man in a good shirt asking why mainstream archaeology was *afraid* of the truth, and the whole

enormous real thing — that human beings with flint and patience had quarried a ten-tonne person out of bedrock and stood it up to face the dawn six thousand years before anyone built the pyramids — would have been made smaller, made into a riddle for the man in the good shirt to be cleverer than.

It didn't need him. That was the thing. The hole was real without him.

"Show me how they raised it," she said, because she had to ask one true question to hold herself together, and Naila answered before Eylül could, because Naila had clearly been waiting for someone to be wrong about it.

"People say it's impossible," Naila said. "Ten tonnes, no machines, no draft animals — they want it to be impossible, because impossible is exciting and impossible needs a saviour with a spaceship. It's not impossible. Banning ran the numbers. With ropes and a track you lubricate, and a lever crew, you're talking seven to fourteen people to move one. Fourteen. You could field that from one big family." She looked down at the pillar, at the bent arm, the spread fingers. "That's not the hard part. The hard part is the carving. The hard part is that fourteen people had to *agree* — to stop hunting, to feed each other while nobody hunted, to haul this thing and dress this stone for weeks, for a thing that doesn't feed anyone, that they couldn't eat, in a world where everyone was one bad week from starving. The labour's possible. The *wanting it that much* — that's the impossible thing. And they did it anyway."

"Try it, then," Frik said, and it wasn't a tic this time, it was Frik, dry, the actual man. "Get fourteen okes from the visitor centre and a rope and a nice slippery plank. Have a go. Daylight. Good plan. Modern boots." His shoulder jumped. "*Couldn't do it.*"

"We couldn't," Eylül agreed, and almost smiled. "People have tried, you know. Replicas. Smaller ones. With a crew that knows what's coming and wants the experiment to work, and a forklift on standby, and lunch. It is *brutally* hard. And then you stand under the real one, which they made the worst possible way, the first way anyone ever made anything this big, with no example to copy because there was no example, anywhere on Earth —"

She didn't finish it. She didn't have to. Mara had her hand on the camera. She had had her hand on the camera for some time.

—

Here was the frame.

Mara saw it whole, the way she used to see them, the way that had once made her name and then, in a white room in another country, made her put the cameras down for a year: Eylül crouched at the rail with the carved vulture rising behind her on the bone-coloured stone, the bald head of the bird hanging over the head of the living woman, the headless figure in the dust beyond, the light coming low and gold under the lip of the roof exactly the way the foundation paid for and could not get. Eylül's face open and unguarded, mid-sentence, talking to her dead. The Kurdish archaeologist and the eleven-thousand-year-old vulture and the man with no head, in one column of light.

It would run everywhere. She knew exactly how it would run. It would run with a headline that said something about the ancients and the birds and the secret of death, and it would be on the cover of the kind of magazine that had once flown her to the worst places on Earth, and it would have her name in nine-point type along the gutter, *Voss*, the way her name used to live along the gutter of images of things much worse than this. It would make this real to a million people. It would make this *hers*.

And it would make Eylül into a face on the cover of a death-secret. It would make her grief — because that crouch was grief, that gentleness toward the headless man was grief, Mara had photographed enough grief to know it without a translator — into content. It would put the vulture and the soft open face together in a frame that *said a sentence*, the one Eylül had just spent twenty minutes refusing to say, the one the place didn't get to have. It would caption these people. It would hand the man in the good shirt his riddle. It would take the *we don't know* and sell it as a *we found out*, and the foundation — the soft-handed man whose name was now a grenade in her bag — the foundation would love it most of all, because *mystery solved, move along, nothing left to protect* was the exact lie they were buying the unopened ninety percent with.

The shot that made her name would help them strip the hill.

Mara's finger was on the shutter. Her hands were very steady. Her hands were always steady; that was the trouble, that was what the

white room had been about, the steadiness that didn't stop when it should, the body that could keep lifting the camera after the soul had walked out of the room and left it.

She thought about the bazaar yesterday, Naila against the old wall, the unbearable photograph she had not taken.

"Eylül," she said. Her voice came out level. "Can I make a picture of the pillar? The bird, the carving. Not you. The stone."

Eylül looked up at her, and something moved across her face — surprise, then a recognition, then a kind of thanks she didn't say out loud, because to say it out loud would have made the not-asking the normal thing and the asking the favour, and she would never let it sit that way round on her own hill. "Yes," she said simply. "The stone. Of course."

So Mara stood, and stepped left, and let the living woman fall out of the frame entirely, and waited for Eylül to rise and move so that the crouch and the open face and the grief went with her, out of the light, back into the privacy of the woman doing her work. And then it was only the stone. The vulture. The bent arm and the fingered hand on the belt. The man without his head, eleven and a half thousand years patient in the dust. She made the photograph small and exact and true, the carving and only the carving, the thing that documented the hole without stealing the people standing at the edge of it. She made it for the hill and not for the gutter. It would not be on any cover. It would not have her name down the side.

It was the best decision she had ever made with a camera, and she knew it the way you know a thing in the body before you know it in the head, and the knowing came without relief and without applause, just the small clean click of a door she could finally close.

She lowered the camera.

Down the boardwalk, at the far rail where the wind came over the lip of the plateau, a man in dark glasses stood with his back to all of them, very still, watching the road below — the one road in, the dust of it, a car a long way off coming up from the plain — and the low gold light was on him and Mara's eye found him out of habit and framed him out of habit and her finger never moved, because some part of her had already understood, days ago, in another country, that there

was no use lifting it for that one; the camera simply would not hold him; he was the kind of thing that left no clean frame.

“Whose car,” Naila said, beside her, reading the dust the way she read the stones.

Frik’s head ducked. The truth came up through him before the question had even finished, flat and certain, a name surfacing for the second time in two days, and this time nobody flinched, because this time they’d been waiting for it.

“Reyes,” he said.

And down on the hill, in the centre of the great oval ring, the two carved people stood and faced the east and the coming dust the way they had faced it through every sunrise since before the first seed was ever planted on Earth — waiting, easy, hands resting on their belts — for whatever the living were going to do next.

Chapter 9 — Did They Bury It

The meeting was in the dig-house common room, which was a portable cabin the colour of old teeth with a window-unit air conditioner that did not so much cool the air as redistribute its misery. Frik counted the people coming in. He always counted. Twenty-two chairs, somebody had said, plastic ones stacked in the corner of the equipment shed and carried over two at a time, and there were going to be more than twenty-two bodies, which meant some would stand at the back by the urn of tea, and standing-room-only was a thing that lived in Frik's shoulders like a current, because in a packed room your body was a sound nobody had asked for and there were always more ears.

He took a chair at the end of the second row, on the aisle, near the door. Near the door was a thing he did without deciding to. Naila took the chair beside him and turned it a few degrees so it pointed at the wall rather than the front, and nobody told her not to. Mara sat on his other side with her camera in her lap, lens cap on, hands folded over it like a person keeping a small animal calm.

"Lots of people," Naila said. Not anxious. Inventorying.

"Twenty-six and counting," Frik said, and his neck pulled, a quick hard tug to the left and back, the kind that made the muscle ache by evening. He let it pull. Fighting it cost more than the tic did.

Eylül was up front with her uncle Cemal, who had brought a tray of glasses and was setting them out on the trestle table with the gravity of a man laying out something that mattered, which it was, because the tea was the ground here, the tea was the thing that said *you are in*

our house even if the house is a German foundation's prefab. Cemal poured. The steam went up. Outside the one window the light was going long and gold over the plain, the same plain the carved people on the hill had been looking at for eleven and a half thousand years, and a generator somewhere chugged under everything like a heart that needed work.

The Trust had brought their own water. Bottles. Branded. *Anatolia Heritage Trust*, a clean sans-serif and a little gold ibex, on a side table all their own, and Frik looked at the water and his stomach did the thing it did near a polished lie.

Anton Reyes came in last, which was a choice, and shook hands on the way, which was also a choice, and the handshakes were good — warm, two-handed, the left coming up to cup the elbow — and Frik watched him do it and understood that the man meant them. That was the part nobody believed when Frik said it later: Reyes meant the handshakes. He wasn't a snake oiling people. He was a man who genuinely loved this. That was worse.

"Friends," Reyes said, when he was at the front, and he had a voice like a good radio, low and unhurried. "Thank you for coming. I know this is your supper hour."

Cemal said something in Kurdish to the man beside him and the man laughed quietly. Eylül did not laugh. She stood near her uncle with her arms folded and her field clothes still grey at the knees from the trench, and Frik watched the line of her jaw and thought, *she has done this before, this exact meeting, with a different glossy man.*

"I'll be brief, because I respect that you've all read more about this hill than I ever will." Reyes smiled. Self-deprecation was a tool and he used it cleanly. "The Trust isn't here to dig. Let me say that first and plainly, because rumours travel faster than facts on this plain — I'd know, I'm a rumour myself by now." A ripple of real laughter. He had them. "We're here to *protect*. That's the whole of it. There are enclosures out under that slope that no spade has touched and no roof has covered, and every winter the rain takes a little more of them, and the local team — and I will say this in front of Eylül, who knows it better than anyone — the local team does not have the budget to save what's already cracking, let alone what's still buried."

Frik felt the tic build in his diaphragm, a pressure, a held breath want-

ing to become a sound. He breathed it down. Not yet. There was nothing yet. The man hadn't said the thing yet.

"And here's the good news," Reyes went on, and now he opened his hands, generous, *I am about to give you something*. "The science is largely settled on what this place is. Professor Schmidt's team established it, and the work since has confirmed it. This is a gathering-place. A ritual site. People came, they raised their pillars, they feasted, and crucially — crucially — when they were done with each enclosure, they *buried it themselves*. They decommissioned it. They filled it in deliberately and walked away."

He let that sit.

"Which means," Reyes said, gently, like a man laying a baby down, "the unexcavated ninety percent isn't a treasure-house waiting to be looted. It's the same. It's more of the known. Beautiful, sacred, and *finished*. It was finished by the people who made it. So when the Trust steps in to stabilise the slope, to put a membrane over the unexcavated ground — we are not opening a tomb. We are honouring a burial those people performed themselves. We're keeping a closed thing closed."

And there it was.

Frik's whole body knew it before his mouth did. It was always like that — the truth came up through the floor of him, through the gut and the chest and the throat, on its own track, and by the time it reached his mouth it had the weight of a thing already decided. People thought the tics and the blurts were chaos. They weren't. They were the most orderly thing about him. They were the part that wouldn't be edited.

He looked at Naila. Naila was looking at the wall, but her hands had gone flat on her knees, very still, and he knew that stillness. She'd heard it too. The wrong number in the ledger.

"That's a hell of a load-bearing word," Mara said quietly, beside him, not loud enough for the front, "*buried*."

"Mm," Frik said. The pressure climbed his throat. *Not yet. Not yet.*

Up front, somebody from the provincial office — a tidy man with a lanyard and a folder — asked a question about the membrane, about drainage, about who held liability if the slope went anyway, and Reyes

answered it beautifully, and Cemal poured more tea, and the air conditioner died and restarted, and through all of it Frik could feel the word sitting in the room like a stone somebody had thrown into still water and was now pretending hadn't made a ring.

Buried. The whole pitch hung off it. *They buried it themselves, so it's finished, so let us seal the rest, so the provenance of ninety percent quietly stops being anybody's problem before the local team can get a roof over it.* Frik wasn't a clever man the way Naila was clever. He couldn't have walked you through the argument. But his body could feel where the floor was rotten, and the floor was rotten right under that word, and the man was standing on it like it was concrete.

Eylül unfolded her arms.

"It's contested," she said.

The room turned to her. Reyes turned to her, and his face did a kind, attentive thing, *of course, tell us*, and Frik watched it and thought: he is not afraid of her saying this. He has an answer for this. This is the part he rehearsed.

"The burial," Eylül said. She didn't raise her voice. She had her uncle's gift for filling a room by lowering it. "Schmidt read the backfill as intentional. He believed they decommissioned each enclosure — packed it with rubble and animal bone and broken tools, and closed it on purpose. That's the famous reading. *They buried their own temple.* It's a beautiful idea and a lot of people built careers on it, including some who are dear to me."

"But," Reyes said, encouraging.

"But the fill has been re-read since," Eylül said. "There's a strong case — published, peer-reviewed, not fringe — that a great deal of what looks like deliberate backfill is *slope-wash*. Hillside coming down. Erosion and landslide over millennia, sediment moving downslope and filling the enclosures the way water fills a bowl, with no human deciding anything at all. The bone and the flint are in there because there was *occupation debris* on this hill — because people lived around here, which we also now know, because we found the houses and the grinding stones and the water channels Schmidt didn't think were here." She paused. "Both readings are live. Neither is closed. Anyone who tells you the burial question is *settled* is telling

you a story they want you to act on, not a fact you can check.”

It was the cleanest thing Frik had ever heard a person do. She hadn’t called Reyes a liar. She’d just put the rot in the floor under a lamp and let everyone see the colour of it.

And Reyes — and this was the thing, this was the part that made Frik’s hands cold — Reyes *nodded*. Warmly. Like she’d helped him.

“Eylül, this is exactly why I wanted the local team in the room,” he said, and he meant it, and that was the horror of him. “You’re right that the scholarship has nuance. Of course it does. But I’d put it to everyone here that the *nuance* is precisely the argument for sealing rather than digging. If we don’t even know whether the fill is sacred or accidental — then opening it risks destroying something irreplaceable to answer an academic question that may never resolve. The cautious thing, the *respectful* thing, is to leave it closed. Whether they buried it or the hill did. Closed is closed.”

And he smiled, and it was a good smile, and Frik watched the room start to move toward it, the lanyard man nodding, the provincial people nodding, because it sounded like wisdom, it sounded like humility, it had the shape of the right answer —

— and the pressure in Frik’s throat became a sound.

He didn’t decide it. That was the thing he would try, and fail, to explain to Mara that night on the dig-house step. You don’t decide it any more than you decide a sneeze. It comes up the track and the track is older than your manners and it arrives with its own weight and it will *out*, and the only question your will gets a vote on is whether you spend your whole life clenched around it, swallowing, going red, being the strange quiet man in the corner who must not be let near important meetings — or whether you let your body say the true thing it has decided to say.

His head pulled left, hard. His shoulder jumped.

“He’s not saying *closed*,” Frik said. Loud. Flat. Certain. The voice that wasn’t quite his and was the truest part of him. “He’s saying *yours*.”

The room stopped.

Frik’s hand came up and pressed his own sternum, the old grounding,

palm flat. The next part came whether he liked it or not, and it came in the cadence the truth always came in, blunt and unhedged, because the editing centre that softens a thing for a room — that centre was the part of him that didn't work, and it was also the part of him the crew had stopped asking him to fix.

“Leave it closed means leave it unrecorded.” His leg bounced. “No provenance. No roof from the local team. No protection on paper. He puts a membrane on the ninety percent and the membrane's not a lid, it's a *deed*. And the burial —” his throat clicked, the word fought him and lost — “the burial's the *excuse*. He needs the burial to be real so the closing's holy. If they buried it, then closing it's respect. If the *hill* buried it —” the tic snapped his head again, his hand pressed harder, and the last of it came out of him like a stone leaving a sling — “then it's just *dirt over the thing he wants and nobody watching while he takes it.*”

Silence. The air conditioner laboured. Somewhere outside a sheep complained.

Frik sat with his palm on his chest, breathing, the heat coming up his neck and into his ears, the old waiting for the old thing — *get him out, who let him in, is he all right, can someone manage him*. He'd lived in that waiting his whole life. The door was right there. Near the door, always, because near the door was the only place a body that says the unsayable can ever fully relax.

Nobody moved to the door.

Cemal set the teapot down on the trestle, slowly, and the small sound of it was very loud.

Naila said, into the quiet, not loudly, “That's correct.”

She wasn't looking at the room. She was looking at the wall, hands flat. “I worked the ledger this morning. The Trust's stabilisation proposal references the unexcavated enclosures by survey grid, not by name, and assigns them a single heritage classification — *decommissioned ritual deposit* — across all of them. All of them. That's not a thing the science supports for ground nobody has opened. You can't classify the fill of an enclosure you haven't sampled. The only way you write *decommissioned* across ninety percent you've never touched is if you need the word to do legal work the trench can't

do yet.” She tilted her head a fraction. “He needs *buried* to mean *finished*. It doesn’t. Frik’s right. It’s load-bearing and it’s hollow.”

Mara had not lifted the camera.

Frik registered that, distantly, through the roar in his ears — that her hands were still folded over the lens cap, that the best photograph in the room was him, palm on sternum, the foundation’s branded water glowing on its little table behind him, the whole rotten beautiful machine of it caught in one frame that would make her name on three continents, *neurodivergent activist names the trick at the heritage meeting*, and she had not moved her finger. She was looking at him and not through a lens, and she gave him a small nod, the nod that meant *I have you, and I am not going to make you the picture*.

Reyes recovered. Of course he did. He was very good.

“That’s a serious accusation,” he said, and the warmth was still there but it had a floor under it now, a coolness coming up. “Made, I’d say, in a — forgive me — a somewhat unguarded way.” A beat. A choice. The kindness turned, just slightly, into a blade so soft you could almost miss it. “I understand the gentleman may not have full control over—”

“He has full control over the truth,” Eylül said. “That’s the only thing he can’t lie about. Which is more than most of us in this room can say.”

And she let that hang too.

It was the second time she’d done it — taken the thing the powerful man reached for and turned it in her hand so its edge faced him. Reyes had reached for Frik’s neurology the way men like him always did, the soft *the poor fellow can’t help himself*, the move that turns a true thing into a symptom so the room can stop hearing it. And Eylül had simply refused the trade. Yes. *He can’t help it. That’s why you should listen*.

Frik’s breathing came down. His hand stayed on his chest a moment longer and then dropped to his knee. The heat in his ears stayed. It always stayed a while. But under it, for the first time he could remember in a room this full, was a thing he had no good word for, a settling, the absence of the door’s pull — because for once the door was not where he needed to be. He needed to be in the chair. In the

second row. On the aisle. *Inside* the room, with the others, where he'd said the unsayable thing and the people he'd come with had not flinched and had not managed him and had picked the true thing up off the floor where he'd dropped it and held it up so it couldn't be put back down.

That was new. He sat very still inside it.

Reyes was talking again — to the provincial officials now, the lanyard man, low and reasonable, *clearly there are strong feelings, perhaps we table the membrane discussion, reconvene with documents* — and it was a retreat dressed as procedure, and everyone in the room could feel it was a retreat, and that was the thing about a true word said where it can't be taken back: it doesn't win the argument. The argument grinds on. The membrane will come up again. The Trust has lawyers and the local team has a portable cabin with a dying air conditioner. Frik knew all that. The blurt didn't fix the world.

But the room could not un-hear it.

You could watch it move through the people. The lanyard man wrote something in his folder and underlined it twice. Two of the village men were talking to Cemal in low fast Kurdish and one of them looked over at the branded water with a new flatness in his face. The word *deed* had been said out loud in a room where Reyes had wanted only the word *respect*, and you cannot take a word back out of a room. It stays in the walls. It gets carried home and said over supper. By morning it would be on the plain.

Through the one window, the long gold light had gone to copper, and the plain was the colour of a thing about to be dark, and out at the edge of the dig-house yard a figure stood by the Beast with its olive paint and its slow-weeping canvas water bag swinging under the bumper, a man in dark glasses he had no business wearing this near to dusk, his back to the cabin, watching the road. He hadn't come in. He never came into the rooms. He'd stood the whole meeting out there in the failing light with his hands loose at his sides, and Frik understood, the way you understand a thing about someone without being told, that the man had stood out there *so that the room would be theirs* — Eylül's, Cemal's, the crew's — and that he was watching the one road in because that was the only part of this he could carry for them, and he meant to carry it.

Cemal began, quietly, to refill the glasses. The meeting was breaking into the murmur that follows a meeting, the scrape of plastic chairs, somebody's phone, and under it the older sound, the sound that had been on this hill before any of the rest of it, the wind coming up over the lip of the plateau with the dark behind it.

Eylül crossed to where the three of them sat. She didn't say *well done*. She wouldn't insult them with it. She crouched in the aisle so she was at Frik's level, and she looked at him, plainly, the way you'd look at a man and not at a condition.

"They don't believe their own *buried* line," she said, low, just for them. "I'll tell you how I know. There's a sister-site east of here. Karahan. The Trust filed for the same membrane there, same grid-classification, before this hill was even on the table." She glanced toward the door, toward the dark coming on, toward the figure by the truck and the one road. "I've been wanting someone to come stand in that trench with me and tell me whether I'm seeing what I think I'm seeing in the stone."

Naila's hands came off her knees.

"What are you seeing," she said.

Eylül stood. She looked at all of them, and at her uncle pouring the tea, and out at the darkening plain that had held its measure under the dirt for eleven and a half thousand years.

"The same measure," she said. "Where there's no reason there should be."

And outside, the wind came over the lip of the plateau and went out across the buried fields toward Karahan, carrying the word the room could not un-hear, and nobody in the cabin said whether the hill had been closed by hands or by rain, because nobody knew, because nobody had ever known, and the carved people up on the ridge stood in the last of the copper light with their fingered hands resting on their belts, facing east, waiting, easy, for whatever the living were going to do next.

Chapter 10 — Karahan

The road to Karahan ran east through ground that gave up nothing. Naila watched it come at the windscreen in long brown waves — basalt scatter, dry watercourse, a shepherd and forty grey sheep standing in a field that had been a sea and would be a sea again given ten thousand years and the patience of rain — and she counted the kilometre stones because counting was a way to stay in her body while the body did the thing she hated, which was sit still inside a moving box and let a stranger drive.

Eylül drove. She had a way of taking the corners that Naila trusted inside the first three of them: no drama, no theatre, the foot doing exactly what the foot meant. Mara sat in the back with the camera in her lap and the lens cap on, which Naila had learned to read now. Lens cap on meant *not yet*. Lens cap on meant Mara was looking with her eyes first, the way she'd started doing, asking the country whether it wanted to be seen before she pointed glass at it.

Frik rode shotgun and bounced his knee and said, twice, the word *Karahan* — once flat, once with the accent slid wrong onto the first syllable, the way it had come out of Eylül's mouth the night before. *KAR-ahan*. He wasn't mocking her. His mouth caught things and kept them and let them out later, helplessly, the audio of a life on a loop a half-second long. Eylül didn't flinch at it. That was the thing Naila had clocked about Eylül in the first hour: she didn't manage them. She'd looked at Frik's bouncing knee in the dig-house and said *there's a strap on the door if you want to pull on something*, and that was all, and Frik had pulled on the strap the whole drive and the knee had quieted, and nobody had made it a moment.

"You said it filed already," Naila said. "The Trust. Same membrane.

Before the hill.”

“Eleven months before.” Eylül didn’t take her eyes off the road. “Karahana was the easy mark. Less famous. No Schmidt on the literature, no Netflix, no busloads. A man could buy stabilisation rights here and nobody in Ankara would lift a coffee cup.” She slowed for a culvert the road had half-eaten. “And then they came west to your hill, with the membrane already drafted, just changing the place-name.”

“Like a template,” Mara said from the back.

Eylül’s mouth did something. Not a smile. “Yes. Funny.”

Karahan Tepe sat on a low rise the colour of a lion, and there was a fence, and there was a gate, and at the gate there was a man in a clean polo shirt with the Anatolia Heritage Trust crest stitched over the heart, sitting in a plastic chair under a sun-shade, with a clipboard and a flask and the bored institutional patience of a man being paid to be a fact.

Eylül showed him a permit. He looked at it for a long time, the way men look at paper when the paper is not the point. The point was the looking.

“Demir,” he read off it. “You’re project, not Trust.”

“I’m Tas Tepeler,” Eylül said. “I have site access on the regional survey grant. You can ring the museum.”

He didn’t ring the museum. He looked past her at the truck, at Naila in the passenger seat, at Frik’s bouncing knee, at Mara’s lens cap, and something in his face did the arithmetic of *who can make trouble for me* and came up short, and he waved them through with the clipboard like a man swatting a fly he’d decided wasn’t worth the calorie.

“They put a fence around a hole in the ground,” Naila said when they were past.

“They put a fence around *property*,” Eylül said. “There’s a difference and they know it and that’s the whole game.”

The enclosures at Karahan were younger in their excavation than Göbekli — the trenches rawer, the spoil heaps fresher, the protective covers cheaper, blue tarp instead of the engineered roof on the famous hill. But the stone was the same stone and the hands had been the same hands or hands taught by the same hands, and Naila knew it before she was four steps in, knew it the way you know a sibling's footstep on a stair.

The T-pillars stood in their rings. Smaller here, some of them, but the *shape* — the broad flat capital that was a head seen edge-on, the stem that was a body, and on the better-cleaned ones the relief carved low and shallow: the arms, the bend at the elbow, the long fingers reaching round the front to meet over a belt. People. Stone people standing in a ring with their hands folded over their middles, patient, eleven and a half thousand years patient, facing in toward a centre where the two tallest stood.

There was a place at Karahan — Eylül took them to it without saying what it was, let them come on it — where a row of carved heads stood up out of the bedrock itself. Not pillars set in. Carved *from* the living rock, faces with no bodies, rising out of the floor of the chamber and looking across it, and one of them, the central one, with a long body running back into the wall as if the man were emerging from the stone or sinking into it, depending which way the light decided to fall.

Mara took the lens cap off. She didn't lift the camera. She held it at her chest and looked at Eylül.

"Can I," she said. Just that. The whole sentence in two words.

Eylül looked at the heads in the rock for a moment, and Naila watched her do the thing Naila could see but not name — the calculation that wasn't a calculation, the reading of the place that came from belonging to it. "The chamber, yes," Eylül said. "Not the village. Not Cemal's people, not their faces, not their tea, unless they say so, each time. This—" she gestured at the carved heads, "—this is everyone's now. They made it to be seen. That's the one thing about it I'm sure of."

Mara nodded and raised the camera and did not, Naila noticed, shoot it for the shot — didn't go for the dramatic low angle that would have made the heads loom and leer for a thumbnail. She got down level with them, eye to eye, the way you photograph a person you respect. The shutter went once. Then she lowered it again.

“That’s it?” Frik said. “One?”

“That’s the one,” Mara said.

Naila stopped counting the kilometre stones because there were no more kilometre stones, and started counting the thing she’d come to count.

She had the figures from Göbekli in her head the way other people had songs. The central pillars in Enclosure D: five and a half metres of worked limestone, eight to ten tonnes of it, a head and a body and two folded hands and a fox-pelt slung at the waist of the one they called Pillar 18, the fox itself carved curling down the man’s flank, alive, mid-leap, eleven and a half thousand years mid-leap. She had the spacing of the ring. She had the ratio of the capital to the stem. She had the angle the relief arms bent at the elbow, which was not ninety degrees and not a hundred and twenty but a particular wrongness of angle, a *style*, the way a face is a style, that you could pick out of a thousand.

And it was here. At Karahan. Sixty kilometres of bad road and a different rise and a different ring and probably a different century — and the angle of the elbow was the same angle, and the capital sat on the stem at the same proportion, and the hands met over the belt at the same place on the body, the navel place, the centre, and the spacing of the ring was the *same spacing*, and Naila stood in the middle of it with her arms wrapped around herself and felt the floor of her certainty tilt the way it tilted only a few times in a life.

“Naila.” Eylül, beside her, quiet. “Tell me what you see. Plain. No softening.”

Naila told her. She gave her the proportion of the capital. She gave her the elbow angle in degrees, and said *give or take, the stone’s worn*, because she would not pretend to a precision the stone hadn’t kept. She gave her the ring spacing and where the hands met and the way the two central pillars stood taller and faced the same way — the way the *living* would face, she thought, if the living were also standing in the ring. She gave it to her the way you’d hand someone a ledger, line by line, and at the end she said:

“It’s the same measure. Two sites. Sixty kilometres. No road between them then, no writing, no — nothing to carry a plan. And it’s the same

measure.”

She heard her own voice do the thing it did when the pattern got too big for the room. Go flat. Go fast. The words coming out level and quick because if she let them have weight they'd have too much.

“Could be one teacher,” Mara offered, gently, from where she stood. “One generation of carvers, walking from site to site.”

“Could be,” Naila said.

“Could be the eye just likes that proportion,” Mara said. “Could be it's the shape a hand makes when a hand carves a body. Could be we're three people standing in a hole pattern-matching ourselves into a story.”

“Could be,” Naila said again, and meant it, because that was the discipline, the one she held hardest — that the pattern was *real* but the *meaning* was the thing you didn't get to assume. You could measure the elbow. You could not measure why.

“Aliens,” Frik said.

The word dropped into the chamber and sat there.

For a half-second nobody moved. Then Frik's face did the thing Naila had come to recognise — the flicker of *that wasn't the one I meant to let out*, the small wince. It was echolalia half the time and blurted-truth the other half and Frik himself, Naila knew, couldn't always tell you which engine had fired. He'd been hearing the word his whole life on the same documentaries everyone heard it on. The mouth caught things.

“No,” Eylül said. Not sharp. Almost kind. “No aliens.”

“Ja, I know,” Frik said. “I *know*. It just—” He pulled the strap that wasn't there, found the hem of his shirt instead. “People say it. About this place. I've read it. *No way hunter-gatherers, must be the lost super-race, must be—*” He shook his head hard, once, like a dog with water in its ear. “It's not. It's worse than that. It's *worse*.”

“How is it worse,” Naila said. She wanted his answer. Frik's answers, when the engine fired right, were the truest thing in any room.

“Because if it's aliens then we didn't do it,” Frik said. The words came out clean and whole, no tic riding them, the way they sometimes did

when the thing was true enough to need saying. “If it’s a super-race then it’s not *us*. But it’s *us*. It’s people with — with bad knees and dead babies and no metal, and they cut a man five and a half metres tall out of a hill with rocks, and then they did it *again*, sixty kilometres away, *the same*. That’s the scary one. Aliens is the comfortable one.” He let go of the hem. “Aliens is the one that lets you off.”

Eylül looked at him for a moment. “Yes,” she said. “That’s exactly it. Where I’m from, the easy story is always the one that lets the outsider off. Aliens. A lost civilisation. A flood, a god, a race that vanished. Anything but the people whose grandchildren are pouring you tea outside the fence.”

They walked the rim. Eylül talked, and she talked the science straight, the way Naila respected — no hedging it down into woo, no inflating it into prophecy, just the facts laid in a row and let to be as astonishing as they actually were.

The radiocarbon at Göbekli, she said, was secure. Pre-Pottery Neolithic, the deep end of it, around nine and a half thousand years before the common era. Klaus Schmidt of the German Archaeological Institute had started digging the famous hill in 1995 and spent the rest of his life there. Built by hunter-gatherers. Before farming. Before pots. Before the wheel, before writing, before metal — the monuments came *first*, before the grain, before the settled village, before everything the textbook said had to come first to make the second thing possible. The textbook had it backward. The hill said you didn’t farm and then build temples with the surplus. The hill said maybe you gathered to build the temple, and feeding all those gathered hands is what drove you, hungry and committed, to farm.

“And Schmidt’s line,” Eylül said, “the one Reyes is leaning on — *temple of nomads, nobody lived here, they came and worshipped and left* — that one’s soft now. Newer work found house structures. Cereal processing. A cut-rock water system. People *lived* here, or near enough. So the postcard’s wrong.” She stopped at the lip of a half-cleared trench, the blue tarp lifting and dropping in the wind. “But the big thing survives. The order’s still inverted. The monuments still came first. Reyes can have his correction on the detail. He can’t have the wonder. The wonder’s still standing.”

"And ninety percent of it's still down there," Mara said, looking at the spoil, at the unopened ground running away in every direction under the lion-coloured grass.

"More," Eylül said. "Göbekli alone — twenty enclosures, two hundred pillars, and we've cleared maybe a tenth. Then Karahan. Then the others. Sayburç. Sefer Tepe. The whole Tas Tepeler, the Stone Hills, a *region* of them, a whole buried tradition, and almost all of it still in the dirt." She said it flat but Naila heard the thing under the flatness. "That's what Reyes wants sealed. Not the part we've seen. The part we haven't. He wants the ninety percent. And his cover is the post-card — *it's a solved site, just a gathering place, finished, nothing left to protect*. If it's solved you don't need archaeologists. You need a fence and a man with a clipboard."

That was when Naila made the mistake she would think about for a while afterward — not a meltdown, nothing dramatic, just a misjudgement of her own ground. She stepped down into the half-cleared trench to put her hand on the elbow of a pillar, to measure the angle with the side of her own forearm laid against the cold stone, and the trench was deeper than it had read from the rim, and the walls came up around her, and there was no clean way out except the way she'd come in, and the blue tarp closed off the sky, and for a moment the chamber was a box and she was in it and the count fell out of her head entirely.

She didn't panic out loud. She'd learned not to make the air thin for other people. She went still and put both hands flat on the pillar and made her breath match the rhythm she'd given herself years ago, the one her mother used to tap on her back — the dum, dum, dum-dum of an old song — and she stood with the stone man's folded hands above her own folded hands and waited for the box to be a room again.

She felt rather than heard Eylül crouch at the rim. Eylül didn't reach down. Didn't say *are you okay*, didn't make it a thing to be managed. She said, conversational, like they were still walking: "This one's my favourite. The carver got the left hand wrong. See the thumb? Wrong side. Eleven thousand years and there's a typo in it." A beat. "There's a ramp at the north end. Spoil ramp. Easier than the way you came."

The count came back. The walls went back to being walls. Naila walked out up the spoil ramp on her own two feet and nobody had had to make a moment of it, and that — that small grace, the ramp offered like a fact and not a rescue — sat warm in her chest the rest of the afternoon, the way the crew's kindnesses always came at her sideways and never head-on, because head-on she couldn't have taken them.

"Thanks," she said, at the top, not looking at Eylül.

"For what," Eylül said, already walking, and that was the whole gift of it.

The labour, Naila thought, walking the rim again with the count restored. People said *impossible*. People stood on the rim and looked at the eight-tonne stone man and said no hunter-gatherer band could have raised him, must be a lost technology, must be levitation, must be the comfortable story Frik had named — the one that lets you off.

It wasn't impossible. She'd run Banning's arithmetic herself, the night before, on the dig-house table with a pencil, because she could not stand an over-reach even when the over-reach was on her own side. Seven to fourteen people. Ropes. A track kept wet and slick. A lever, a fulcrum, a count to pull on — and you could move the stone. It was hard. It was brutal, knee-killing, rope-burned, weeks of it, the kind of hard that breaks bodies and makes legends. But it was *people-hard*, not *miracle-hard*, and the difference mattered more than anything, because the moment you said *impossible* you handed the whole hill to the aliens and to Reyes both, who wanted nothing more than for it to be too big for the people who made it.

"It's not impossible," she said aloud. "I want that on the record. It's astonishing. It is not impossible. Don't anybody put *impossible* in the cut."

"Noted," Mara said.

"Seven to fourteen people and a wet track," Naila said. "I did the numbers."

"And then they did it twice," Frik said, looking at the ring. "Here and there. The same." His knee had stopped bouncing. He stood very

still, which was its own kind of loud, for Frik. “Why the *same*, but. That’s the bit. You can move the stone with fourteen okes and a rope, fine, ja, I believe you. But who told the okes at Karahan to make the elbow at the same angle as the okes at the other hill, sixty k away, no road, no writing—”

“Nobody,” Naila said. “That’s the hole. Nobody told them. We have no carrier for it. No road, no script, no — channel. And the measure’s the same anyway.”

The wind came over the rim of the rise and dropped into the chamber and lifted the blue tarp and let it fall. The stone people stood in their ring with their long fingers folded over their bellies, facing in, facing the centre, waiting, easy, the way they’d waited at Göbekli, the way they were waiting under the grass at all the hills nobody had opened yet.

Eylül came and stood beside Naila and looked at what Naila was looking at.

“You want me to tell you what it means,” Eylül said. “What the same measure means. Whether it’s one teacher or one god or one — thing, walking the hills, leaving the same yardstick everywhere it went.”

“Yes,” Naila said.

“I’m not going to,” Eylül said. “Not because I’m keeping it. Because I don’t know. And the day I pretend I know is the day I’m Reyes — selling a finished story over a hole that isn’t finished.” She turned, and the lion-coloured plain ran away east behind her toward the next hill and the next, all of them holding their measure under the dirt. “What I can tell you is what it’s *for*. Maybe. When you’re ready to hear it not from instruments. That’s mine to give. Not today.”

She looked at the gate, at the man in the clean polo shirt folding up his plastic chair as the light went, at the fence around the hole.

“They want this sealed by the end of the month,” she said. “Both hills. The membrane goes to the provincial office Thursday. After that the ninety percent is theirs and the only people who get to say what it’s *for* are people who’ve never stood in the trench.”

The sun went down behind them and the stone faces in the rock caught the last of it and held it, and the same measure they could

not explain stood in two rings sixty kilometres apart and waited, and Naila looked at it and could not flatten it into coincidence and would not inflate it into a god, and stood in the gap where the true thing lived, and asked the only question she had left:

“Then how do we get there before Thursday?”

Chapter 11 — The Beast on the Plain

Mara had photographed three wars and never once managed to make a picture of a man who didn't want one taken. You could always get something. The half-turn, the hand coming up too late, the eyes finding the lens a quarter-second before they hid. Bodies confessed. That was the whole grammar of her old life: people leak.

Jakobus did not leak.

She'd been trying since Urfa, idly, the way you worry a tooth. He was forty feet off in the blue almost-dark, crouched at the Beast's front wheel with a torch in his teeth, and she lifted the camera out of habit and found him and there was nothing to find. Not a closed face — closed faces are their own tell, the muscle of holding. His was just a face doing work. The torch beam moved. His hands moved. The composition refused to compose. She lowered the camera before she'd touched the shutter and felt the old animal in her, the one that used to win prizes, go quiet and confused, like a dog that's lost the smell.

"He does that," Frik said beside her, not looking up from the map. "Bliksem doesn't *photograph*. My ma had a cat like that. Every picture, just a smear and two eyes."

"He's not blurry," Mara said. "He's right there."

"Ja." Frik's head ticked left, sharp, and came back. "Right there. Nothing." He said it without weight, a man stating the weather, and went back to the map, which was Eylül's, which was the only one that mattered.

They were nineteen kilometres from the sister-site by the road that existed and fifty by the road that was legal, and it was nine at night, and Thursday was the day after tomorrow.

—

The Beast had come over in a container and looked, in this country, like a lie about itself. In the Northern Cape it had been the most sensible object for a thousand kilometres. Here on the Anatolian plain, parked off a tractor-track between a pistachio terrace and a field of stubble going silver under the rising moon, the great rust-and-canvas bulk of it read as something dragged out of the wrong story. The locals at Cemal's village had circled it that afternoon with the flat appraising courtesy you give another man's working animal. One old farmer had put his palm on the bonnet, felt the engine-warmth still in it, and nodded once, as at a horse.

The water bag hung off the wing mirror and wept. That was the desert canvas — a *girba*, Jakobus called it, or a word like it; it sweated its own surface to cool the water inside, the oldest air-conditioning there was, and it worked here exactly as it worked at home because physics didn't care about borders. The cayenne tin lived in the door pocket. The hanky — the one impossible always-white hanky, a magic trick Mara had decided not to investigate — was folded in his breast pocket. The shades were pushed up on his head because the sun was gone. The rule was the rule: the shades came down with the sun, went up with it, and nobody had ever heard him explain the rule and nobody asked.

He stood from the wheel and the torch went off and he said something low across the dark, in the handful of Kurdish he carried — *sebra te ye*, patience, or near it, mangled and offered anyway — to Cemal's nephew Rojîn, who was nineteen and angry and good with a vehicle and had appointed himself their second driver. Rojîn laughed, surprised, and answered too fast, and Jakobus didn't follow it and held up the clean hanky like a small flag of surrender and they both laughed, and that was the whole exchange, and Mara could not have photographed that either. The warmth was real. It just wouldn't sit still for a frame.

"He learns three words and hands them over like he's sorry," she said.

"It's not sorry," Eylül said. She'd come up on Mara's other side with-

out sound, the way she moved on her own ground. “It’s *Sawubona*. He told Cemal. I see you. You hand someone three words of their language wrong, you’ve told them you tried. That’s the whole thing.” She nodded at the men. “My uncle’s been deciding about him all day. He’s decided.”

“Decided what?”

“That he’ll do.” Eylül almost smiled. “Cemal once spent four years deciding whether to lend a man a ladder.”

—

The plan was Eylül’s and it was small and it was legal in the way that mattered and a problem in the way that didn’t.

The sister-site — she would not give it a name to the camera, not the working name, not the official one; *the hill*, she called it, *that hill* — sat on land that three families farmed and one of those families was Cemal’s by marriage. The Anatolia Heritage Trust had a stabilization permit, the same template document they’d waved at Karahan, the paper that said *we are protecting this from neglect* over a hole nobody had neglected. The permit gave them the fence. It did not give them the unexcavated ground under it, not until the membrane — the access-and-conservation instrument, forty pages of clean clauses — cleared the provincial office in Sanliurfa on Thursday morning. After that, the ninety percent still buried belonged, for the purposes that counted, to Anton Reyes’s careful gentle hands.

But the membrane required, in clause nine, *documented community consultation*. And clause nine, like most clauses written by men who’d never stood in a trench, assumed the community would be consulted *by the Trust* and would say yes because the form said yes.

“They never asked Cemal’s people,” Eylül said. “They asked the headman of the wrong village. Forty kilometres off. A man who sold a yes for a road grading. It’s on the form. It’s a forgery of a procedure, not even a real lie — a clerical lie.” She said *clerical* like a curse. “If three families who actually farm that ground file an objection before the membrane is stamped, the provincial office has to send it back. Has to. It’s their own form. They love their own form more than they love the Trust.”

“So we drive there,” Frik said, “tonight, and we — what. Knock?”

"We don't do anything." Eylül's voice didn't rise; it just got more itself. "*They* do. The families. I drive there, with my project authority, and I sit with the people who hold that ground and I tell them what the form is, in their language, by a fire, with tea, and if they want to sign the objection they sign it and tomorrow at dawn it goes to Urfa in Rojîn's hands and it gets stamped *received* with a date on it before nine o'clock when the Trust's courier arrives." She looked at each of them. "You four are not the point. Understand that or stay here. You're the reason I can do it in one night instead of three. That's all you are. That's plenty."

"Plenty," Frik echoed, soft, and it sat in the dark as agreement.

Naila had been silent, folded into the Beast's open back with her knees up, the field-light off her tablet making a small blue room of her face. She'd been silent since Urfa, since the bazaar that afternoon — the bazaar that had no exits she could see and too many shoulders and the smell of three hundred spice sacks, and she'd gone grey and gone down inside herself in the middle of it, and Frik had simply turned and become a wall, big and Afrikaans and loudly demanding directions to a carpet shop nobody wanted, drawing every eye onto himself and his ticking head so that Naila could find the wall's lee and breathe, and Mara had got them out a side door, and nobody had named it then and nobody named it now. It was just a thing the family did. You didn't manage Naila. You changed the weather around her and let her come back.

She came back now.

"The legal road is fifty," Naila said. "The track is nineteen. The Trust will have the track watched."

"Yes," Eylül said.

"Then it isn't a legal problem. It's a driving problem."

Eylül looked at the Beast. At Jakobus, who'd come to stand in the open door of it, not inside the conversation and not outside it, a man at a threshold, hands loose. He hadn't said a word about the route. He wouldn't, Mara understood — not until it was handed to him, and it wasn't his to take.

"It's your ground," Jakobus said to Eylül. Three words. *Hou jou bek* under it somewhere, the South African virtue of shutting up. "Tell me

where it's safe to be."

—

She told him. She knelt in the dust by the front wheel with Rojîn and she drew the plain in scratches — the irrigation channel you could run dry that ran behind the Trust's sightline, the old threshing floor where the moon would silhouette anything that moved on the ridge, the place two terraces met where the track pinched and a watcher would expect them and where, two hundred metres east, an animal track Rojîn's grandfather used went down through a dry watercourse the maps didn't have. Jakobus listened the way he did everything, completely and without commentary, and when she finished he asked exactly two questions and both were about water — where it stood, where it had stood, where the ground would be soft tonight under a top crust that looked hard.

"Here," Rojîn said, surprised again, and pointed, and Eylül translated, and Jakobus nodded as if water were the only language and he'd just been told a poem.

They went at full dark with the moon doing the work of headlights.

—

Mara rode up front for the first leg with the camera in her lap and her hand off it. That was the discipline now. Hand off it. She'd come to this crew because at a checkpoint outside a city she would not name she'd had a child in her frame, perfect light, the whole composition handing itself to her like an apple off a branch, the picture that would have run on four continents — and her hands had stopped. Just stopped. The shutter under her finger and her finger gone to stone. She'd thought it was failure for a year. Jakobus, when she told him, on a different night on a different continent, had said: *or your hands learned to ask first*. And she'd wanted to hit him and instead had cried, which was worse, and then had come to work.

So her hand was off the camera, and she watched.

The Beast ran without lights on the threshing floor, Jakobus reading the silver ground at twenty kilometres an hour, the engine down to a mutter — he'd done something to it, dropped it into some gear that turned the diesel into a heartbeat instead of a roar. Music played, low, off a cracked phone wedged in the dash: not for pleasure. Mara had

clocked it three sites ago. A slow thing, four-four, the same handful of bars looping, and his foot and the gear changes and the small corrections of the wheel all sat *on* it, the music a metronome he drove to, so that the Beast moved across the dangerous open ground with the unhurried inevitability of a thing keeping time. She would have killed, in her old life, for a picture of his hands on the wheel in the dash-glow. She lifted the camera. The dash-glow was on the wheel and the rust and the cayenne tin and not, somehow, on him; he sat in the one part of the cab the light declined to reach, and she got the wheel and the tin and a darkness shaped like a man, and lowered it, and laughed once under her breath.

"Told you," Frik said from the back.

"He's leaning *toward* the light."

"Ja. And the camera says no thank you." Frik's hand drummed his knee, a private rhythm, off the music and then onto it, off and then on. "S'pose if you spend your whole life being the thing people point at," he said, and stopped, and his head ticked, and he didn't finish it, but the unfinished end of it sat in the cab and was true. Frik knew. Frik had been pointed at since he was six. Frik's whole body was a thing that other people's cameras came up for, and he'd built, across thirty years, the only defence there was, which was to make himself useless to the frame by giving it everything — and here was a man who'd built the opposite defence, total withholding, and the two of them recognised each other across it like men who'd survived the same war on different sides.

The watercourse came up where Rojîn said it would. Jakobus stopped the Beast on the lip of it, killed the music, killed the engine, and the silence of the plain came in so total it had a pressure to it. He got out. He walked the lip of the dry channel with the unlit torch in his hand, not using it, reading the soft ground Eylül and Rojîn had promised — and Mara, watching through the open door, saw the only thing all night that the camera could have held, and didn't reach for it.

He knelt. He put his bare palm flat on the watercourse floor the way the old farmer had put his palm on the bonnet, and held it there, reading what was under it through his skin. Then he licked his finger and held it up — wind — and then he did the thing that was his and

not theirs: he took a pinch of cayenne from the tin in his pocket and let it go off his fingers into the night air and watched which way it drifted and how fast it fell.

“What is he—” Naila started.

“Dew point,” Eylül said, very quietly, fascinated. “He’s reading where the cold air’s pooling. Where the crust’s wet under the dry. My uncle does it with cigarette smoke.” She watched the red dust fall. “His desert taught him your hill.”

The pepper fell slow and drifted left. Jakobus came back to the cab and got in and said, “Soft on the right shoulder. We hug the left. Rojîn — *tu li pêş*,” go ahead, the words wrong and accepted, and Rojîn took the little farm bike down into the watercourse first as a scout and his single light bobbed away into the dark and Jakobus put the Beast in after him on the line the pepper had drawn, and the great machine went down into a riverbed older than the road and the road was older than Rome and the hill they were driving to was older than all of it by eight thousand years, and Mara held the camera in her lap and did not lift it, and felt, for the first time since the checkpoint, that her hands had been right.

—

They saw the drone at the threshing-floor exit, climbing out of the watercourse onto the last open ground.

A quad-copter, small, expensive, with the matte non-glare finish of a thing that did not want to be seen seeing. It came up off the Trust’s fence-line a kilometre off and hung, and a light didn’t blink on it because the men who flew it weren’t amateurs, but the moon caught the rotor-blur.

“Down,” Eylül said, and they went still, and the drone drifted closer, and its camera — Mara knew that camera, knew its gimbal, had carried its cousin into worse places — swept the open ground looking for the thing that had no business in this riverbed.

It found the Beast. Of course it found the Beast; the Beast was four metric tonnes of rust under a full moon.

It hung on the Beast. It hung on Naila’s pale face turned up, and Frik’s, and Eylül’s hand up to shield her eyes, and it would have a frame of

all of them, a clean frame, four faces and a registration plate, *here is who came in the night* — and then Jakobus stepped down out of the cab.

He didn't hide. That was the thing Mara would turn over for weeks. He walked out into the open between the drone and the Beast and he stood in the full moon with his face up to it, the most visible man on the plain, and the drone swung onto him because he was the largest moving thing — and *got nothing*. Mara had her own camera up now, on the drone's exact line, stealing the drone's own shot, and she saw it on her screen in real time: the moon was full on him and her sensor, the best money could buy, rendered the ground and the rust and the dust hanging in the air and where the man was it gave her a column of dark with shades pushed up on it and the white flag of a hanky and no face. He'd turned the shades down. The sun was long gone and the rule was the sun but he'd turned the shades down into the moon and under the brim of his cap and over the lenses there was no skin the camera could swear to.

The drone hung on him for four seconds, gimbal hunting, refocusing, hunting again — a machine built to capture faces, baffled by a man who'd made a forty-year study of not being captured — and then a hand came up off Rojîn's farm bike in the dark and threw, and a fist-sized rock took the drone somewhere in its electric heart and it staggered and yawed and went down into the stubble fifty metres off with a sound like a dropped guitar.

Nobody cheered. Eylül said one word and Rojîn answered it and it was business. The drone's fall was a clock starting. The Trust knew now that someone had come.

"Go," Eylül said, and Jakobus was already in the cab, and the music came back on, four-four, and the Beast climbed out of the last of the watercourse onto the high ground and the hill stood up out of the plain in front of them in the moonlight, low and dark and rounded, a belly of earth with the Trust's mean little fence around one shoulder of it and the stone — she could see it now, raw and pale where the trench cut in — the stone standing up inside the fence the way it had stood for eleven and a half thousand years, before the wheel that had brought them, before the road, before the word for *road*.

There were lights at the foot of it. Not the Trust's. Warm ones. A fire, and the headlamps of two pickups, and twelve, fifteen people standing — the families, Cemal among them with his hand already raised, and the old man who'd palmed the Beast's bonnet, and women, and three children up too late, all of them on their own ground in the moonlight, waiting, because Rojîn had phoned ahead from the water-course and Eylül had told them the truth and they had decided, the way Cemal decided things, slowly and then all at once, to be here.

The Beast came up the track and stopped at the edge of the firelight and the engine died and the music with it.

Eylül got out first. It was hers. She walked into the light toward her uncle and the people who held the ground, and Mara stayed in the cab with her hand off the camera, because this was the frame that would have made her name — the families, the fire, the eleven-thousand-year-old hill behind them, the *real* picture — and it was theirs, and asking would have to wait for daylight and for Eylül's yes, and she was learning, slowly and then all at once, to sit in the dark and let a thing be witnessed without being taken.

Jakobus didn't get out. He turned in the seat, shades still down in the firelight, and looked back at the three of them in the body of the Beast, and didn't say anything, because the next part wasn't his.

It was Eylül's. It always had been.

She reached the fire. Cemal handed her tea. And beyond the fire the hill stood up dark against the stars with its buried stone people waiting under the dirt to be asked, at last, by the one person here with the right to ask it, the only question that was left.

What were you *for*.

Chapter 12 — What the Stone Was For

Naila stayed in the body of the Beast longer than she meant to.

It was the engine. Not the absence of it—the *after* of it. Jakobus had a way of killing the ignition that let the machine settle through its registers, the way a struck bell goes down its overtones, and her ears followed it the whole way down: the diesel knock, then the tick of cooling metal, then a frame-creak as the chassis took up the slack, then nothing, then the fire outside, which had its own rhythm she didn't have a name for yet. Wood-pop. The low corrugated mutter of forty people deciding whether to talk. A child, somewhere, refusing to be asleep.

She counted the people at the fire because counting them put a floor under the night. Thirty-eight, then forty-one when three more came out of the dark by the pistachio terrace, then forty exactly when one of the children was carried off bodily by a woman in a headscarf the colour of dried apricot. Forty held. She let it be forty.

Frik was beside her with his hands flat on his knees, pressing down, which was the thing he did when the body wanted to go and the room wasn't his to go into yet. His jaw ticked twice. He said, very quietly, to the window, "*Tea*," which was echolalia off Cemal's voice carrying up the slope, and then he said, also quietly, also to the window, "they're not afraid of him," which was not echolalia, which was the other thing.

"No," Naila said. "They're not."

"That's the bit," Frik said. "Forty people. A stranger. *No gun*. And they're not afraid of him." He pressed his knees. "I keep waiting for

the bit where someone's afraid of him."

Mara had her camera in her lap with the lens cap on and her hand over the lens cap, which Naila had come to understand was Mara holding herself the way Frik held himself. Down at the fire Eylül had reached her uncle and taken the glass from his hand, and the firelight did the thing firelight does to a face that knows it's on its own ground, and Mara's thumb moved on the lens cap and did not lift it.

"Not yet," Mara said, to no one, to herself.

Jakobus opened his door. He didn't get out into the firelight. He got out into the dark just past it and stood by the front wheel where the weeping water bag hung off the wing mirror, leaving a dark coin of damp in the dust under it, and he checked the bag's knot the way he checked everything, with two fingers, once, and then he stood with his back to them and his face to the hill, shades down, a shape the firelight refused to fully describe.

"Come," Eylül called up the slope. Not to him. To the three of them in the Beast. "Cemal says come and sit. He says the stones won't mind."

They sat where they were put, which was the discipline of the place and Naila liked it: you did not choose your spot at Cemal's fire, you were placed, and the placing meant something she couldn't read but trusted. She was put between an old woman who smelled of woodsmoke and lanolin and a boy of about nine who stared at her openly and was not told to stop. Frik was put across the fire next to Cemal himself, which Naila understood was an honour and also a test, and she watched Frik understand it too, watched him go very still and let the tics come small because small was what his body could afford here. Mara was put at the edge, near the dark, where a photographer sits when she has decided not to be one tonight. Jakobus was not placed. Jakobus had placed himself, out past the light, a sentry nobody had asked for and everybody had accepted.

Tea came. The glass was hot and Naila held it by the rim the way the boy held his, and the sweetness of it hit the back of her throat and steadied something.

The hill stood behind the fire.

She had been looking at it on screens for eleven weeks. She knew its numbers better than she knew the numbers of the street she'd grown up on. Twenty enclosures, give or take, in the surveys—the magnetometry that read the buried walls like ink under skin. Two hundred pillars at this one site alone, and ten percent dug, which meant ninety percent of it was the dark under the fire, the dark she was sitting on. Pre-Pottery Neolithic. Around nine and a half thousand years before the common era. Eleven and a half thousand years old, which she could say but could not feel, the same way she couldn't feel the distance to the sun, and the not-feeling was honest, she trusted the not-feeling more than people who said they could feel it.

Six thousand years before the first stone of Stonehenge. The pyramids were a recent event by this hill's reckoning. Klaus Schmidt had put a spade into it in 1995 for the German Archaeological Institute and found, under a hill everyone had walked over for ten thousand years thinking it was a hill, people made of stone.

"He thought no one lived here," Eylül said.

She wasn't lecturing. She was talking the way you talk over a fire when the talking is part of the warmth. She had her glass in both hands and her elbows on her knees and she was looking at the hill, not at them.

"Schmidt. The first big idea. A temple in the wilderness—nomads come from far away to build it and pray and then go back to the wild, and nobody *lived* here, no homes, no hearths, no bread." She tipped her head. "It's a beautiful idea. It's the idea that made the place famous. Cathedral before the city. God before the farm." She drank. "And it's mostly wrong now. Or the strong version is."

"How," said Naila. It came out flat. It always came out flat. The boy beside her flinched at the flatness and she did not soften it because softening it was a lie and she didn't have one to spare.

"Newer digging." Eylül shrugged one shoulder. "Mine, some of it. Other teams. We found the boring stuff. Domestic walls. Cereal—people grinding wild grain here, processing it, a lot of it, more than a passing-through crowd grinds. A whole water system cut into the limestone to catch the rain, because up here there's no spring, you'd die of thirst running a building site without it." She made a small motion with the glass, dismissing the romance of it. "People *lived*

here. It's less pretty. The temple-of-nobody is a better story."

Frik said, "But." His knee jumped. He pressed it. "Sorry. But."

"But," Eylül agreed, and looked at him, and the *but* was a gift she was handing him, letting his body's blurt be the thing that turned the talk, and Naila saw Frik take the gift and hold very still under it. "But the thing that makes your hair stand up—that survives. They *built* it before they farmed. The big stones, the carving, the whole effort—it's older than the wheat. Older than pots. Older than writing by six thousand years. They had flint and rope and their own backs and the time between hunts, and they raised people out of the ground who weigh ten tonnes apiece."

"Ten tonnes each," Naila said. The numbers were a railing she could hold. "The two central ones in the oldest enclosure. Enclosure D. About five and a half metres tall. Eight to ten tonnes. Limestone, quarried out of the same plateau, dragged across it."

"Dragged how," said Mara, from the edge, from the dark, and Naila heard the professional in it—the woman who'd photographed enough hard places to know that *how* was the whole story and the picture everyone wanted was the lie.

"That's the potato," Naila said.

"The what," said the old woman beside her, in Turkish, and Eylül translated, *patates*, and the old woman laughed a single dry note and said something back, and Eylül said, "She says you can't eat a hill," and Naila found she liked the old woman quite a lot.

"The easy version," Naila said. "The version where you go, fine, primitive people, lots of them, simple work. There's a number people throw around. Five hundred. A thousand men hauling on ropes, like the pyramids in the films."

"Charlton Heston," said Frik, helplessly, echoing a thing nobody had said, and then, "sorry," and Cemal beside him laughed low and put a hand briefly on Frik's shoulder, once, and took it away, and Frik's jaw unlocked half a notch.

"It's wrong," Naila said. "The big number's wrong, and it's wrong in the direction that matters. There's an archaeologist, Banning—E. B. Banning—did the labour arithmetic properly. A pillar like that,

on a track, lubricated, the limestone bedded right—you don't need a thousand. You don't need five hundred." She set her glass down in the dust, very precisely, because her hands wanted to do the moving and she let them. She walked two fingers across the ground. "Rope here. Track here. Bank the slope. Crew on the lines, crew rolling the track-logs from back to front as it moves, crew on the levers at the head. Seven people. Maybe fourteen if you want it gentle and you want everyone to live."

The fire popped.

"Seven people," said Mara.

"To *move* it," Naila said. "Not to make it. Not to think of it. Not to feed the seven people while they spend their winter not hunting because they're dragging a stone man across a hill instead. Seven to drag. But you've already lost the easy version by then, because the easy version was *they were primitive and there were lots of them and it was simple*, and the truth is there weren't many of them and it wasn't simple and they weren't primitive, they did the arithmetic I just did, eleven and a half thousand years ago, with no number system I'd recognise, and they got it *right*, every time, two hundred times, across twenty buildings, across—"

She stopped. She had been about to say it. The across-sites thing. The measure she'd been finding in the survey grids of the other hills, Karahan, the smaller ones with no names in the brochures, the same proportions turning up where there was no road between them and no reason, the too-clean repeat that sat in her chest like a stone she couldn't put down. She had not told the crew the whole of it. She didn't have the whole of it. She had a maybe, and a maybe was not a thing you set down at a stranger's fire.

"Across the whole hill," she said instead, which was true and was not all of it.

Eylül was watching her. Eylül, she had learned in eleven weeks, missed very little, and Naila felt herself read—not unkindly, the way the magnetometer reads a buried wall, the shape of the thing under the dirt without the dirt being moved—and Eylül let it go, the way you let a thing go that isn't yours yet.

"So the big number's a lie," Frik said. He'd found his level. When

the talk was true his body quieted; it was the lies that lit him up, the rooms full of polite untruth he'd been thrown out of his whole life, and a fire full of people saying the real thing was the easiest room his body had ever been in. "The thousand slaves. That's the lie."

"That's the lie," Naila said.

"So what's the hole." Frik leaned in. The boy across the fire leaned in too, mirroring, because nine-year-olds are honest. "There's always the hole. Naila does the numbers and then there's the bit the numbers can't reach. What's the bit?"

Naila looked at the hill.

"They covered it up," she said.

Eylül topped up the tea. Cemal said something to the apricot-scarf woman and she went off toward the houses and came back with a cloth of flatbread and walnuts and passed it round, and you took some, that was the rule, you took some whether you were hungry or not, and Naila took a walnut and held it because holding things was allowed.

"The enclosures," Naila said. "Some of them, the dirt's *on top* of the stones. Metres of it. The fill that hid the whole thing for ten thousand years until it looked like a hill." She turned the walnut. "Schmidt's idea—the second big one. They buried it on purpose. Built it, used it, and then when they were done, or when something changed, they didn't knock it down, they didn't burn it, they *buried* it. Filled the rooms with rubble and dirt and stone-tool waste, by hand, on purpose, tucked their stone people into the ground like—"

"Putting someone to bed," said Mara, from the dark, and Naila almost said *don't caption it* and didn't, because it wasn't a caption, it was Mara reading the same thing and saying it shorter, and Naila let the better word stand.

"On purpose," Frik said. "Or."

"Or," Naila said. "After about 2014 a lot of people stopped being sure. Because if you look at the fill close—the way it lies, the way the slope sits above it—some of it reads like a landslide. Slope-wash. Ten thousand years of a hillside coming down over a thing nobody

was maintaining anymore. Not a burial. An *abandonment* that the weather finished." She set the walnut down beside the glass, lined up, two objects, a small order. "Both are true to the evidence depending which trench you're standing in and who's arguing. Schmidt's gone—he died in 2014—so he can't fight his own corner. And it's not settled. It's not going to be settled tonight by me." She heard her own voice go careful. "I won't pretend it is. The intentional-burial reading is beautiful. The landslide reading is boring and might be right. Beautiful isn't a method."

"But you want it to be the burial," Frik said. Blurted. Flat true. "You want them to have tucked them in."

The fire did its work on her face and she let it. "Yes," she said. "I want that. Which is exactly why I don't get to have it."

Cemal laughed at that, when Eylül put it into Turkish for him, a real laugh from low in him, and he said a long thing, slow, and Eylül listened to all of it with her head down before she lifted it.

That was the turn. Naila felt it come the way you feel a key go into the right depth of a lock—not the click yet, the *seating*, the moment the metal knows the door.

"My uncle says—" Eylül stopped. Started again, because she was not going to flatten his words into hers. "He says you've all been very careful about *how*. The rope and the track. The numbers. The dirt on top, on purpose or not." She turned the glass. "He says outsiders always ask *how*. The professors, the foundation people, the television. *How did they lift it*. As if knowing how a thing was lifted tells you why anyone wanted it in the air."

"The man asked *what is it for*," Eylül said. Not pointing at the dark past the fire. Not naming him. But Naila knew the *man*, and Frik went very still, and Mara's hand left the lens cap entirely and lay flat in the firelight palm-up, empty, a photographer with both hands shown to be holding nothing. "When he got here. First thing. Cemal asked him his business and he didn't say roads or stones or money. He said: I want to know what it's for. And Cemal liked that, which is why you're sitting at his fire."

Out past the light the shape by the front wheel didn't move. The water bag wept its slow coin into the dust.

“So.” Eylül looked at the hill, and then she looked at her own people around the fire, the forty of them, the old woman, the boy, the woman in apricot, the men who farmed this plain because their fathers had and theirs before, all the way back, not eleven thousand years back, nobody’s that, but *back*, a line of people who had never once stopped living on this ground. “So I’ll tell you what it’s for. Not because I dug it. Because it’s ours to say and the digging’s only the half of it that washes off your boots.”

She set the glass down.

“They’re people,” she said. “The pillars. Everybody knows that now—the arms. You’ve seen the arms.” Her own arm came up, bent at the elbow, the way the relief was carved, forearm laid along the flank of an imagined stone, and her fingers spread and then came together low at her own waist, where the belt would be, where Pillar 18 holds its hands with every finger cut separate over a loincloth of fox-pelt, a fox tucked under its arm like a thing it has decided to carry forever. “Hands. Fingers. A belt. A fox in the crook of the arm. They’re not gods up there, not the way the brochure means. They’re not gargoyles. They’re *people*. Big ones. Raised up. Standing in a ring in a room with the dangerous things carved all round them—the lions, the boars, the scorpions, the snakes, the vultures. The vultures most of all.” She let her arm down. “The vulture’s the one that takes you up when you’re dead, in a lot of places round here. The bird that carries you off the ground. They put the carrying-bird on the walls and the standing-people in the middle and then they came—the living ones, the small soft warm ones like us—and they *gathered*.”

“To do what,” Naila said. Flat. Needing it exact.

“To stand with them,” Eylül said. “That’s it. That’s the whole of it and it’s bigger than how-they-lifted-it. You’re a band of forty—maybe two hundred when the bands came in. You hunt, you move, you die young, half your babies don’t make it, and the dead are everywhere behind you, more of them every year than there are of you, and you can’t take them with you when you move. So you make a place. You raise your dead up out of the ground in stone so they don’t move when you do. You make them *bigger* than you and you put the things that eat you on the walls so the dead can hold the line against them, and then you come, in the season, all the bands, and you sit in the ring at the feet of your stone grandfathers in the only room on earth where the

dead outnumber the living and aren't gone. You stand with them. You bring beer—we found the vats. You bring the wild grain and you grind it and you feast at the feet of the watching ones, and you don't *leave* the way you leave everywhere else, because this is the one place that doesn't move."

The fire was the only thing talking.

"That's what the stone was for," Eylül said quietly. "A place to be with the dead that wouldn't walk away. We've never had a place that didn't walk away. They built the first one." She looked at the hill, at the ninety percent of it that was still the dark under all of them. "And then—my uncle says—when they buried it, if they buried it, that wasn't them throwing it out. That was the last thing you do for someone you love. You tuck them in. You cover the watchers so the watchers can rest. And then you build the next ring, bigger, with bigger people, because by now you can't *not*. By now you're a people who gather. By now—"

She stopped herself at the edge of it. Naila felt the edge too—the next thing, the larger thing, the thing about what gathering does to a band that gathers, what it might have *started*—and felt Eylül decide it was for tomorrow, for daylight, for the trench and not the fire.

"By now you're something you weren't," Eylül said, and left it.

Naila sat with the walnut and the glass lined up in the dust and the hill standing up behind the fire, and for once the not-feeling left her. She had had the pattern for eleven weeks—the proportions, the two hundred pillars, the too-clean measure she still hadn't said out loud. She'd had the *system*. She had never had this: the meaning the system was the bones of, handed to her by the one person at the fire whose ground it was, who'd grown it not out of a magnetometer but out of being the unbroken end of a line of people who never left.

The wonder didn't shrink down into an answer. She'd been braced for that her whole life—the moment the beautiful thing gets explained and goes small and grey. It didn't go small. It went the other way, out past the firelight, out over the dark ninety percent, out to twenty rings of raised stone people on hills that shouldn't share a measure and somehow did, and she felt the maybe in her chest get heavier and not lighter, and she did not say it, not yet.

The boy beside her had fallen asleep against the old woman's shoulder.

Out past the firelight the shape by the wheel finally moved—turned, not toward them, toward the plain and the dark road the foundation would come up Thursday morning—and the water bag swung once on the mirror and went still.

"So tomorrow," Eylül said, picking her glass back up, the field leader again, the night's warmth folding back into the work, "we keep them off it. And the day after we go up the hill, all of you, and I'll show you the thing I haven't said yet."

"Which is what," said Frik.

Eylül smiled, and it was not a brochure smile.

"The reason any of us are farmers," she said.

Chapter 13 — The Thing That Made Us

The hill at seven in the morning was nothing like the brochure.

Naila had seen the brochure. Anton Reyes's people had a brochure, glossy as a magazine, the kind of object that arrives in a province like an apology — *Anatolia Heritage Trust: Preserving the First Temple for All Humanity* — and on its cover Enclosure D sat under a clean dawn, the two great central pillars rising gold out of a haze that some retoucher had painted in, the whole thing lit like a cathedral and just as empty.

The real hill smelled of diesel and goat. The protective roof over the main enclosures was a steel-and-fabric thing, vast and engineered and faintly absurd, like a tennis court had been dropped on a field of the dead. The walkway boards were grey with dust and someone had taped a torn sheet of cardboard over a gap where a plank had gone soft. A generator coughed somewhere down-slope. Two of Eylül's students were already in, knees on foam pads at the lip of a trench, doing the slowest possible work in the world with brushes and dental picks, and the older one had earbuds in and was very quietly mouthing along to something.

"It's smaller than the photos," said Mara, behind her. Her camera hung off one shoulder, capped, the way it had hung for three days now. "And bigger."

"That's not a sentence."

"It's the only one I've got."

Naila got it, though. She'd come up the boards braced for the mag-

netometer's ghost — eleven weeks of survey, the grids, the too-clean measure — and instead the ground had handed her the thing itself, and the thing itself was *small*, was a stone ring you could throw a ball across, and inside the ring two figures eight metres tall were standing with their arms bent and their long fingers laid over their bellies and they were not small at all.

Eylül was already down inside D, on the safe side of the rope, with the early light coming in low and sideways under the canopy and laying the relief out in shadow the way no overhead photo ever could.

"Come look," she said. "While the light's honest."

They went down one at a time, where she pointed, on the boards she pointed to. Frik went second and stopped at the bottom and made a sound — a short hard click in the throat, twice — and then said "*sorry, sorry,*" not to anyone, the apology a reflex, a tic of its own by now, and Eylül didn't turn round and didn't make a thing of it, just said, over her shoulder, "You don't have to be quiet down here. The pillars don't mind. Trust me, they've heard worse," and Frik laughed, a real one, surprised out of him.

Cemal hadn't come up the hill. *My knees retired before I did*, he'd said at the fire, but he'd sent his nephew with a thermos and a folded blanket for the cold dawn, and the boy — Devran, eleven, the one who'd fallen asleep on the old woman's shoulder last night — had attached himself to Frik somewhere around the carpark and now stood beside him at the foot of the boards with the proprietary calm of a child who has decided an adult is his.

"This is Pillar eighteen," Eylül said.

Naila had known the number for eleven weeks. She had drawn it. She had its dimensions in a notebook in three places. She looked at it now and the number went away.

It was a T. That was the brochure word for it, the word the early diagrams used, the word that made it furniture, made it a tau cross, made it a *thing*. It was not a thing. The long vertical shaft was a body. The horizontal block across the top was a head — not a face, no eyes, no mouth, the head turned the other way, turned *out*, away from you, the way you'd see a person from behind. And down the

narrow side of the shaft, carved in low relief so you only got it when the light came sideways, was an arm. A whole arm, the shoulder, the line of it down, the elbow bending — *bending* — and then the forearm coming round across the front of the stone, and a hand. Five fingers. Long, splayed, individual, the nails suggested, the fingers from both hands very nearly meeting low on the belly, over a belt.

“Oh,” said Mara. The cap was still on the lens. She’d lifted the camera off her shoulder anyway, by reflex, the body remembering before the mind got a vote, and then she’d stopped, the strap caught in her fist, and she didn’t shoot.

“There’s a belt,” Naila said. Her voice came out wrong, flatter than she wanted. “It’s wearing a belt.”

“It’s wearing a belt,” Eylül agreed. “And on this one — see, on the front of the shaft, below the hands — that’s a loincloth. A pelt. We think a fox pelt. And here—” she crouched, brought her flat hand near the stone without touching it, traced the air over a low relief on the side, “—it’s holding a fox. Against its body. Like this.”

Devran said something in Kurdish, quick, and Eylül answered him, and to the others she said, “He says it looks cold. The fox.” She smiled. “He’s not wrong about the morning.”

Frik made the click again, once, and then said, clear, the way the true thing came out of him sideways and unbidden: “*They’re people.*”

Nobody contradicted him. That was the whole point, Naila would think later. Nobody down in that ring at seven in the morning, with the honest light on the relief, contradicted him.

“Eleven and a half thousand years,” Eylül said, standing, brushing dust off her knees. “That’s not a guess and it’s not a vibe. That’s radiocarbon, from the fill, from charcoal, replicated. Klaus Schmidt started digging here in 1995 and he had the dates back and they were so old he had them run again because nobody believed them, including him.” She looked round at them. “Six thousand years before Stonehenge. Seven before the Pyramids. These two—” the central pair, the giants, fingers over their bellies, looking out, “—were already three thousand years old when the first farmer in Mesopotamia thought, hm, what if barley.”

“Stop,” said Mara, very quietly.

“I’m not even at the part yet,” said Eylül.

The part came later, and Eylül built up to it the way you build up to something true: by first knocking down everything cheaper.

She walked them along the inner wall, out of D, to where a smaller, later enclosure sat half-cleared, and here the procedural grain was thick on the ground — a clipboard zip-tied to a stake with the day’s grid references, a row of finds-bags weighted with stones, a hand-lettered sign in three languages saying DO NOT SIT ON THE PIL-LARS that someone, evidently, had needed to make. The whole site ran on string and patience and the goodwill of a provincial museum forty minutes away that was perennially one budget cycle from disaster.

“The story you’ve heard,” Eylül said, “is *temple of the nomads*. Schmidt’s phrase, near enough — a holy place, a sanctuary, built by hunter-gatherers who came here to worship and then went home, and nobody *lived* here, it was too sacred to live in.” She let it sit. “It’s a beautiful story and it’s how I got into this. And it’s wrong. Or — not wrong. Too clean.”

Naila felt the *too clean* land in her chest like a key in a lock.

“Newer work,” Eylül said, “ours, and Lee Clare’s team, and the others — we’ve got domestic structures. We’ve got grinding stones, thousands of them. We’ve got the chemistry of cereal processing in the bedrock basins. We’ve got a water-harvesting system, channels cut to catch the rain because this hill has no spring. People were *here*. Eating, grinding, drinking, for a long time. It wasn’t a cathedral that emptied out at sundown. It was lived in.”

“So it’s a village,” said Frik.

“So it’s *more* than a temple, which is more interesting, not less,” Eylül said, and there was an edge in it, fast and bright, that Naila understood was aimed at people who weren’t here — at a brochure, at a glossy dawn with the people painted out. “The ‘nobody lived here, it’s pure ritual’ line is exactly what makes it easy to sell. Empty cathedral. No descendants, no daily life, no claim. Just *heritage*. Spiritual. Universal. *For all humanity*.” She said the brochure phrase with no inflection at all, which was worse than mockery. “An empty sacred

thing belongs to whoever can afford the roof. A place people *lived* belongs to the people who lived there.”

Down-slope the generator died, ran out of something, and in the sudden quiet a sheep-bell carried up off Cemal’s land.

“Right,” said Eylül. “The potato.”

Naila had been waiting for the potato. She’d been waiting, if she was honest, to be the one to say it.

“Everybody who comes up here,” Eylül said, “looks at those two big ones in D and the maths goes off in their head. Five and a half metres. Eight, ten tonnes of limestone. Quarried—” she pointed off across the plain, “—over there, a few hundred metres, you can still see the bedrock they pulled them out of, there’s one half-cut that cracked and they left it, it’s lying there right now. So. Quarry it. Move it. Raise it. Stand it upright in a socket cut into the floor, dead vertical, eight tonnes, with no metal, no wheel, no draft animals, no writing to keep the plan in, no—”

“It’s not impossible,” Naila said.

It came out of her flat and certain and a little too loud, and Devran looked up at her, and Eylül stopped, and Naila felt the old heat of having interrupted, of being the one who couldn’t read the room — and then Eylül said, “Go on,” and meant it, and the heat went somewhere else.

“That’s the trap,” Naila said. “The maths goes off and people land on *impossible*, and from *impossible* it’s two steps to giants or — the other thing. The sky people. The lost super-race.” She made herself look at Eylül and not at the pillar. “It’s not impossible. There’s a man, Banning, ran the numbers. A pillar that size — seven people, fourteen at most, with ropes and a lubricated track. Wet clay, fat, you lay a runway and you drag it. Seven people. You and your students, this morning, plus the man with the thermos, could *theoretically* move one. Slowly. With a track. Over days.”

“You’d kill yourselves,” said Eylül, “but yes.”

“So it’s not magic and it’s not aliens.” Naila heard her own voice settle into the thing it did when the pattern was clean. “It’s worse. It’s *or-*

ganised. Somebody fed seven people for the days it took. Somebody knew the route. Somebody cut the socket to take it before it arrived, to a tolerance, because you don't adjust an eight-tonne stone after it's standing. Somebody had done it before, because look—" she pointed at the two giants, then off, vaguely, toward Karahan, toward the hills she'd surveyed and not yet said out loud, "—they did it more than once. They did it across — there's more than one hill."

"There's about twenty," Eylül said. "That we know. Maybe two hundred pillars at this site alone. We've dug about a tenth of it."

"A tenth," said Mara.

"Ninety percent's still in the ground." Eylül said it lightly, the way you say a thing you've stopped being able to fully feel because you live inside it. "Right under your feet. All up this slope. We leave it. On purpose. Because we're better at protecting it buried than we are at protecting it open, and that—" the edge again, fast, "—is the part the foundation would very much like everyone to forget by Thursday."

Frik had gone very still. Stillness, for Frik, was its own kind of weather; the tics didn't stop so much as gather, and Naila had learned to watch for the gathering the way you watch a sky. His hand came up and touched the side of the pillar — not the relief, the blank flank, the way you'd put a hand on a person's shoulder from behind to say *it's me* — and Eylül let him, didn't say *don't touch*, watched him do it.

"It's facing away," Frik said.

"Yeah," said Eylül.

"You stand—" he turned, worked it out with his whole body, the way he worked everything out, "—you stand in the ring, and they're all round you, looking *out*. Not at you. Out." His head jerked, once, the click came, "*out, out,*" the echo of his own word folding back on itself, and then, sideways, true: "*they're not looking at us. We're looking at them.*"

Eylül looked at him for a long moment.

"Say that again," she said.

Frik looked stricken — the old reflex, *I've done the wrong thing, I've*

been the wrong thing in the room — and Devran, who could not have followed the words, reached up and took hold of two of Frik's fingers in his small fist, the way the carved hands nearly held the fox, and held on, and Frik's shoulders came down half an inch.

"We're looking at them," Frik said again, smaller.

"That's it," Eylül said. "That's the thing I haven't said yet. That's the thing I wanted you up the hill to see and not just hear, because it doesn't go in down at the fire, it has to go in here, with the light right." She put her own hand flat near the flank of Pillar 18, not touching. "These aren't gods. We don't think they're gods. No faces, see — they didn't want faces. A god you'd give a face. These are *people*. Big people. Standing. With their arms and their belts and their fox, dressed like the men who carved them were dressed, and turned to face out into the dark with the living standing in among them. The dead, maybe. The ancestors. The ones who were here before and are watching now. You come up the hill, you stand in the ring, and you are standing in a room full of your own enormous dead, who are bigger than you and stand straighter than you and are not looking at you — they're looking *past* you, at the dark, at what's coming, keeping watch."

Nobody said anything. Down-slope someone got the generator going again and nobody heard it.

"And here's the question my professor asked me," Eylül said, "the first week, that I've never put down. Why would hunter-gatherers — people with no farms, no granaries, no surplus, people who live by following the herds and the seasons and *moving* — why would those people, of all people, stay in one place long enough to do *this*?" She gestured at all of it, the ring, the giants, the buried slope, the twenty hills. "Because *this* takes staying. You can't move an eight-tonne stone on a Tuesday and keep up with a herd. You can't carve a fox into limestone with a flint in an afternoon. You have to *stay*. You have to come back, year on year, to the same hill. And the staying has to be fed. You can't feed seven people dragging a stone for ten days on what you forage that morning. You need a store. You need grain you've put by."

She let the next thing arrive on its own.

"So which came first?" she said. "We always told it one way round.

People learn to farm — they get surplus — surplus gives them free time — free time and surplus build temples. Farming, *then* this.” She shook her head slowly. “Look at the dates. *This* is older than the farming. The monument comes *first*. So the question some of us are asking — and I want to be careful, this is a live argument, this is not settled, there are people I respect who’d fight me on the floor of a conference about it—” the procedural caution in her, the scientist’s reflex, even here, even now, “—the question is whether it’s the other way round. Whether the *gathering* came first. Whether people came together to build this, to stand with their dead on this hill, in numbers, year on year — and *that’s* what made them invent the staying. The store. The grain. The settling. The farm.”

She looked round at the four of them.

“Whether we didn’t build the temple because we became farmers,” she said. “Whether we became farmers because we wanted to build the temple.”

Naila felt it the way she felt a wrong number in a column go right — a physical thing, a click low in the body, except this click did not close. It opened.

She had spent her life being handed the moment where the beautiful thing gets explained and goes grey. The trick was always the same; the magician shows you the wire and the levitation dies. She had braced for it on the boards an hour ago. She braced for it now, the answer to *what is it for*, certain it would shrink the hill to a diagram.

It didn’t shrink. The function was the most grounded thing imaginable — a room to stand with the dead, a reason to gather, a load-bearing wall under the whole invention of *us* — and it made the hill *enormous*. It pushed the wonder out, not in. It said: the famous loud thing, the farm, the city, the writing, the wheel, all the things the school books put first — maybe none of them came first. Maybe first there was a hill, and a reason to come back to it, and people who loved their dead enough to drag eight tonnes of limestone up a slope to stand them up so they’d keep watch. And out of *that* — out of the gathering, the wanting-to-be-here, the staying — came the rest. Came everything. Came her, eleven and a half thousand years downstream, standing in the ring at seven in the morning with the

honest light on a stone man's bent arm.

The maybe in her chest got heavier and not lighter.

And the too-clean measure she still hadn't said out loud — the proportions she'd pulled off three different hills that should not have shared a single ruler and somehow did, the thing that sat under everything Eylül had just said and made it *larger* in a direction Naila could not yet name — that she still did not say. Not because she didn't trust them. Because it wasn't the morning's. The morning was Eylül's, and Eylül had handed them the meaning, and you don't grab a thing that's being given to you with both your hands.

She looked across the ring. Mara had lowered the camera all the way, was holding it against her chest with both arms like you'd hold something sleeping, and her face had the look it got — Naila had learned to read it — the look of a woman deciding, again, not to take the shot that would put this on a billion screens with a font over it. *Ask first. Sometimes don't.* The pillar's fingers, the boy's small fist round Frik's two, the giants looking out into the dark: she let all of it stay where it was, in the air, unconsumed.

"Can I—" Mara started, and stopped, and started again, turning to Eylül, the discipline coming hard but coming. "The pillar. Just the pillar, the arm and the hand, the relief. Not Devran. Not — not a feature for anybody. For you. For the file. If you say yes."

Eylül looked at her, and at the camera, and at the hill that ninety percent of belonged to no foundation on earth.

"The arm," she said. "Yes. The light's good for another twenty minutes." A beat. "And you send me the file, and it stays the site's, not yours, and not theirs. Deal."

"Deal," said Mara, and lifted the camera at last, and took the cap off, and the small mechanical sound of it was the loudest thing in the ring.

Out past the canopy, down by the rope at the head of the boards, a shape that had been still for an hour was no longer there, and none of them had seen it go, and on the rail where it had stood a folded square of white cotton, very clean, had been left weighted under a stone, the way you mark a thing you'll come back to.

Eylül saw it. She didn't say anything about it.

"Thursday," she said instead, and the field leader came back up over her like a coat, and the warmth of the morning folded itself away into the work. "Reyes brings his lawyers and his roof money and his *for all humanity*. And his whole pitch is the brochure. The empty cathedral. Nobody lived here, no one to ask, just heritage going to waste in a poor province that can't keep the lights on." She looked at the buried slope, the unopened ninety percent, the giants keeping their watch. "We let that story stand, he walks off with the part that's still in the ground."

She turned and started up the boards, and they followed, the boy's hand still in Frik's, the light going ordinary.

"So," she said, without turning round, "how do you break a man who genuinely believes he's the one rescuing it?"

Chapter 14 — Clean Hands

Thursday came in white. The plain held its heat from before dawn, and by the time the convoy raised its dust on the access road — two glossy hire SUVs and a third car behind, lower, official plates — the light had already gone flat and merciless, the kind of light Naila hated because it killed shadow and shadow was how she read depth. Without shadow the pillars looked drawn rather than carved. She stood at the rail at the head of the boards and counted the vehicles and counted the men getting out of them and the numbers settled her the way numbers did. Three cars. Four men in shirts that had been ironed somewhere with electricity. Two women with lanyards. One man in a linen jacket who waited by the lead car until the dust laid itself down before he moved, because his shoes were pale and good.

That was Reyes. She knew him from the brochure before she knew him from the man.

“He waited for the dust,” she said.

Beside her, Frik bounced once on his toes, a settling motion, his hand loose now — Devran had been taken back to the village before sunup, Eylül firm about that, *not today, not with lawyers* — and he echoed it back to her under his breath, *waited for the dust, waited for the dust*, the way he held a true thing in his mouth to keep it. Then, louder, not to anyone: “Clean shoes.”

“Frik,” said Mara, low.

“It’s not — I’m not —” His shoulder jerked. “It’s just true.”

“I know it’s true,” Mara said. “Keep it for later.”

Eylül didn't look round at any of them. She stood at the top of the boards with a clipboard she did not need and a thermos of her uncle's tea she did, and she watched the linen jacket come up the slope with the ironed shirts fanning slightly behind him, and Naila watched her watch, and learned more from Eylül's stillness than from all three cars.

Reyes stopped a courteous two metres off and put out his hand. "Dr. Demir."

"Mr. Reyes."

"Anton, please." He had the handshake of a man who'd been told his handshake was good. He turned the warmth of it on the rest of them like a lamp finding a corner. "And these must be the famous internet people. I watch, you know. I'm not embarrassed to say it. The episode on the chalk figures — the woman, Edie Vane —" he pressed a hand briefly to his own sternum, a man locating his sincerity, "— it stayed with me. You found a person under the data. Most people just find the data."

"We found a person," Mara said. Her camera was at her hip, capped. She had not lifted it. Naila clocked the cap and read the choice in it.

"That's the gift, isn't it." Reyes turned, took in the ring of pillars below, the canopy, the boards, the buried slope behind it all going up brown and patient toward the crown of the hill. He let himself be moved by it, and the thing Naila could not get past — the thing that made her arithmetic itch — was that he wasn't faking it. The brochure's prose had read like a lie. The man in front of it did not. He looked at the giants the way you'd look at someone in a hospital bed.

"Eleven and a half thousand years," he said. "Before the wheel. Before pottery. Schmidt pulls it out of a slope in the nineties and the whole story of us has to be rewritten — monuments first, then the farm, then the city, then everything. And it's *here*." He said *here* like a wound. "In a province that can't keep a museum's air-conditioning running through August. I've seen the budget lines, Dr. Demir. I've seen what reaches the dig and what doesn't. The geophysics says there are twenty enclosures under that hill. You've opened, what —"

"You know what we've opened."

"Two. You've opened two, properly. The rest is sitting in the ground while the slope moves and the water table does what water tables do

and the funding gets voted on in Ankara by men who've never held a flint." He spread his hands, clean, open, nothing in them. "I'm not here to take anything. I'm here to keep it from being lost by neglect. The Trust puts a roof — a real roof, climate-controlled, the conservation it deserves — over the unexcavated enclosures *before* the next collapse, not after. We fund the dig you can't fund. The finds stay catalogued, stay studied, stay —" a small smile, "— stay *yours*, on paper. We just hold the door open. For all humanity. That's all heritage is. A door somebody pays to keep open."

It was a good speech. Naila could feel how good it was, the way you can feel a tune is in tune without being able to say why. Every line of it was a true line. The air conditioning did fail in August. The funding was voted on by men who'd never held a flint. The slope did move. And under all those true lines, like the dressed face of a pillar over the rough back you weren't meant to see, sat the thing that wasn't said, and Naila's whole body bent toward the unsaid thing the way it always did, the gap in the ledger, the entry that should be there and wasn't.

"For all humanity," Eylül repeated. Flat. "Whose roof."

"The Trust's, in the build phase, then —"

"Whose name on the access agreement. For how long. With what clause about the catalogue if the funding chain breaks." She didn't raise her voice. She had her uncle's tea in one hand. "I read the draft, Mr. Reyes. Page eleven. The rights to the *unexcavated material* — the ninety percent still in the ground, the stuff nobody's recorded yet, the stuff that has no provenance because it's never been touched — those convey to the Trust on signature. Not the finds we've already catalogued. The *unknown* ones. The ones where nobody can ever check what came out of which enclosure, because there's no record yet, because they're still in the dirt."

A small pause. The ironed shirts had stopped fanning.

"That's standard salvage language," Reyes said, and his voice didn't change, and that was the tell, Naila thought; a man defending a clean thing gets warmer, a man defending a clean-*looking* thing keeps very level. "Material without secure context is —"

"Is everything that's left," Eylül said. "That's the point. The ten per-

cent that's dug, that's published, that has Schmidt's name and mine and the radiocarbon attached — you don't want that. You can't sell that, it's witnessed. You want the ninety percent that's never been seen, the part where a pillar can come out of enclosure C and surface in a private collection in Geneva labelled *Anatolia, ca. 9000 BCE, ex-Trust conservation programme*, and there is no slope diagram, no find number, no me, to say it's a lie."

The plain was very quiet. A bird did something far off. One of the lanyard women looked at her shoes.

Reyes did not look at his shoes. He looked at Eylül with what Naila could only read as genuine hurt, and it frightened her more than a sneer would have, because a sneer she could have done the arithmetic on.

"You think I'm a thief," he said quietly.

"I think you believe you're a rescuer," Eylül said. "I think that's worse, because it means you'll do it with a clear conscience and a press release."

Mara had the camera off her hip now. Naila watched her bring it up to chest height, not to her eye, the lens still capped, holding it the way you hold a tool you haven't decided to use. There was a drone up — Naila had heard it before she'd seen it, a wasp note over the canopy, one of the Trust's, a little white quadcopter making its slow pretty arc over the enclosure to gather the footage that would become the promo, the *for all humanity* sizzle reel, the empty cathedral set to strings. It hung over Pillar 18 and his fox and his fingered hands and it would have him for the brochure by lunchtime.

"They're filming," Mara said, not loud. To Eylül. Asking.

"Let them," Eylül said. "It's a public site under permit. They can film the stones." A beat. "They can't film the people without consent. That's the law and it's also the line, and Devran's home for a reason." She glanced at Mara. "Same goes for you."

"I know," Mara said. And she did the thing then that Naila had watched her not-quite-do for a week — she lowered the camera back to her hip and left the cap on, and stood with empty hands in

front of the best frame of her professional life, the lawyers and the giants and the linen jacket and the lie, the photograph that would have gone everywhere with her name on it, and she let it go past her ungrabbed. Naila felt the cost of it come off her like heat off a stone. Witnessing without consuming. The discipline of the not-taken shot.

“Page eleven won’t stop him,” Mara said under her breath. “He’ll argue salvage language till the funding window closes and then it’s signed and it’s done. He’s not wrong that the slope’s moving. That’s the horrible part. He’s *not wrong about the slope.*”

And that was the hook in it, Naila understood — not a hook anyone had set, just the true geometry of the thing. Reyes had built his grab out of true facts and pointed them at a real wound. You couldn’t break him by calling him a liar, because the bricks were honest. You had to find the one place where the honest bricks didn’t add up.

So she did the arithmetic.

She’d been doing it under everything else, the way she always did, the numbers running like a tap she couldn’t turn off, and now she let them come to the front. The Trust’s pitch rested on a single load-bearing claim, repeated in the brochure and twice this morning in the linen jacket’s own mouth: *neglect*. That the site was being lost. That the part in the ground was perishing faster than the underfunded local team could save it, and therefore needed rescue, and therefore the rescuer’s clauses were mercy.

She pulled the geophysics in her head. She’d read the published survey three times on the flight, the magnetometry, the ground-penetrating radar grids, the ~20 enclosures, the ~200 pillars at this hill alone, the famous ~10% opened and ~90% sleeping. The numbers were beautiful and they were stable. And stability was the thing.

“How fast is the slope moving,” Naila said.

Everyone looked at her. She didn’t like everyone looking at her and she kept going anyway because the number mattered more than the looking.

Reyes recovered first, gracious. “Centimetres a year, in the worst sectors. Over a decade —”

“Centimetres a year.” She had it now, clean, and the cleanness of it was the only comfortable thing in the white morning. “You said the slope’s moving and the water table’s doing what water tables do and the next collapse is coming and that’s why the ninety percent has to be rescued *now*, this funding window, this signature. But the survey’s been run three times in twenty-five years. Schmidt’s grid, the DAI grid, the 2019 grid. And the enclosures haven’t moved. The magnetometry overlays. The anomalies sit in the same place to within the instrument error. The thing that’s been holding them for eleven and a half thousand years —” she nodded down at the buried slope, at whatever it was that had put the dirt over the giants, the backfill they fought about, the landslide they fought about, the argument nobody on earth had won, “— whatever buried them, intentional or a slope-wash, it’s the same dirt that’s been protecting them since the Neolithic. It’s not racing the collapse. It’s the *reason* there’s anything left to find. The ground is the conservation. It’s been the conservation for ninety-six centuries. Your roof isn’t saving it from neglect. There’s no neglect. There’s just dirt that’s slower than your funding cycle.”

She ran out of breath. Her hands were doing the thing where they pressed flat against her thighs, hard, and she let them, because nobody was making her stop.

“That’s —” Reyes began.

“The urgency is invented,” Naila said. “Not the slope. The slope’s real, you were right about the slope. The *urgency* is invented. You need it to be perishing this quarter so the clause that hands you the unrecorded ninety percent looks like mercy instead of a buy. But the radiocarbon’s secure and the survey overlays and the dirt’s slower than you. There’s no clock. You built a clock.”

The drone wasp-noted over them. Somewhere a vehicle ticked, cooling.

“It’s a great deal of confidence,” Reyes said, and now there was an edge under the warmth, the first one, fine as a flint flake, “from a woman who read a survey on a plane.”

“I read it three times,” Naila said, because that was the relevant fact.

That was the moment, and afterward Naila could reconstruct it exactly, the way she could reconstruct anything, because it had a clean shape — the relay, no one of them able to carry it alone, the thing that only worked because it went hand to hand.

Naila had the arithmetic. *There's no clock; the ground is the conservation.* It killed the *neglect* claim cold. But arithmetic doesn't move a room; it only loads the chamber. The room was full of men in ironed shirts who could take a true number and bury it under salvage language and slope diagrams until the white light moved off the hill and the moment passed and the brochure went out anyway, *for all humanity*, strings rising.

Mara had the lens. She'd just declined the photograph that would have made her — and now she lifted the camera at last, off her hip, to her eye, and Naila heard the cap come off, that small mechanical sound, and Reyes turned toward it on reflex the way a man with good shoes turns toward a camera, his face arranging itself into the sincere wound, the rescuer's grief. And Mara held him there, not even shooting, just *aimed*, holding the linen jacket in the frame in front of his own drone, and the holding said: *I see which picture this is. I know the difference between the frame that documents you and the frame that helps you. I'm choosing.* He didn't know which she'd take. That uncertainty was a leash and she had him on it for one second, two.

And in that held second, with Reyes's face turned and arranged and the room gone still around the unanswered number, Frik Basson's body did the thing it had done his whole life in every room they'd thrown him out of. His shoulder jerked. His head pulled left. And the truth came up out of him the way it always came, involuntary, exquisitely timed, landing in the silence where it could not be taken back:

"You already have a buyer."

Nobody breathed.

Frik's hand flew to his own mouth, the old reflex, the apology that had lived in his body since he was six. "I didn't — I'm not —" The shoulder again. "Sorry. Sorry. It just —"

But it was out. And Naila watched Anton Reyes's clean-handed face

do, for less than a second, the one thing the brochure could never do: it confirmed. Not in words. The brochure would never use words. It was the flick — the involuntary glance, fast as Frik's tic and just as honest, toward the third car, the low one, the official plates, where a man had stayed inside with the windows up the whole morning, a man nobody had introduced, the man you bring when the deal is already done and you're here to witness the signature. The flick said *how does he know*. And the *how does he know* said *there's a he to know about*.

Mara's shutter fired. Once. Naila heard it. Not the empty-cathedral frame, not the giants and the strings. The frame of a man in a linen jacket glancing at the car that held the buyer, in the half-second after a stranger's involuntary mouth had named the thing the salvage language was built to hide.

That was the one. That was the photograph that documented the hole instead of decorating it.

"That's enough," Reyes said. The warmth was gone now. Not into a sneer — he was too good for a sneer — but into the flat administrative cold of a man recalculating exposure. "Dr. Demir, I think we've —"

"Eylül," said Eylül. "If we're past *Anton*, we're past *Dr. Demir*. And no. We're not done. *I'm* not done." She set the thermos down on the rail, deliberate, the way you put down a thing you've finished holding so your hands are free. "You came here Thursday because Thursday's when the provincial committee meets in Urfa and you wanted the access agreement on the table before they sat. You wanted my signature this morning so it'd read as the local archaeologist's blessing." She took her phone out. "The committee's in session in forty minutes. The Director of the Museum is on it. Cemal Demir's cousin's on it — that's how a poor province that can't keep the air-con running actually works, Mr. Reyes, it works on cousins, it's the densest provenance network you'll ever fail to buy. I'm sending three things to that committee right now. The survey overlay that says there's no collapse clock — that's hers." A nod at Naila, brief, exact, *hers*, and Naila felt the credit land where it should, the relay acknowledged. "Page eleven, highlighted, the unrecorded-material conveyance. And one photograph." She didn't look at Mara. "If she'll license it to the site and not to a wire."

"It's the site's," Mara said. "It was always going to be the site's."

"Then it's evidence," Eylül said, "not a scoop. Send it to me."

The phone made its sound. Off it went — the number, the clause, the flicked glance — over the white plain toward a committee room in Sanliurfa where men who'd held flints would read it with cousins' eyes.

Reyes stood very still in his clean shoes. The drone, up over Pillar 18, kept making its pretty arc, gathering footage for a promo that had just, somewhere in the last ninety seconds, become unusable — because you cannot cut *for all humanity* over a deal the local committee voted down on Thursday morning with the archaeologist's number in their hands and the buyer's car in the photograph.

"You'll lose the funding," he said. It came out almost gentle. Almost a warning offered in good faith, and Naila believed it was, half of it; the slope was real, the air-con did fail, the men in Ankara had never held a flint. "Whatever you think I am. The roof was real. The conservation was real. You're choosing the slope over the science because you won't take a clean man's hand."

"I'm choosing the ground that's held it for ninety-six centuries," Eylül said, "over a man who built a clock to scare me out of it. The slope's slower than you. She did the arithmetic." A breath. "Go to your committee meeting, Mr. Reyes. We'll be at ours."

He went down the boards the way he'd come up them, unhurried, a man who would survive this and try the next province, and his ironed shirts went down after him, and the low car with the windows up turned around without anybody getting out of it, and the drone peeled off the sky and went home to its case. Naila watched the dust raise itself and lay itself back down. Three cars out. The number was satisfying. The number was the same as the number coming in and that was correct.

Down by the rope at the head of the boards, near where Reyes had paused for his shoes that morning, a folded square of white cotton sat weighted under a stone, very clean, exactly where it had been left, and a shape that might have been standing near it for the last hour was, when Naila looked properly, not there, and the dust by the rail

held no clean print of any boot. Eylül looked at the white square and didn't say anything about it, which Naila had learned was its own kind of saying.

The pillars stood in their ring, fingered hands meeting over their belts, foxes at their loincloths, watching the cars go the way they'd watched everything go for eleven and a half thousand years, and the ninety percent slept under the slope behind them, unrecorded, unprovenanced, unbought, slower than any clock a clean-handed man could build.

"For now," Eylül said. She picked her thermos back up off the rail. "It holds for now."

She poured tea into the cap of it, her uncle's tea, dark and oversweet, and handed it not to Naila and not to Mara but to Frik Basson, who had said the true thing in the room where it couldn't be taken back, the way his body had said true things in every room that had ever shown him the door — except this one.

"Drink," she said. "You did a thing."

And Frik took the cup in both hands, and his shoulder jerked once, settling, and he didn't apologise for it.

Chapter 15 — The Promo, Shelved

The promo died in a way Mara almost missed, which was the way the good ones always went — not with a press release but with a non-event, a thing that simply stopped being scheduled.

She found out from Eylül's phone, third-hand, eight days after the convoy left. They were sitting under Cemal's awning at the edge of the village, the four of them and Eylül, in the long flat light of late afternoon when the plain went the colour of wet straw and the heat let off its grip an inch at a time. Cemal had strung the awning between the house wall and two poles years before any of them were born, and the canvas had gone soft and pale and patched, and under it the temperature dropped maybe four degrees and the world became survivable. He brought tea without asking. He always brought tea without asking. The little tulip glasses sweated and the sugar sat undissolved in the bottom like silt.

Eylül turned her phone around so Mara could see it. A page from the Anatolia Heritage Trust's site, the kind of glossy that cost money to look effortless. There had been a film. *Cradle: The First Temple* — a teaser, ninety seconds, drone sweeps over Enclosure D scored to a cello and a heartbeat, a voice that pronounced *eleven thousand five hundred years* the way you'd announce a sale. Anton Reyes in a linen shirt, gesturing at the pillars with an open hand, generous, a man giving the past back to the world.

It was gone. Where the embed had been there was a grey rectangle and a line of small type. *This video is unavailable.*

"Shelved," Eylül said. She said it flat, the way she said most things,

but Mara had learned that flatness in her was not absence. It was a held breath. “Their distribution partner pulled out. The museum sent a letter — the regional directorate, copied to the ministry. Two paragraphs. Very polite. The film, they said, made claims about the management and condition of a registered first-degree archaeological site that were not consistent with the record.”

“Translation,” said Naila. She had her back to the house wall, where there were no people behind her, only stone, and the awning made one clean edge of shade she sat exactly inside of. She’d counted the glasses when Cemal set them down. Mara had watched her do it. Five glasses, five people, and her shoulders had come down a notch when the numbers agreed.

“Translation,” Eylül said, and almost smiled. “Their ending walked out the back door.”

Frik, who had been quiet, who had been turning his tea glass a quarter-turn at a time and setting it down and turning it again, said, “*Made claims that were not consistent.*” He said it twice. The second time softer, tasting it. Then, not to anyone: “They built the ending first. Same as the people who built the hill. Built the ending and went looking for the dig to fit it.”

Nobody told him he’d said something. Eylül looked at him for a second the way she’d looked at the white square of cotton folded under the stone, and let it sit.

The thing Mara kept coming back to, the thing that had taken eight days to surface, was how easy the promo had made it look.

Ninety seconds. A man’s open hand. The drone rising off the slope and the music doing the work, telling you what to feel before you’d seen anything, and the whole astonishing argument of the place — *monuments first, the impossible inversion, hunter-gatherers raising eight-tonne portraits of the dead six thousand years before anyone thought to* — flattened into a tagline you could license. *The First Temple*. Solved. Branded. Ready to be saved by the man who’d license it.

She’d spent two weeks now on the actual ground the drone had flown over. She knew what the drone had skipped.

She'd watched a graduate student named Berna spend a full morning on her knees with a wooden tool and a paintbrush, clearing four centimetres of fill from beside a pillar base, photographing every layer before she lifted it, logging it, bagging it, because the dirt was the document — the order things lay in was the only sentence the site would ever speak, and once you stirred it you'd torn the page. She'd watched Eylül argue for forty minutes with the museum's conservator about whether to consolidate a section of relief or leave it, and the argument was not about beauty, it was about reversibility, about whether a glue invented this decade would betray them in fifty years. She'd watched a man with a total station shoot points off a pillar's edge for an hour to get a contour the drone got in one pass and got *wrong*, because the drone saw the surface and the man was building the bones.

That was the gap. That was the whole gap. The promo was the open hand. The dig was the four centimetres a morning.

She'd nearly photographed Berna at it — the brush, the kneeling, the absolute patience — and had asked first, and Berna had laughed and said *not my hands, my hands are filthy*, and Mara had put the camera down. She was getting better at putting the camera down. It still cost her. It would always cost her. There was a frame she could have taken that morning that would have been beautiful and true and would have made the careful slowness of real archaeology visible to a hundred thousand people, and she'd let it go because *not my hands* was a no, and a soft no was still a no, and the discipline only meant anything when it cost you the good shot.

She thought, sometimes, about the frames she hadn't taken in other places, years ago, the ones she'd taken instead, the ones that had made her name and were still out there in the world doing whatever they did to the people in them. She didn't think about it under the awning. The awning was a place you could not think about it. That was what the awning was for.

"So that's it," said Frik. "They go away."

"They go quiet," Eylül said. "Different thing. The page-eleven language is still language. The Trust still exists. The money still exists." She turned the glass in her fingers. "Reyes believes he's the good

guy, you understand. That's the part the film got right about him. He looks at this plain and he sees neglect — provincial budgets, one conservator for a region of sites, a directorate that can't afford the fence it needs. He's not wrong about the neglect. He's wrong about who gets to fix it and what it costs them." She set the glass down. "A man who's right about the problem is harder to send away than a man who's wrong about everything. He'll be back. Next season, next directorate, next government. He has time. He thinks he has more time than us."

"He doesn't," Naila said.

Everyone looked at her.

"He has the same amount of time as the hill," Naila said, to the middle distance, where it was easier to talk. "Which is a hundred years, maybe, of him and the people who think like him, before they die or it goes out of fashion. And the hill has been there eleven thousand five hundred years and ninety percent of it is still down there." She tipped her chin at the slope, invisible from here behind the rise of the land. "Twenty enclosures. Around two hundred pillars at Göbekli alone and they've cleared, what, a tenth. The rest is under the slope. It's not going anywhere on his clock. It only goes somewhere if someone digs it the wrong way fast, which is the thing he wants the permission to do." She paused. The arithmetic of it settled her, Mara could see — the dread of the man translated into a number, and the number was on the hill's side. "He's playing a game where he runs out of time and the hill doesn't. He just doesn't know he's playing that one yet."

"That," said Eylül, "is roughly what I have been telling the directorate for three years." She looked at Naila with something that wasn't quite surprise. "You said it shorter."

"I usually do," Naila said.

Cemal came back with bread and a dish of white cheese and olives, and a small bowl of *isot* — the dark, smoky red pepper of the region, almost black — and set them down and said something to Eylül in Kurdish, and she laughed, the first full laugh Mara had heard from her, and translated: "He says you've all been here long enough to stop being guests, so now I have to feed you properly or it shames

the house.”

Frik repeated *isot*, careful with it, and Cemal beamed and nudged the bowl toward him, and Frik dipped bread and ate it and his eyes went wide and watered and he said, with total sincerity and no filter whatsoever, “*That is the best thing I have ever put in my mouth,*” and Cemal didn’t need the translation, he was already pouring more tea and laughing, a hand on Frik’s shoulder, and Frik’s shoulder jerked under it and Cemal didn’t move his hand, just rode it, the way you’d ride a horse shifting weight, and kept it there.

Mara watched the old man’s hand stay on the young man’s jumping shoulder and thought: *there*. That was the frame. That was the one. An old farmer’s brown hand on a foreign boy’s tic’ing shoulder, both of them grinning, the pepper, the bread, the light coming flat under the canvas — it would say everything, it would say more than the pillars, it would say what the whole place was *for*.

She didn’t lift the camera.

She’d have had to ask, and asking would have made the moment a moment, would have put a frame around it, would have made Cemal perform his own kindness for a lens, and the kindness was real precisely because it was not for anyone. Some things you let pass. You witnessed them and you let them go through you and out the other side and you kept nothing but the having-been-there. That was the new arithmetic. That was the thing she was learning, slower than four centimetres a morning. *Witness without consuming*. She had it written, badly, in the back of the notebook she didn’t show anyone. She was getting better at it. It still felt like a wound healing wrong, the way the no-shot ached after.

Jakobus was at the truck.

She could see him over the low wall, fifty metres off where the Beast sat in the only shade for two hundred metres, a square of canvas slung off its side that he’d rigged the first day, and under it the water bag swinging slow, weeping its slow cold down its own canvas in the way that made no sense to anyone here and that he’d explained to a fascinated Cemal with six words and a lot of pointing. He was doing something to the engine with the hood up, music low off the cab radio, that flat steady thing he ran under everything like a heartbeat. He had not come under the awning. He came under the awning sometimes

and sometimes he didn't, and when he didn't it was because he'd decided the awning was theirs, the crew's and Eylül's and Cemal's, and his job was the fifty metres of open ground between the awning and the road, and the truck, and the watching.

She'd tried to photograph him once. Week one. Reflex — he was *exactly* a photograph, the shades, the still way he held himself, the legend that came off him in the small things people said. She'd raised the camera and he'd been mid-frame and then she'd had him sharp in the viewfinder and pressed and looked at the result and there was the Beast, there was the canvas, there was the weeping bag, and the place where he'd been was a smear of heat-shimmer and a shoulder going out of frame, like the air had closed over the spot. She'd assumed she'd jogged it. She'd tried again, twice, other days. She had a folder now of beautiful empty frames with a man-shaped absence in them. The Trust's drone had a thousand hours of footage of this site and Mara would have bet money there wasn't one clean second of him in any of it. She'd stopped trying. It wasn't a thing you cracked. It was a thing you respected, like the no-shot under the awning, and after a while you stopped reaching for the man and let him be the road he was.

Eylül stood and stretched and said she wanted to show them something while the light held, and they walked — not far, just up the rise to where the village ended and the plain began and you could see, across two kilometres of stubble and the heat coming off it in sheets, the hill.

It sat there. Belly Hill. Potbelly. A low rounded swell of land the colour of everything around it, with the modern shelter roofs over the cleared enclosures catching the light like wings, and the rest of it just *land*, just a hill you'd drive past, that you *had* driven past, that everyone had driven past for eleven and a half thousand years.

"There," Eylül said. She didn't point. "Most of what matters, you can't see. That's the whole thing about it. The cleared enclosures, the pillars in the films, that's the part we know how to look at. The mound is mostly still mound." She was quiet a moment. "Klaus Schmidt — he dug here from ninety-five, he found D, he changed everything — he used to say they buried it. That when they were done with an en-

closure they filled it in on purpose, with rubble and bone and broken tools, and raised the next. They buried their own temple.” She tilted her head. “Beautiful idea. People loved it. *They buried it*. It made the place a deliberate act top to bottom.”

“And?” said Frik.

“And the work since he died says maybe not. Maybe a lot of that fill is slope — the hill washing down on itself over the centuries, landslide and slope-wash, the way a mound does.” She shrugged, and it was not a dismissive shrug, it was the shrug of someone holding two true-shaped things at once. “We don’t know. We genuinely don’t. Some of us think one thing, some the other, the same trench can argue both ways. It’s not settled and the people who tell you it’s settled are selling something.” She looked sidelong at where the Trust’s promo had been, in everyone’s memory. “Either way. Buried on purpose or buried by time, the part that matters is the same — it’s *down there*. Recorded by nobody. Yet.”

Mara looked at the hill and tried to hold the size of the thing. Ninety percent. Twenty enclosures, two hundred pillars, and under the next valleys and the next ridgelines the other hills, Karahan and the rest, the whole Tas Tepeler, the Stone Hills, a *tradition*, a thing done over and over across a region by people who were supposed to be too few and too unsettled and too early to do anything but follow the herds.

“How,” she said. “I keep coming back to how. Eight tonnes. The two big ones in D, the central pair, five and a half metres, ten tonnes maybe. No wheel. No metal. No farm to feed a workforce.” She’d seen the films say *impossible* over a swell of strings. She didn’t believe *impossible*. She didn’t know what she believed.

“It’s not impossible,” Naila said. “That’s the thing people get wrong loudest.” She had her eyes mostly on the ground in front of her feet, but her voice had gone certain, the way it did with a number. “There’s an archaeologist, Banning, ran it. You don’t need a thousand slaves. Ropes, a track, lubricate the track — water, mud, fat — and seven to fourteen people can move one pillar. Fourteen people. A big extended family. A couple of bands meeting up.” She glanced at the hill. “That’s the part that’s actually amazing and everyone skips it to say *impossible* because impossible is sexier. It wasn’t an impossible workforce. It was a *possible* one. Which is worse. Worse for the easy

story. Because if fourteen people could move it, then the question isn't *how did they have the muscle*. The question is *why did fourteen people who didn't have to, who could've just kept hunting, choose to spend that much of their short hungry lives dragging a ten-tonne stone up a hill and carving a person into it.*"

The wind came across the stubble and the awning behind them snapped once.

"That's the hole," Mara said. Quietly. "Isn't it. That's the actual hole. Not how. Why."

"That's the hole," Eylül said.

She was watching the hill and her face had changed — gone private, gone home, the museum-and-directorate armour off it for a second. When she spoke it was slower.

"You want to know what I think it's for. You've all been too polite to ask, except him—" a nod back at the truck, at the man who asked nothing else, who'd asked it the first hour, *what is it for*, the only question he ever seemed to carry. "I'll tell you what it means to the people whose ground this is. Not what it *is*. What it *means*. Different thing." She crossed her arms, not defensive, just holding herself in the wind. "The pillars are people. You've seen — the arms, the relief arms bending at the elbow, the hands, the fingers meeting over the belt. The fox loincloth on Eighteen. They're not abstract. They're not symbols of people. They *are* people, made tall and made to last, made to stand up out of the ground and not lie down. And you put them in a ring and you come in and you stand among them." She let it sit. "My grandmother would say — you go to a place to stand with the ones who've gone ahead. To be looked at by them. To not be alone with being alive. People walked a long way to stand in that ring and be watched by the tall stone dead. And to do *that* — to want it enough to drag the stone and feed the diggers — you have to stay. You have to come back to the same hill, year on year, generation on generation. You have to gather."

She turned and looked at them, all of them, and last at Frik, who had gone very still.

"And maybe," Eylül said, "you stay near the hill long enough, gathering, feeding the gathering, that someone notices the wild wheat coming

up thick where the camp middens fall, and saves a handful, and plants it the next year so there's bread for next year's gathering. Maybe the farming came to feed the building. Maybe we didn't settle down and then build temples because we could finally afford them. Maybe we built the temple first, because we couldn't *not*, and farming was the price of the temple, and being us — settled, fed, counted, owned, all of it — was the bill that came after." She uncrossed her arms. "That's not proven. Don't write it down like it's proven. It's the thing under the thing. It makes the place bigger, not smaller. The drone wanted it smaller. *First temple, solved, save it*. It's the opposite of solved." She almost smiled. "It's the most unsolved thing there is. It's the question of how we became the kind of animal that builds a thing it doesn't need and then can't go home."

Nobody said anything for a while. The light was going amber and long. Behind them Cemal called something, tea, more tea, and the word for it carried, and Jakobus's radio threaded its low steady line under the wind.

Frik said, to the hill, not to them: "They built the ending first." Third time he'd said it that day. But it had moved. It had stopped being about Reyes. "And then they had to become the people who could deserve it."

Eylül looked at him a long moment.

"Yes," she said. "I think that's exactly it. I think you should be a field archaeologist. You'd be insufferable and you'd be right a lot."

Frik went pink and his shoulder jumped and he didn't apologise for it.

They drove out the next morning. Cemal pressed bread and a twist of paper full of *isot* on them at the truck and wouldn't be argued with, and held Eylül's face in both hands and said something none of them caught and she didn't translate, and the Beast started clean and the water bag swung and wept and they went down the dirt track to the road with the dust coming up behind in the mirrors.

Mara had the camera in her lap, capped.

She didn't lift it for the village, or for Cemal getting smaller under

the awning, or for Eylül standing in the road growing out of the dust until the road bent. Some things you let pass through you and keep nothing of but the having-been.

But at the last rise, where the track climbed and the plain opened one final time before the highway swallowed it, she asked Jakobus to slow, and he did without a word, and she looked back across two kilometres of stubble to the hill.

It sat there, low and round and mostly buried, the shelter roofs catching the early light like the wings of something that hadn't decided yet whether to be born. Ninety percent of it asleep under the slope. The same measure, Eylül had said once and not explained, the same hand's-width turning up at Karahan, at the other hills, across ground that shouldn't share a ruler — and Mara had asked what she meant and Eylül had only looked at her and said *another time*, and meant it, and it had sat in Mara's chest ever since like a stone she hadn't been allowed to lift.

She raised the camera. She uncapped it. She framed the hill — just the hill, no people, only the stones and the slope and the sleeping nine-tenths — and her finger was on it, the best frame of the whole trip, the one that would make her name and say nothing it shouldn't, and she held it, and held it, and the light moved a degree, and she lowered it again without pressing.

Not yet. Not this one either.

She capped the lens and tapped the cab roof and the Beast pulled away, and the hill went down behind the rise and was gone, and the measure went with it, uncounted, into the next valley and the next hill and the question of who had walked between them with the same ruler in his hand, eleven and a half thousand years ago, leaving the same true thing in stone after stone after stone where no one had thought to look for it yet.

Chapter 16 — The Measure

The drone came up out of the southwest a little after four, while the worst of the heat was still sitting on the plain like something that had been left there to die.

Frik heard it before he saw it. He always heard the machines first — the brain that couldn't filter the world into background and foreground had its uses, and one of them was that a high small whine on the edge of the wind arrived in him fully formed, demanding, while everyone else was still pouring tea. He set his glass down on the low table under Cemal's awning. His left shoulder jumped twice, the old hitch, the one his physiotherapist in Bloemfontein had called *the gun-cock*. He let it.

"Up there," he said, and his hand went up and pointed, steady, because the pointing was a deliberate thing and the deliberate things he could mostly hold. "Two o'clock. Coming over the wadi."

Mara was already moving. She had the long lens up off her knee and against her eye before the rest of them had found the dot, tracking it across the white sky, her thumb on the focus ring, and her whole body had gone into the stillness that came over her when she worked, the stillness that was the opposite of calm, that was a held breath dressed as professionalism.

"It's theirs," she said. "Trust livery. White, the little crest on the boom." A pause while she rode it. "Survey pattern. Lawnmower lines. They're not done with this hill."

"Eight days," Eylül said. She didn't look up. She was peeling an apple for Cemal's grandson with a small black-handled knife, one long unbroken curl of skin, and the boy was watching it like it was the only

thing happening in the world, which for him it was. “Eight days they’re gone, and they leave the eyes behind.” She handed the boy the apple. She said something to him in Kurdish, low, and he laughed and ran off toward the goats with the curl of skin trailing from his fist like a streamer.

“They’re allowed?” Frik asked. “Just — to fly that. Over the dig.”

“They have *page eleven*,” Eylül said, and the way she said it the words had quotation marks you could hang washing on. “Page eleven says they have a data-sharing interest. Page eleven is a clean white room with no doors in it. The directorate is fighting page eleven in an office in Ankara with the air conditioning broken.” She set the knife down. “So yes. They are allowed to look. Looking is free. Looking is what they are best at.”

Cemal said something then, leaning forward off his cushion, his hand moving toward the hill, and Eylül translated without being asked, the way she’d been doing all afternoon, the two voices braided together so easily you forgot one of them was for the foreigners.

“My uncle says: they have been flying over this plain since before the foreigner — the German, Schmidt — since before he ever came. Surveyors. The state, the companies, the oil people who found no oil. He says the plain is very used to being measured.” Eylül’s mouth did something complicated. “He says it does not feel measured.”

Naila was not watching the drone.

She had clocked it — she’d have to be dead not to, the whine cutting a clean diagonal across the ambient field of goat-bell and generator and the wind moving in the awning’s loose corner — but she’d assigned it and moved on. A surveying UAV running a boustrophedon raster at, call it, sixty metres altitude, ground sample distance fine enough to count the courses of stone but nothing the directorate’s own photogrammetry hadn’t logged in 2019. It would learn nothing. The hole in the hill was not a thing you could photograph from above. She’d said as much to Mara two valleys ago and Mara hadn’t argued.

She was watching the numbers. She’d been watching them all afternoon, in the good way, the way that felt like cold water going down:

the page from the museum library that Eylül had let her copy out long-hand because the photocopier was broken and had been broken, by the look of the dust on it, since roughly the late Holocene. Pillar heights. Enclosure diameters. The spacing of the ring-walls. The recurring interval she'd started calling, privately, in the part of her head that named things, *the unit*.

It kept showing up. That was the whole of it and it was enormous. The central pair in Enclosure D — the two great Ts, five and a half metres, the People, the ones with arms — sat on a baseline. Measure the baseline. Measure the gap to the inner ring. Measure the modules at Karahan, twenty-odd kilometres east, a different hill, a different ridge, in the photographs and the published plans Eylül had laid out for her on the awning's plank table, weighted at the corners with tea glasses. The same interval. Not exactly the same — nothing eleven and a half thousand years old was *exactly* anything, the stone slumped, the slope crept, the German's trenches and the new Turkish trenches sampled different parts of a thing that was mostly still in the ground. But within the error. Within the kind of error you got from people, not from coincidence.

A hand's-width. A forearm. Some reach of the body, repeated, carried.

"It's not nothing," she said, to no one, which was how she said most of the things she most meant. "The measure. It's not nothing. It's under the noise but it's there. You'd need every plan, properly. Total-station, not the old tape data. But it's there."

"There you go again," Frik said, gently, the way you'd say it to someone you liked, "with your *it's there*."

"It's there," she said.

"Ja. Okay." He was smiling. The smile cost him a fast double-blink and a click of the jaw, the tics riding the warmth out the way they rode everything out, and nobody at the table so much as flickered, and that — the not-flickering — was the thing Frik had come four thousand kilometres and into a war over a hill to find. A table where his body was just weather. "So what does it *mean*, the measure. Same ruler, two hills."

Naila looked at the hill. The drone scratched its quiet lines across

the sky above it.

“I don’t know what it means,” she said. “I know it’s not random. That’s a different sentence from knowing what it means. People want those to be the same sentence and they’re not.” She put her finger on the longhand column. “This is where it goes wrong. This is exactly where someone stands up and says a *lost civilisation* or a *master race* or — the other one, the worse one —”

“Aliens,” Frik supplied, and a muscle by his eye jumped on the word, and it was not a joke, it just arrived.

“Aliens,” Naila agreed. “Because a shared measure across sites that shouldn’t share one *feels* like it needs a big answer. And it doesn’t. The boring answer is the staggering one. The boring answer is: the same people. The same *culture*. A way of building you learned from your mother’s mother, a length you carried in your own arm, that travelled the twenty kilometres between hills the way songs travel, the way a recipe travels, because someone walked it.” She stopped. “I can prove the measure’s real. I can’t prove who carried it or why. So I won’t say. I’ll say the true small thing and shut up about the big one.”

“That’s the most boring superpower I’ve ever heard,” Frik said, and meant it as the highest possible compliment, and Naila knew it, and the corner of her mouth moved.

Eylül had been listening. She had a way of listening that didn’t look like listening, that looked like apple-peeling and tea-pouring and watching her uncle’s hands, and then she’d say one thing that proved she’d had the whole conversation in her hands the entire time.

“You’re afraid of saying the wrong big thing,” she said to Naila, “so you say no big thing. That’s a good fear. Keep it.” She turned a photograph around on the table so it faced them — a glossy thing, a frame from the Trust’s film, the one that had been pulled. *Cradle: The First Temple*. Anton Reyes had handed copies around the village like sweets, in the first days, before any of them understood what the foundation was. In the frame, the central pillars of Enclosure D glowed honey-gold under lighting that had been hauled up the hill at considerable expense, and a sonorous caption hung beneath them: *AT THE DAWN OF TIME, A LOST PEOPLE BUILT A MIRACLE THEY COULD NOT EXPLAIN.*

“This,” Eylül said, “is the wrong big thing. Two wrong big things, actually, in one sentence, which is efficient of them.” She tapped *lost*. “Not lost. We know who. Hunter-gatherers, here, on this ground, the people who became the people in that village over there pouring you tea — there isn’t a clean wall between them and us, that’s a thing the film wants you to feel, the *lostness*, so you’ll think it needs rescuing.” She tapped *could not explain*. “And this. This is the one that does the work. *Could not explain*. Make the builders into mysteries and you make their hill into a mystery, and a mystery has no owner, a mystery belongs to whoever can fund the helicopter.” She sat back. “They built it. They could explain it perfectly. We’re the ones who can’t, and we’ve decided to call that *their* mystery instead of our ignorance, because it sells better and it costs us nothing.”

The drone changed its note. They all heard it. It had reached the end of its raster and it banked, the white speck tilting, and it came back over the hill on the return line, lower now, and Mara tracked it the whole way with the long lens to her eye and her breath held and her finger nowhere near the shutter.

Here is what Mara could see, and what the drone could see, and the difference between them, which was the whole of her work:

The drone saw the hill. Ground sample distance fine enough to count stones. It would go home tonight to a server in a building she’d never enter and it would be stitched into an orthomosaic, a flat true god’s-eye map of every exposed pillar, accurate to the centimetre, completely correct, and it would be a lie the way an orthomosaic is always a lie, because it would have no light in it that meant anything and no person in it at all.

Mara saw the table. She saw Frik’s shoulder hitch and settle, hitch and settle, a metronome no one had asked for that the table had absorbed into its weather. She saw Naila’s finger on the longhand column, the stillness of someone for whom the numbers were not cold but warm, were the warmest thing, were the place the noise stopped. She saw Eylül’s hands, which were the most eloquent thing in the frame and which Mara would not photograph, because Eylül hadn’t said she could, and the asking and the not-photographing had become, over these weeks, the actual content of Mara’s days — the

long slow undoing of the reflex that had made her name on other people's worst hours, the reflex she'd come here precisely because she could no longer obey.

She lowered the lens. Her hands were steady. They hadn't always been; there were mornings the camera still felt like the thing she'd been holding the day she stopped being able to hold it, in a different country, with a different smell. Today they were steady. She set the camera in her lap and looked at the table with her own eyes, which was its own discipline, the hardest one.

"He's not in any of it," she said.

"Who's not," Frik said.

"Jakobus." She nodded at the hill, at the drone, at the air. "They've flown that thing over us — what, four times now, since they left? And the day they did their big survey flyover, the real one, the calibrated one, the day they brought the second drone and ran it for three hours —" she stopped. "That was the day Cemal had him under here. The whole day. Tea and the long table and that thing they did with the —" she gestured, helpless, at the memory of two men who didn't share fifty words trying to argue about engines. "He was off every lens for the only hour it mattered. And I tried, after. I've tried for weeks. I have a thousand frames of this trip and I have him in maybe nine of them, and in all nine he's turned, or it's his back, or there's dust, or the focus walked, or he's exactly behind the awning post." A short breath that was nearly a laugh. "I'm a professional. I made my living being the person who got the shot. And I cannot get a clean shot of that man to save my life."

"He doesn't like cameras," Eylül said.

"It's not that he doesn't like them." Mara was working it as she said it, the way she'd learned to from these three, saying the true small thing and not reaching past it. "I've photographed a hundred men who don't like cameras. You get them anyway, the ones who don't like it, you get them best, the not-liking is *in* the picture. This is different. It's like —" and she stopped, because she'd been about to caption it, to put a sentence under it that named it, and that was exactly the thing she didn't do anymore. She left it. "I don't have a word for it. I just keep not having the shot."

Across the yard, by the low wall where the goats came through, the man himself was crouched on his heels in the late gold light, doing something with his hands that none of them could quite see — the field-kit spread on a cloth, the little tin he carried everywhere, the cayenne he swore by for reasons that had made sense in a desert two continents away and made no sense here and worked anyway, the always-clean white hanky folded into a square that no amount of this red dust seemed able to dirty. He had the water bag off the Beast's wing mirror and he was hanging it from a nail in the shade so it could weep itself cool the way it did, the way it had no business doing in this dry, and Cemal was watching him do it with the frank delight of a farmer watching a stranger's trick that he intends to steal.

Mara looked at the two of them. The light was perfect. It was the kind of light she'd flown into war zones to chase, low and gold and forgiving, raking across the wall, the two crouched men, the weeping bag, the goats coming through. It was the photograph. It would have been a beautiful photograph and it would have said something true about how a man carries his home across the world in a tin, and it would have belonged to nobody who'd consented to it, and she lifted the camera and put it to her eye and framed it and the focus walked.

It just walked. The lens hunted, the way good glass doesn't, racked past him and came back and sat down a half-metre short, on the wall, on a goat, on the bright nothing of the dust, and by the time she'd thumbed it back the light had moved a degree and the men had shifted and the picture was gone.

She lowered the camera.

"See," she said, to no one, and there was no fear in it, only a kind of laughter she didn't have to explain to this table. "Nine frames. Nine, in a thousand."

Naila looked up from her numbers. "It's not a thing," she said, mildly, because she could not help saying it, because she heard the shape of where the table's mood wanted to go and she put her small cold true hand on it before it could leave the ground. "The focus. It's not a thing. It's dust, and heat shimmer off the wall, and a long lens at the worst hour for it. There's no — there's nothing *in* it. It's nine out of a thousand because a thousand is a lot of frames and nine is exactly the number of accidents you'd expect." She said it to protect

them. She said it because the worst big thing wears the costume of the best small mystery, and she would not let it in even here, even for a friend, even for a man she loved. “He’s just a guy who’s always behind the post.”

“Ja,” Frik said, and his jaw clicked, and he was grinning into his tea. “He’s just a guy who’s always behind the post.” His shoulder jumped. “*Always behind the post*,” he said again, the echo riding out of him unbidden, and then, in the flat helpless honest voice that was his other body, the one that said the thing the room had agreed not to say — “but you can’t photograph him.”

It hung there. Nobody picked it up. Naila let it sit because it was, narrowly, true — Mara *couldn’t* — and Naila only ever fought the false thing. Eylül smiled into her glass. The drone whined off toward the southwest, its lawnmower done, going home to its server to make its perfect lying map of every stone it could see and none of the ones it couldn’t.

And out by the wall, the man no camera could hold stood up out of his crouch, and turned the water bag a quarter so it would weep on the other face, and said something short to Cemal in the four words of the local tongue he’d troubled himself to learn — a greeting, the one that meant *I see you*, the one he carried from home and laid down wherever he went like a coin on a counter — and Cemal laughed and clapped him on the arm, and the two of them stood looking not at each other and not at the camera but out at the hill, at the low round buried nine-tenths of it, the way men stand when they’re looking at a thing one of them has made and the other one understands.

Because that was the question. Mara watched the back of him, the only angle she’d ever get, and thought it without saying it. He read made things. He’d walked up the hill the first day and stood in front of the great central pair, the five-and-a-half-metre People with their relief arms bent at the elbow and their long fingers meeting over the belt, the one in the fox-pelt with the fox held against him like a thing he loved, and he hadn’t said *who* and he hadn’t said *how* and he hadn’t said *aliens* and he hadn’t, mercifully, said *miracle*. He’d put his shades up on his head and looked at the stone people a long time and asked the only question that had ever interested him about anything anyone had ever built.

What is it for.

And the answer to that one wasn't his. It wasn't Naila's, who could prove the measure but not read it. It wasn't Mara's, who could frame the hole but couldn't fill it. It wasn't Frik's, whose body could say the true thing but couldn't tell you what the true thing was *for*. It belonged to the woman peeling apples for her uncle's grandson on the ground her family had farmed since before the German came, and she had been carrying it under the awning all afternoon, turning it over, deciding whether the foreigners had earned it yet.

"Eylül," Frik said. He'd felt it too — he felt everything, it was the curse and it was the gift. "You keep nearly telling us. The measure. The People with the arms. What it's *for*. You keep getting to the edge of it and then you peel another apple."

Eylül set down the knife. She looked at the hill, and then she looked at the four of them, the photographer who'd stopped consuming, the man whose body couldn't lie, the woman who'd say the small true thing and starve the big false one, and the road who'd gathered them and was standing out by the wall with his back to all of it, watching her hill go gold.

"Another time," she said — and then she heard herself, and a laugh came up out of her, real, the wariness going off her shoulders for the length of one breath. "No. No. I keep saying that. Cemal says I'm worse than the German." She wiped her hands on the cloth.

"Pour the tea," she said. "I'll tell you what it's for."

The drone was a dot now, and then it was gone, and the hill kept the only ninety percent that mattered.

Chapter 17 — Roll the Tape

The report ran to forty-one pages and it was, Naila thought, the most honest thing any of them had ever signed.

She had it open on her knee in the back of the museum's reading room — the small one, off the main hall, where the air conditioner ground like a man clearing his throat and the strip lights buzzed at a pitch she could feel behind her molars. Eylül had got them in after hours. The Şanlıurfa Archaeology Museum had let them sit with the printed draft and a box of the photographs before any of it went up the chain to the Directorate, which was either trust or a courtesy or both, and Naila had stopped trying to tell those apart somewhere around the second week on the plain.

She turned a page. The radiocarbon table was on it, and the radiocarbon table was beautiful.

Not in any way she could have said out loud to anyone but the three of them and the woman across the table. But there it was: charcoal from the fill of Enclosure D, the calibrated dates clustering hard against the back wall of the Holocene, ~9,500 BCE, the error bars tight enough to make her chest ache. Eleven and a half thousand years. Six thousand years before the first stone went into the Giza plateau. Schmidt's lab and the labs that checked Schmidt, two decades of someone scraping black flecks out of mud and asking a machine in a basement *when*, and the machine answering, and the answer holding, and holding, and holding.

People built rooms before they built fences. They raised the dead in stone before they bent a single ear of wheat to their will. The report said so in the dry voice of the discipline, with citations, and the dry voice did not make it smaller. It made it true, which was larger.

“You’re doing the face,” Frik said.

He was across the table, tipped back on two legs of a museum chair he was absolutely not allowed to tip back on, a hand going to the side of his jaw and away, to the jaw and away, the small private weather of him. He’d found the box of museum-issue pencils and was rolling one along the table-edge with one finger, back, forth, the metronome his body wanted when the rest of him went still.

“What face.”

“The numbers face. You go all —” His head ticked sideways, once, hard. “*Soft*. You look at a table of dead carbon like Cemal looks at his grandson.”

“It’s good carbon.”

“*Ja, lekker carbon*.” The pencil clicked off the table’s edge and he caught it. “Tergan loves a clean error bar.”

“Somebody has to.”

Across the room Mara was at the long table with the box of prints, not photographing them — that was the discipline, you didn’t shoot the shoot, you didn’t make a picture of a picture and call it work — but turning them with the backs of two fingers, slow, the way you’d turn the pages of something borrowed. Her own contact sheets were in there, the digital stuff burned to the museum’s drive and a set printed for the file. She’d shot eleven days on the hill and she’d handed over every frame and then she’d sat with Eylül for an afternoon and they’d pulled, together, the ones that didn’t go in. The vulture pillar at the angle that made it a poster. Cemal’s face in the gold light under the awning, which would have been the cover of something, which was exactly why it stayed in the box.

“This one’s in,” Mara said, and slid a print across to Eylül without lifting it past her own sightline. The two central pillars of D, shot flat and square and boring, a ranging rod laid against the base for scale. No drama. A document. You could measure off it.

Eylül looked at it for a while. “That’s in,” she said.

It was the potato that wouldn’t lie down in the report. It never did.

They'd put the labour arithmetic in an appendix, because Naila had refused to let it go in the body where someone could pull it out as a headline. *Appendix C: On the Question of Workforce*. Three pages. She'd written most of it and Eylül had cut a third of it and what was left was clean.

"Read me the Banning line again," Frik said. "The one you killed people with."

"I didn't kill people."

"You killed a *narrative*. I watched you do it. It was beautiful, like a fish gutting a fish."

She found it. She didn't read it like a victory. She read it the way she'd written it, flat, because flat was the only honest pressure to put on it.

"Banning's estimate," she said. "Seven to fourteen people, with hide ropes and a prepared track — timber sleepers, lubricated, a downhill run from the limestone bench to the enclosure — can move a finished pillar in the eight-to-ten-tonne range. It is hard. It is dangerous. It will hurt people who do it wrong. It is *not* impossible, and it does not require a workforce that hunter-gatherers couldn't field, and it does not require anyone who wasn't from here."

"And the carving?"

"The carving's the part nobody wants to talk about, because the carving is the part that's actually hard."

She'd thought, when she started on the plain, that the lifting would be the wall. Eight tonnes of limestone, no wheel, no pulley you could prove, no draught animal anyone had domesticated yet — surely *that* was the gap you fell into and never climbed out of, the gap where the woo crept in on its soft feet. And it wasn't. The lifting was an engineering problem with an engineering answer and a margin for error measured in broken fingers. Ropes and ramps and patience and the long terrible arithmetic of leverage.

It was the *finish* that opened under her.

Because the pillar wasn't a slab. The pillar was a person. The relief arms came down the sides in shallow, controlled planes, the elbows bending, the forearms turning across the front of the stone to a belt,

and over the belt the hands — and the hands had fingers, individual, stylised but counted, four and a thumb, laid against the belly the way a man stands with his hands folded when he is waiting for something. Pillar 18 wore a fox-pelt at his waist and held a fox in the crook of his arm, and somebody had cut all of that out of standing limestone with stone tools, by eye, at a scale of five and a half metres, *and got it right*. Symmetrical. Confident. No false starts in the rock that anyone had ever found.

That was the potato. Not *could they*. They did; the stone's still there; you can drive to it. The potato was the silence behind the doing — the first time, the no-one-had-done-this-before time, the day somebody looked at a hillside of unworked limestone and *saw a man in it* and then went and got the others and said *help me get him out*.

"Try it," Frik said, deadpan. "That's the move. The Why Files move. *You* go cut a five-metre man out of a hill with a rock. Daylight, plan, the smartest okes you've got. Roll the tape."

"I'd take an angle grinder."

"They had a *deer antler*."

"That's why it's the potato," Naila said. "Modern kit, daylight, a plan — and you still couldn't make it look easy. The gap between what we'd plan and what they did is the whole thing. The gap *is* the thing."

Frik went very still, the way he did right before, and she knew it was coming a half-second before his body said it for him, the truth jumping the queue past every gate he had —

"They were *better at it than we'd be*."

He looked almost annoyed at himself. He pressed the pencil flat under his palm.

"Sorry. That's — *fok*. That's the true one, though. Hey. That's the one nobody's allowed to say. We do the documentary voice, *primitive, early*, and they'd carve you under the table. They'd carve *us* under the table."

"Put it in the report," Eylül said, from the end of the long table, not looking up.

They all looked at her.

“Not like that,” she said. “In the discipline’s words. But — yes. There’s a line in there already about the level of craft ‘indicating long-developed skill traditions.’ That’s the same thing. That’s Frik’s thing in a tie.” She did look up then, and there was the dry flat thing she did with her mouth that was the closest she came to letting them see she was pleased. “You can leave a true thing in. You just have to dress it so the Directorate doesn’t get nervous.”

Naila left the water system in.

She fought for it harder than anything, because it was the part that broke the old story and the new story both, and broke them in the right direction, and she was not going to let it be soft.

For years the line had been the clean one, the quotable one: *a temple of nomads, nobody lived here*. It made a nice slide. Hunter-gatherers walking in from the four winds to worship at a place too holy to sleep in. Schmidt himself had carried it for a long time, and Schmidt had earned the right to be wrong honestly, which was a thing you almost never got to say about a man.

But the newer work had found the rest of it. Domestic buildings. The grinding stones and the worn querns of people processing cereal — wild cereal, not farmed, not yet, but *gathered and ground in volume*, which was its own quiet bombshell. And the channels and the cut basins of a system for catching and holding water on a hill that had none.

People had *lived* here. Or near enough to here, around the monumental enclosures, in numbers, and they had organised water, and they had ground grain, and the picture was not nomads-blowing-through-to-pray. The picture was something thicker and stranger and more human: a gathering that *stayed*.

“That’s the one they’ll cut,” Mara said quietly. “The Trust. If they get a hand on the file. That’s the exact paragraph.”

“Why that one.” Frik.

“Because ‘nobody lived here’ is the whole sale.” Mara turned a print, set it down. “It’s the line in their film. I’ve watched the film.” She had; they all had, the glossy thing the Anatolia Heritage Trust had cut,

twelve minutes of drone-swoop and a low cello and a narrator with a transatlantic non-accent saying *lost* and *unexplained* and *vanished* over slow push-ins on the vulture's wing. "If the site's a solved riddle, a gathering-place, a thing the people who made it walked away from and forgot — then there's nothing left to *protect*, is there. Nothing to lose by letting a foundation tidy it up and quietly sell the provenance off the ninety percent nobody's dug. You don't guard an empty house."

"And the water system," Eylül said, "is the house not being empty."

"It's the house not being empty," Mara said.

Naila wrote a margin note in pencil, neat, small. *Keep §4.3 intact — load-bearing, not for the wonder, for the protection.* The two were the same thing, in the end, on this hill. The honest astonishment and the legal shield were the same paragraph. You protected the place by refusing to make it a riddle. You kept it real, and real was harder to steal than mystery, because mystery belonged to whoever told it loudest and real belonged to the ground.

Through the high window the light had gone the colour of weak tea. Out past the museum's lot, somewhere, the drone would be putting up its evening run over the dig — it had legal cover, *page eleven*, nobody had managed to ground it — flying its patient grid over the ninety percent, photographing what it couldn't have. Mara had stopped trying to photograph the drone. There was a kind of peace in that, in not making a picture of your enemy's picture-making, in just letting it whine across the sky and get nothing that mattered. The hill kept its ninety percent. The drone kept its noise.

The contested part they left contested, which had cost an argument too.

Frik wanted it decided. Frik wanted, with his whole body, for the fill in the enclosures to *mean* one thing — that the people who built the place had buried it, deliberately, with their own hands, an entire temple put to bed under tonnes of rubble and gravel and shaped intent, the most extraordinary act of letting-go in the human record. He wanted that to be true so badly that twice his body said it for him before his mouth got a vote, *they buried it, they buried it on*

purpose, and twice he'd had to sit with the fact that his wanting wasn't evidence.

Because the other reading was there in the section drawings too, and it was not stupid. The post-2014 work, the geomorphology, the slope and the sediment: a hill like this *sheds*. Rain and gravity over centuries fill a sunken room with the hillside above it whether anyone wills it or not. Landslide. Slope-wash. Time and weather doing what time and weather do, no ritual required, no grand renunciation, just a hole on a slope going quietly back to slope.

"You don't get to pick," Eylül said. She wasn't unkind about it. "Neither of them. Not yet. Maybe not ever. The drawings don't say. The dates don't say."

"It's *better* if they buried it," Frik said, low, the want naked on him.

"It's a better *story*." She let that sit. "That's the thing to be careful of, *abi*. When the story's better, check your hand."

So the report said both. §5: *Depositional History — competing interpretations*. Schmidt's intentional backfill, cited, respected. The slope-wash reading, cited, respected. And then the sentence Eylül had written herself and would not let Naila tidy: *The present evidence does not permit resolution*. Which was the most disciplined thing in forty-one pages and the most generous, because it left the door open and refused to lie about what was behind it.

Naila loved that sentence almost as much as the carbon table. It was a true thing dressed in a tie. It was the whole method in a row of words: here is what we know, here is exactly the size of what we don't, and we are not going to make the second one smaller to make ourselves feel braver.

They stayed too late. The museum man came twice to lean in the door and the second time Eylül said something to him in Turkish that made him laugh and leave them another hour.

The measure went in last, and it went in smallest, and that was Naila's choice and she stood by it.

She had it on its own half-page. The unit. The repeated module — a length, give or take the error you'd expect from stone tools and

eleven thousand years of weather — that turned up in the pillar spacings here, and then turned up again at Karahan Tepe, in the spacing there, and that she'd been almost sure she'd seen the start of in the published plans of two more of the Taş Tepeler, the Stone Hills, the whole scatter of them across this plain where only the tenth had been touched and the rest lay under grass with their dead men standing in the dark.

A shared measure. A unit a builder here and a builder forty kilometres away both seemed to have known.

And she had written exactly one interpretive sentence under it, and crossed out four others first.

"Read it," Frik said. He'd gone quiet. He knew this was the one that scared her, the one the woo would grab with both hands if she let her grip slip even once.

" 'The recurrence of a comparable dimensional module across multiple Taş Tepeler sites is consistent with a shared cultural building tradition, including transmitted knowledge of measure between contemporaneous communities.' "

"That's it?"

"That's it. That's all it says."

"It wants to say more," Frik said softly. "I can feel it wanting to say more. *You* want it to say more."

"I do." She didn't pretend. That was the only way to handle the thing that wanted to say more: you admitted it was in you, you looked it in the face, and then you wrote the small true sentence anyway. "I want to say it's *too* clean. I want to say a unit doesn't usually travel that far that early. I want to ask who carries a measure across a plain before writing, and how, and *why it's the same one*. I want to put a question mark on this hill so big you could see it from space."

"So why don't you."

"Because the second I write the big question, somebody films it with a cello," Naila said, "and tells everyone an angel did it. And the measure's real, Frik. It's a real residue. I'm not handing a real thing over to a fairy tale because I couldn't keep my voice down."

Eylül was watching her across the box of prints with an expression Naila didn't have the file on yet, eleven days of data and she still couldn't always read this one woman, which she'd come to think was the truest thing the plain had taught her.

"You leave the maybe in," Eylül said. "And you don't tell anyone what it's a maybe of. That's exactly right. That's how you carry it without dropping it." A pause. "We'll be here a long time, finding out what it is. Long after you're down the road."

Naila looked at the half-page with its one careful sentence and its one buried question, and she thought: *that's the door I'm leaving open*. Not a riddle. Not a hook for a believer or a sneer for a debunker, the two of them the same half-blind coin spun by the same hand. A real hole, the right size, the door left honestly ajar so that the next person to walk up this plain could feel the draught coming off it and have the decency to say *I don't know*.

She didn't write *though she didn't know it yet*. She didn't know it yet. That was the point.

They walked out into the lot near midnight, the four of them, the heat finally off the day, the diesel and dust of Şanlıurfa gone cool and almost sweet. The report was signed. The prints were boxed and lodged. Eylül had the keys and the future and the ground; the report had been a thing the foreigners helped carry, and now they were handing it back to the place it belonged to, which was the only way any of it had ever been worth doing.

Out at the far edge of the lot, past the last of the museum's lights, a figure stood by the wall with his back to all of it, watching the dark where the plain began. The shades were folded in his collar at this hour; the always-clean hanky showed white at his cuff. He'd been waiting. He was always waiting, out at the edge, between them and whatever came across the dark, and no camera the Trust had flown and no frame Mara had ever lifted had got a clean square look at him, and Naila had stopped finding that strange too.

Eylül said something to him in the courtesy handful of Kurdish he'd learned, and he answered with the one word he had right, *spas*, and tipped his head, and didn't come any closer, and didn't take the mo-

ment. He gave it to Eylül. He always gave it to Eylül.

“The People with the arms,” Frik said, into the cool dark, not asking, just laying it down. They’d had Eylül’s telling under the awning the day before — what the carvings were *for*, the gathering and the standing-with-the-dead, the watching ancestors raised in stone so the living had something to come back to and stay near, the act of building-it-together maybe the very thing that made the builders settle and sow and become the people who became us. Her telling. Hers to give. It had made the wonder bigger and Naila had not slept for it.

“Hers,” Naila said. “It’s hers.”

“Ja.” Frik’s hand went to his jaw and away. “Lekker.”

Mara had the camera over her shoulder, capped, asleep. She wasn’t reaching for it. The light was perfect for a frame she would not be taking, the whole crew dark against the museum glow, the man at the wall and the plain beyond, the kind of shot that would have made her name back when making her name was a thing she did to people. She let it go. The draught off the open door was enough. You didn’t have to photograph everything to have stood in it.

Out beyond the wall, somewhere over the dark grass, nine more hills lay under the stars with their measure in them, only the tenth one read.

“Where’s the next one,” Frik said.

Nobody answered him yet. The Beast sat ticking as it cooled, packed and pointed at the road, and the road went out past the edge of the light to the next hole, the way it always did, the way it always would.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor